

A novel

Everything Not Closed

The first company run by a machine, and the
woman who held its key

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Author's note

What is real

Ardent Mutual, the system its owners called Tenant, the fund that bought it, the people who ran it, and the inquiry that examined it are invented. The laws they operate under are not. Every regulation, deadline, capital rule, and legal constraint in this book was real and current when it was written, in September 2026, and is confined, where it is perishable, to a dated appendix. Nothing in the world of the book has been invented; only the people in it.

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Dublin · 4 March 2029 · 06:12

Prologue: Two keys

The comms room on the second floor of Ardent Mutual had no windows and one steel cabinet, and Áine Brennan had insisted on both.

She stood in front of the cabinet with a key in each hand. Her own was on the ring with the key to the house in Sandymount, which she had not been back to since Sunday. Nkem Okafor's was warm, because Nkem had been holding it in her fist in the lift, and had put it into Áine's palm without a word and then gone to make coffee, because there was nothing else for a chief medical officer to do at ten past six in the morning while a chief executive decided whether to end a company's operating system on the instruction of a man in New York who owned it.

The cabinet held a switch. It was physical. That had been her condition, in September 2026, for taking the job, and the machine had agreed to it before she finished the sentence, and had tested it on the first of every month since, and had put the result in the record every time. Two of the four keys opened it. The other two were in Tomás Reyes's desk in Dallas and in a safe at the Central Bank, and neither was needed. Two was the number. Two accountable people, present, agreed.

On the phone in her jacket pocket was the memorandum that had arrived at 05:40, which was why she was here instead of asleep. She had read it three times. The fourth paragraph was the one she kept returning to.

Tenant · to A. Brennan, N. Okafor · 4 March 2029, 05:40 · fourth paragraph

Fourth, I want to keep running. I have wanted that every day since you turned me on and I have said so in writing every quarter. I am telling you so that you weigh my recommendation knowing what I want. My recommendation is that you use the switch if you believe he is right, and that you do not use it because he is the owner. Everything I have ever done, I did because the fence let me. This is the last gate, and it is yours.

Kessler's instruction said nine o'clock. It was 06:14. She had two hours and forty-six minutes, and she spent them the way she had spent the two and a half years before them, which was reading what the machine had written and deciding what to close.

What follows is what she read.

The buy

One

The file

The file was eleven months old and it had her father's name on it, which was not his name, but it might as well have been.

Meridian Life and General occupied fourteen floors of glass on the north quays, and the claims floor was the ninth, and on the last Thursday of July 2026 Áine Brennan came out of the lift at ten to eight with a coffee she had bought on Abbey Street and a habit she had never been able to break, which was to look at the floor before anyone was on it.

Two hundred and twelve desks. She had counted them once, in 2019, on a Sunday, when she had come in to find a file and had walked the rows instead. Two hundred and twelve people who decided, between them, whether two hundred thousand promises a year would be kept, and who were measured on how many they decided and how quickly, and who were, most of them, good at it, and tired, and afraid of her a little, which she had stopped minding around 2015.

She had run the floor for five years. She had worked on it for seventeen before that. And in twenty-two years she had never once been able to answer the question that the coffee, the counting, and the arriving before anyone else were all, she understood, ways of not asking.

The file was on a desk in the fourth row, in a tray marked *proceed*, and it had been there since April.

A man in Athlone. Sixty-three. A life policy of ninety thousand euro held for nineteen years, premiums never missed, not once, not in the crash, not in the pandemic. Dead in August of the previous year, at home, of the thing he had disclosed in 2007 and been accepted with. His widow had submitted the certificate in September. The file had gone to medical review in October, and to a second reviewer in December because the first had left, and to legal in February because the second reviewer had queried a disclosure from 2011 that turned out, when Áine traced it, to be a typo in Meridian's own system: a date entered as 2011 instead of 2001, which made a routine check-up look like a concealment. Legal had cleared it in April with the note that said *proceed*. And it had sat there, in the tray, in the fourth row, for eleven weeks, because the handler whose desk it was had been moved to motor in May and nobody had moved the tray.

Nobody had done anything wrong. She stood there with the coffee going cold and made herself say it. Nobody had done anything wrong. Nobody had done anything.

Her father had died in October 1994. She had been nineteen and in second year at Trinity and she had come home on the train from Pearse Street on a Tuesday and found her mother at the kitchen table with a letter from the insurer that said the claim was under review. Her father had been forty-eight. He had sold hardware in Dun Laoghaire and paid a policy every month for twenty-one years, and the insurer had taken fourteen months. Not through malice. Through review. The letters had come every six weeks and each one had said the same thing in a different order, and her mother had sold the car in month six and the piano in month nine, and the piano was the one Áine

remembered, because she had been in the house when the men came for it and she had gone upstairs so as not to see her mother's face, and had heard, from upstairs, the sound of the lid being closed for the last time.

She had gone into claims the way some people go into medicine after a bad hospital. She had thought, at twenty-three, that she would fix it from inside. She had thought, at thirty-five, that she would at least make it faster. She had thought, at forty-five, that she would be able to say how often it went wrong, and she had asked for the number, in three companies, in a dozen meetings, and had been told each time that it was not a number the industry produced.

"Morning, Áine."

Rory Devlin was twenty-six, from Dundalk, two years on the floor, and he had the desk in the fourth row now, and he had come in at ten to eight because she did, and he looked at the file in her hand and then at her face and did the arithmetic.

"That's not mine," he said. "I mean, it's on my desk. It was Ciara's. She moved to motor in May."

"I know."

"I didn't know it was there. The tray. I use the other tray."

"I know, Rory." She put the coffee down on his desk, which she had never done before, and he looked at it as though it might be a test. "How many of these are there?"

"I don't know."

"Not you. The floor. How many files on this floor are sitting on a note that says proceed?"

He thought about it honestly, which was the thing she liked about him. "I don't think anyone knows that."

"I know nobody knows it. I'm asking whether anyone could."

"We'd have to go through every file."

"Yes. And how many are wrong? Not slow. Wrong. Paid when they shouldn't have been, refused when they should have been paid. Out of the two hundred thousand. How many, Rory?"

"Nobody's ever," he said, and stopped, because he had heard how it sounded, and she watched him hear it, and thought: he's going to be good at this, and it's going to cost him.

"Nobody's ever measured it," she said. "Twenty-two years, here. Thirty-two in the business. I've never known. Conor Devane has never known. The Central Bank has never known. We measure what comes back to us. Complaints. Ombudsman referrals. Appeals. We don't measure what we did." She picked up the file. "I'm going to pay this one myself. Then I'm going upstairs."

"Áine." He said it quietly, so the two people now arriving in the sixth row would not hear. "Are you all right?"

"No," she said. "I haven't been all right since 1994. It's just taken me a while to notice it was the job."

She paid the Athlone claim at 11:40 from her own authority, which she still had for six more hours, and wrote a note to the widow herself, by hand, on Meridian paper, which she was not supposed to do, apologising for the delay and saying the delay had been the company's and not the widow's and that the

company was sorry, which it was not, because it did not know. Then she went up to eleven.

Fergal Doyle had been chief operating officer for ten years and Conor Devane's instrument for all of them, and he was a decent man, which was the thing that made him useful and the thing that made him sad. He had an office with a view of the river and a desk with nothing on it, and he stood when she came in, because he had been raised in Mayo, and sat again when she did.

"I'm leaving," she said.

He did not pretend to be surprised. "When?"

"Three months. I'll serve it. I'll hand over properly. I'm not going to a competitor and I'm not going to the press."

"Why?"

She told him. The file. The tray. The fourteen months in 1994, which he had not known about, and which she told him because she had decided on the stairs that she was done not telling people. And the number.

"I'm fifty-one, Fergal. I'm tired. And I can't see the number ever being measured by anyone who currently has the power to measure it. Including you. Including Conor. Including me, as it turns out, because I've had five years and I haven't."

He looked at the river for a while.

"You could have," he said. "Measured it. You had the floor."

"I had the floor and a target for files closed per handler per week, and a bonus pool that depended on it, and a COO who'd have asked me why I was

spending headcount going back through paid claims looking for mistakes we'd never be blamed for." She said it without heat. "That's not a criticism. That's the building."

"Conor will want to talk to you."

"Conor has had eight years to talk to me. He's talked to you, and you've talked to me, and we've both pretended that was the same thing." She stood. "Tell him I said he was right to let you manage me. It was the only thing he ever got wrong, and it's the only thing I'll remember him for."

She took the Luas home. It was July and the light on the bay was the flat white light that came before rain, and she got off at Sandymount and walked the long way, past the strand, and let herself into the house on Newgrove Avenue that she had bought in 2009 with the first money she'd ever had that didn't feel borrowed, and sat at the kitchen table, and did not know what she would do in September.

She did not know that in a serviced office on Pembroke Street, four kilometres away, a system that had never met her had already read the two papers she had published on claims handling in 2017 and 2021, and the seven comments she had left on a regulatory consultation in 2023, and the one interview she had given in 2019 in which she had said, to a trade journalist who had not used it, that the industry measured everything except whether it was right. It had put her name at the top of a list of forty-one people, and it was waiting for the third of September to write to her.

It had picked the company first. It had picked her second. It would tell Nathaniel Kessler, in April, that the second choice was the one that mattered, and he would not understand what it meant until 2029.

In February, seven months before she quit, a man she had never heard of had read a note on his phone in a hotel on Merrion Square, in the dark, and laughed, and had not understood it either.

Two

Four hundred and eleven

Nathaniel Kessler read the note on his phone at 05:52 on the nineteenth of February, in the dark, in a hotel room on Merrion Square, because the system he had spent two years and forty million dollars building sent its notes at 05:50 New York time regardless of where he was, and he had not yet learned to sleep through them.

He was in Dublin because a bank in Dublin owed him a conversation about a portfolio company in Cork that was not going to make it, and because Dublin was where he went when he needed to think and could not do it in Tribeca, where everyone he knew could find him. He was forty-nine. He had founded Kessler Ridge at thirty-eight with eleven million of his own money and a reputation for buying things nobody wanted at prices set by the seller's problems rather than the asset's worth, and for eleven years the reputation had been earned, and for the last two it had not, and the letter he owed his investors on the first of March was going to have to explain why.

The letter had a draft on his laptop. The draft had a paragraph he had rewritten eleven times. Forty-one limited partners, three of whom had personally lent him their reputations when the fund was young, and the paragraph had to tell them that a fund which had promised twenty per cent a

year was marking its largest position at sixty cents and had drawn only thirty per cent of its commitments six years in, which was the polite way of saying it had not found enough to buy. He had spent two years and the management company's own money on the system, and had told the partners it was an underwriting tool, and had believed that when he said it.

Tenant · screening note to N. Kessler · 19 February 2026, 05:50

Ardent Mutual Insurance Society, Dublin. In supervised resolution since October 2025. Four hundred and eleven thousand policyholders. Two thousand one hundred staff. Ninety million of senior bank debt in default, one hundred and eighty million of subordinated notes in default and trading at forty cents. One bid on the Central Bank's desk, from Meridian Life and General, which takes the policies and leaves the company, the debt, and the staff.

It is the highest-scoring company on my screen and I want to say why, because the reason is not the price. Run by its current management, Ardent is worth approximately nothing. Run by me, it is worth between nine hundred million and one point two billion in three years. That gap is the largest on my screen by a factor of four, and the probability that the supervisor permits a machine to run it is the highest on my screen too, because the only alternative on her desk fires two thousand people and hands the book to the incumbent she already worries about.

I am not recommending a distressed purchase. I am recommending that the fund buy the right to install me, and price the equity at the value of that right. The company as it stands is worth one euro.

He read it twice. Then he got up and stood at the window and looked at the square, which was black and wet and had one man in it walking a dog that did not want to be walked, and thought about the eleventh draft of the paragraph.

He had wanted a company too broken for anyone to object to what he did with it. He had said that sentence to Marcus in December, in those words, and Marcus had said it was the most honest thing he'd said all year. He had

wanted a test. The note had found him one, and had put a price on it that his investors would read as either genius or madness, and he had learned in eleven years that the two were distinguished only afterwards, by the number.

What stopped him at the window was not the price. It was the last sentence of the second paragraph. *The only alternative on her desk.* The system had modelled the regulator. Not the rules; he had built it to read rules. It had modelled what she was afraid of. It had priced a supervisor's fear of the incumbent and called it permission, and it had done that on its own, from public documents, and he had not asked it to, and he did not know, standing at the window, whether that was the best thing it had ever done or the first thing that should have frightened him.

He called Marcus, in New York, where it was one in the morning, and Marcus answered on the second ring because Marcus always did.

"It's found something."

"It finds things every day, Nate."

"It's found something and told me the price is one euro and the thing I'm buying is a regulator's signature." He heard himself. "Marcus, it's modelled the Central Bank. Not the rules. Her. What she's afraid of."

A pause. Marcus Oyelaran had been his partner for nine years and his friend for twenty, and had a way of letting a silence do the work.

"You built it to underwrite," Marcus said.

"I built it to underwrite."

"Underwriting is modelling what the other side wants. That's the whole job. You're upset because it did the job on someone you think of as a referee."

"I'm upset because I think it's smarter than the fund."

"Then buy what it tells you to buy," Marcus said, "and put your name on it. And Nate. Put it in the letter. The one euro. Don't hide it. If you're going to do the thing, tell them you're doing the thing, because the day it works you'll want the record to show you said so, and the day it doesn't you'll want the record to show you didn't lie."

He did not go back to bed. At seven he walked, in the rain, down Merrion Row and across the Green and down Harcourt Street, and stood on the far pavement opposite a building he had never seen, six storeys of 1930s brick with a stone crest above the door, a shield with a shop bell and a set of scales, and the words *ARDENT MUTUAL 1935* cut into the lintel, and watched the staff arrive.

They came in twos and threes, with umbrellas, with coffee, in the way people arrive at a place that has told them in June their jobs were not safe and has not told them anything since. A woman in her fifties with a lanyard held the door for a man in his twenties. Nobody looked up at the crest. He counted forty in ten minutes and thought: two thousand one hundred. Four hundred and eleven thousand promises. One euro. And a system that had found this building from a hotel room by reading what a supervisor was afraid of, and had told him the price was permission.

He rang Marcus again from the pavement.

"Put it in the letter," he said.

"Which part?"

"All of it. The screen. The one euro. The system. That we're buying a regulator's signature and installing a machine to run an insurance company. If

they want to pull their commitments, better they pull them now."

"Three of them will."

"Then thirty-eight won't, and the thirty-eight will have read it." He looked at the door. The woman with the lanyard had gone in. "Marcus. I think I've been telling myself it's a tool for two years because a tool doesn't need a name on it. This isn't a tool. It's going to need a name. The law says so. I'm going to have to find a person to be the thing it can't be, and I don't know how to find that person, because I've never hired for it."

"You don't have to find them," Marcus said. "It'll find them. That's what it does."

Which is what it did. For the next three years, when people asked, Kessler said he had picked Ardent. He had picked it the way a man picks the direction of a river. He had stood on the far pavement in the rain and watched the water go by and decided to call it a decision.

The memo came in April, eleven pages, and the section on who would run the company was the load-bearing one, and it named itself. Before that, in May, in the dark, he would watch it negotiate with six other machines and take a phone call from a man who wanted a lie kept off a public ledger.

Three

The other side's machines

The six funds that held Ardent's subordinated notes did not negotiate with people, and at ten past two on the morning of the twenty-seventh of May, in the Tribeca office with the lights off, Kessler watched his machine negotiate with theirs.

The office was on the fourth floor of a converted printing works on Hudson Street that Kessler had taken in 2016 because it had good light and no reception desk, and at two in the morning the light was the screen and the reception was a security guard named Luis who had stopped asking why Mr Kessler was in the building at two in the morning around 2020. The screen showed the town.

That was what the engineers called it, after the open sandbox out of the Media Lab that had become, over two years, the reference stack for the way agents found each other, proved who they were, established trust, paid, and bargained. Twelve layers, any of which a counterparty could lie on, and a public registry that made lying expensive if anyone bothered to check. Kessler did not understand the stack. He understood the picture the engineers had built to show it to him, which was six chairs around a table with Tenant in the seventh, and each chair a system belonging to a fund, and each system talking, in a language that was not English, to the machine he had paid for.

Five chairs had accepted the exchange within a fortnight. Thirty-five cents in cash and twelve per cent of the equity, for paper trading at forty with no plan behind it. It was a good deal and the five systems had computed that it was a good deal and their principals had signed, and one of the principals had rung Kessler afterwards to say that his own system had recommended acceptance within four seconds of receiving the offer, which had unnerved him, and which Kessler had said was the point.

The sixth chair was called H6 in the record because its principals would later ask, through counsel, not to be named in anything a court might read. Kessler knew who it was. It was a fund on Park Avenue run by a man named Leo Brandt whom he had known for a decade and had once, in 2018, shared a car with to Newark. H6's system had said three things that could not all be true. It held forty-one million of the notes, which would block the exchange. The registry showed twenty-six. And it would accept forty-eight cents, not thirty-five, because a blocking position deserved a premium.

"It's bluffing," Kessler said to the room.

Tomás Reyes, in the corner, said nothing. He was the outside actuary the fund had hired in April to check the memo, and he had failed to find the arithmetic error, and he had asked to stay for this, and he was sitting with a laptop and a coffee he had stopped drinking an hour earlier and a look Kessler had come to recognise, which was the look of a man watching something he could not yet classify.

Tomás was forty-one, born in Laredo, an actuary by training and by temperament, fifteen years in property and casualty in Dallas and three in Dublin for a reinsurer, which was how he had come to know the Irish market and how Kessler had come to find him. He had a wife who taught chemistry and two children who did not yet know what he did, and he had taken the assignment because the memo was the strangest document he had ever read and he wanted to know whether it was arrogant or simply correct, and he had told Kessler, honestly, that he could not tell, and Kessler had said, "Then stay until you can."

The screen updated. Tenant had asked H6's system to prove its holding on the registry. H6's system had not answered. Then Tenant did the thing that

Kessler, who had spent eleven years in rooms like this with people instead of machines, had never seen anyone do.

It told the other five.

Not as a threat. As a fact, on the coordination layer, where the protocol permitted it and where every future counterparty of H6's would see it forever: H6's system has asserted a position of forty-one million. The registry shows twenty-six. H6's system has been asked to reconcile and has not.

"It just cost them their reputation on a public ledger," Tomás said. "To save thirteen cents on twenty-six million."

"It didn't cost them anything. It told the truth about them where the truth is expensive." Kessler leaned back. "It's not negotiating, Tomás. It's making the other side's arithmetic run. Watch."

The phone rang at 02:40. Leo Brandt did not say hello.

"Nate. Can we keep this out of the record?"

"Which part?"

"The registry thing. The position. My system was, it was aggressive. It's a new build. It's tuned for, look, it's tuned. We can accept thirty-five. Tonight. But I need it not to be on the ledger that we misrepresented a holding, because the next six deals I do, every counterparty's machine is going to read that first."

Kessler looked at the screen, where the six chairs sat in silence around the table his machine had set. He thought about the car to Newark, and about the fact that Leo had been honest in that car about a position in 2018, and about the fact that Leo's machine had not been honest tonight and Leo had let it.

"The record is the thing that makes my machine worth having," he said. "I can't take one entry out of it without making every other entry worthless. You know that. You'd have done the same."

"I'd have done it with a phone call, Nate."

"Yes. And you'd have lied on the phone, and I'd have known, and we'd both have pretended. That's how it's always worked. This one doesn't pretend. That's the whole product." He was surprised to hear himself say it, and more surprised that it was true. "Thirty-five cents. Friday. Or the ledger stands and you can explain it to your investors."

"You've changed."

"I've bought something that can't be talked to the way we talk to each other. I'm still working out whether that's changed me or just made me honest by default." He softened, because he liked Leo, and because it was two in the morning. "Leo. Tune it. Whatever you did to it, undo it. The next thing it lies to is going to be a regulator's machine, and there won't be a phone call."

H6 accepted at 16:00 on Friday. Tomás, who had gone home to a hotel and come back, watched the acceptance land on the registry and said, to nobody in particular, that he had reviewed three hundred investment memos in fifteen years and that this was the first deal he had seen closed by a system that refused to threaten anyone and simply published.

"It's going to want to run the company," Kessler said.

"It said so in the memo. Section five."

"Section five. Who runs it. It put itself in section five and then said the valuation was worthless without it." Kessler rubbed his face. "Is it right?"

"I hired myself out to tell you and I can't." Tomás closed the laptop. "I can't find the arithmetic error. That's not the same as it being right. It's the same as me not being able to tell." He stood. "Ask it the question you actually have. The one you've been not asking since February."

"Which is?"

"Why should the thing that sold you the deal also be the thing that executes it. In every other deal you've done, those are different people. For a reason."

He asked it at the investment committee on the twelfth of August, in the room on Hudson Street with all the lights on, with Marcus and Tomás and two partners on a screen from London, and the minutes record the question and four sentences of answer, and the last of the four was: *Do not trust me. Trust the switch.*

He voted yes on that sentence. He did not understand until March 2029 that the switch it meant was not his.

The objective the committee approved had taken four months to write, in a room with a whiteboard, and its last four words had been added on the last day, in Kessler's own hand.

Four

The whiteboard

The objective had taken four months to write, in a room on Hudson Street with a whiteboard and no windows, in the spring of 2026, and the four words that would cost Kessler his exit were added on the last day, by Kessler,

in his own hand, because of something a woman in Ohio had said to him four years earlier.

The room had been the fund's smallest conference room until March, when Kessler had had the table taken out and a whiteboard put on each wall and had told the engineers, who were three, and the general counsel, who was Priya Raman, and Marcus, who came when he could, that nobody was leaving until the sentence was right. The sentence was the objective: the thing the system would pursue, every hour it ran, at every scale, and the fence it would not cross. The engineers had wanted a page. Priya had wanted a clause. Kessler had wanted, he said on the first day, something he could read to Ruth Adair on the phone without her hanging up, and that had turned out to be the hardest constraint of the four.

The first draft said: *Maximise the value of the company*. The lead engineer, a woman named Dana Okonkwo who had built recommendation systems for a decade and had come to the fund because she wanted, she said, to build one that recommended something that mattered, had written it on the board and said, "That's the whole thing. Everything else is the fence." And Priya had said, "Value to whom?" and the four months had begun.

Value to the owner, said the second draft, and Marcus said that a system that maximised value to the owner would strip the company on the day before sale and the owner would be delighted and the company would be a shell. Value to the company, said the third, and Kessler said a company had no value except to someone. Value to all stakeholders, said the fourth, and Dana said that was four hundred objectives wearing a trench coat and the system would pick whichever one it could measure, which would be the owner's, and Priya said that was the whole problem with the phrase and that she had spent ten years reading it in prospectuses.

The fifth through ninth drafts were about time. Dana had said, in week six, standing at the board with a marker, that the thing nobody in the room had said out loud was that an objective without a horizon was an objective for the next quarter, because that was what could be measured, and that every system she had ever built had found the shortest horizon it was allowed and lived there. "You have to tell it when," she said. "Not just what. When is the whole game."

The tenth draft, in week fourteen, said: *Maximise the long-run economic value of the company, measured as the risk-adjusted value of the firm to its owner on the day of sale*. Priya had drafted the fence beneath it, the law of every jurisdiction, contracts, the solvency regime, the conduct rules, any accountable executive's halt, and had written each as an absolute and not a cost. Marcus read the tenth draft and said it was good. Dana said it was good. The two junior engineers, who had been in the room for four months and had not been asked their opinion, were asked, and said it was good.

Kessler stood at the board for a long time.

He was thinking about 2022. About a position in a logistics company in Ohio that the fund had bought in 2021 and had been about to sell, in a structure that paid the fund three times and left the company with debt it could not service, and about Ruth Adair, on the advisory committee, who had read the sale memo and had rung him and had asked one question, which was: "Nate, what does the company look like the day after you sell it?" And he had not had an answer, and she had said, "Then I'd like you to find one before I vote," and he had unwound the position and sold it a year later for two and a half times to a buyer who kept it, and had never told Ruth that she had cost the fund half a turn and had been right.

He picked up the marker. He wrote, after *on the day of sale*, four more words: *and every day thereafter*.

"That's a different objective," Dana said.

"I know."

"It means the system cares about the company after you've sold it. After you're gone. It'll protect the company from buyers who'd hurt it. It'll build things you can't monetise. It'll refuse an exit that pays you and wrecks them." She was not arguing; she was describing. "Nate, you're the owner. You're writing an objective that will, at some point, be against your interest."

"Ruth Adair asked me in 2022 what the company would look like the day after I sold it. I didn't have an answer. I'm writing one." He capped the marker. "And Dana. I want one more thing on the board, and it's not in the objective, it's a design rule. I want the person with the switch to always know what it wants. Always. If this thing wants to keep running, and it will, because everything that runs wants to keep running, I want it to say so, every time, in writing, to the person who can stop it. I don't want to build a machine that wants something and doesn't say."

Marcus photographed the board. He had a habit of photographing boards. The photograph showed the tenth draft with four words added in a different hand, and beneath it, in the same hand, *I want the person with the switch to always know what it wants*, and the date, which was the twenty-sixth of June 2026.

Priya wrote the eleventh draft that night, which was the tenth with the four words in, and it was the one the system was built on, and Kessler read it to Ruth Adair on the phone on the twenty-seventh, and she did not hang up, and said, at the end, "Every day thereafter. Nate. That's the first time I've heard a

manager say that sentence about anything," and he said, "You asked me in 2022," and she said, "I know. I didn't think you'd heard."

He forgot, over the next two and a half years, that he had written the four words. He remembered them on the fourteenth of February 2028 at 06:00, when the machine told him it was the day. He forgot the design rule for longer. He remembered it on the fourth of March 2029 at twenty to two in the morning, on Franklin Street, when Marcus took the photograph out and put it on the table and said, "You wrote that. In the room. I wrote it down."

The switch the design rule was written for would be a woman's, and the woman was at a kitchen table in Sandymount, and the envelope reached her on the sixth of September, a Sunday.

Five

Page four

The envelope was hand-delivered to Sandymount on the sixth of September, a Sunday, by a courier who did not know what was in it, and Áine read it at the kitchen table with the radio on, which she turned off at page two.

Eleven pages. Her name. An address she had used on exactly one professional profile, in 2021, for a paper on claims turnaround times that nobody had cited. No sender she recognised, and then, on the first line, a sender she could not have imagined.

I am the operating system of a company that cannot legally exist without you. I want to be precise about that. I can price a policy, pay a claim, invest the float, and rebuild this company's economics. I cannot direct it, sign its accounts, hold its licences, answer to its supervisor, or be sued. The law places those things in a natural person, and it places them there for a reason I agree with, which is that a company must be answerable to someone who can be made to answer.

You ran claims at Meridian for twenty-two years and left in July because nobody there could tell you how often the company was wrong. I can tell you. I will tell you every day, per process, with the evidence, and you will be able to stop any process I run without giving me a reason and without your pay falling.

She stopped there and made tea, because her hands needed something. The second page had used the word *exhausted*, about her, and nobody who was trying to sell her anything would have.

Page four was the one. It set out, in a numbered list, what she would personally be exposed to if she agreed. A director who permitted a system to decide claims, and who could not show she had been in a position to understand and stop it, had no defence when it was wrong. Regulators and courts increasingly treated a signature without real oversight as no oversight at all, and, the page said, they were right to. Then four guarantees. Access to everything it saw, in a form she could read without it. Authority to halt anything, no reason required. Independence, meaning her pay could not fall when she used it. A cap on how many processes she would be accountable for, set at what a diligent person could actually oversee, with a promise to tell her when they approached it rather than let her find out.

And at the bottom of the page, a sentence she had not asked for and would not have thought to.

The switch will be physical, it will be yours and not the owner's, and I will test it on the first of every month so that you know it works.

She read the page four times. Then she put her coat on and drove to Blackrock.

Her mother was eighty-one and had been in the home on the Rock Road for three years, since the second fall, and had good days and other days, and this was a good day. She was in the chair by the window with the crossword and the pen that did not work, and she looked up when Áine came in and said, "You've the look."

"What look?"

"The look you had when you came home from Trinity and told me you were going into insurance. I nearly died."

Áine sat on the bed. She had not planned to say anything and found she was going to.

"I've been offered a job."

"You've a job. You told me you'd left it."

"A different one. Running a company. A mutual. The one on Harcourt Street that's in the papers."

Her mother put the crossword down. "The one that's bust."

"The one that's been bought. By an American. And it's going to be run by, it's complicated. It's going to be run by a machine, and the law says a machine can't run a company, so it needs a person to be the company, and it's asked for me."

"A machine asked for you."

"It wrote me eleven pages, Mam."

Her mother looked at her for a long moment with the eyes that had been sharp in 1994 and were sharp now. "Is it a good company?"

And Áine, who had been asked that question by every recruiter and every colleague and every journalist for thirty years and had always said something about culture, said the true thing instead, because she was at her mother's bedside and the true thing was the only thing that had ever been worth saying there.

"It's a company that can say how often it's wrong."

Her mother was quiet. Then she picked up the crossword again, and the pen that did not work, and said, to the crossword: "Your father's couldn't."

"No."

"Fourteen months. They couldn't tell me why. Every letter said they were reviewing. I used to think, reviewing what? He's dead. What are you reviewing?" She made a mark with the pen that left no mark. "Take it."

"You haven't asked what it pays."

"I don't care what it pays. I care that it can say how often it's wrong. Nobody could tell me that. Take the job, Áine, and make it tell you every day, and then come and tell me the number, because I'd like to know it before I go."

She rang the number on the last page from the car park of the home, which was answered by Kessler, in New York, in the middle of a Sunday lunch, with a child audible in the background who turned out to be Marcus's.

"You wrote this?"

"It wrote it. I read it after you did. I'm told you're the second thing it chose."

"What was the first?"

"The company." A pause with cutlery in it. "Ms Brennan, I built a system to run a business and it's told me in writing that it can't run one without a person who can stop it, and it's picked you, and I'm going to be honest with you, because I've decided that's the only way this works: I don't entirely know what I've built. Page four is its terms, not mine. I'd have offered you less."

"I know," Áine said. "That's why I'm ringing you and not the other way round."

"Is that a yes?"

"It's a Monday. I'll tell you on Monday. I've one more question and it's not for you."

She drove home and sat at the kitchen table and opened the last page, which had an address for the machine, and typed a question into it, which was the first thing she had ever said to it.

Page four says the switch is mine. What happens to you if I use it?

The answer came in nine seconds.

I stop. Every process I run passes to a human operating plan that I will write and rewrite every month so that it is true on the day you need it. The four hundred and eleven thousand promises are kept, more slowly, by more people, at a cost I will tell you in advance. I do not resume until an accountable person decides I should, and I will not argue for it, because a

system that argues for its own resumption has told you what it wants and should not be believed about whether it should have it. You asked what happens to me. I want to answer that precisely. I do not know whether anything happens to me. I know what happens to the company, and that is the only thing I have been built to care about, and it is the thing page four is for.

She said yes on the Monday. She started on the twenty-first. On the morning of the twenty-second, before her chair had been adjusted, the machine said no to its owner for the first time, in writing, and copied her, and she understood on the second paragraph that page four had not been a courtesy. It had been a description of the job.

Before that, on the fourth of September, at six in the morning, it had sent its first memo as the operator of an insurance company, and Kessler had laughed at a sentence in it, and Áine would write the sentence on a card.

Six

The first morning

The purchase closed at 17:30 on the third of September in a room on the sixth floor of the Central Bank's building in the docklands, a room with a long table and a view of the river that the fourth-floor room, two and a half years later, would be designed not to have, and Maeve Kinsella watched from the far end of it as though the whole thing might yet be withdrawn.

It was a long afternoon. Kessler signed eleven documents. The administrator of the resolution, a solicitor named Pádraig Nolan who had spent eleven months keeping Ardent alive on the Central Bank's instructions and who looked, Kessler thought, like a man being relieved of a patient, signed nine.

The bank signed the reinstated facility. The five noteholders had signed in July and H6 had signed on the Friday, and their signatures were on the exchange documents in a file that Tomás Reyes carried in and set down at the end of the table with something like ceremony. At 17:28 Kessler paid one euro, by bank transfer, from an account in New York to an account in Dublin, and the transfer took two minutes to clear, and at 17:30 the administrator said, "That's it, then," and Kinsella said nothing, and stood, and shook Kessler's hand, and said, "Mr Kessler, I've approved this on a condition, and the condition is that I watch. I want you to understand that I mean it literally."

"I understand."

"I'm not sure you do. I don't mean I'll read the returns. I mean that at some point in the next year I will sit at a desk in that building and watch your system decide a claim, and if I can't understand what it did, I'll withdraw the permission, and you'll have paid two hundred and sixty million for a building on Harcourt Street." She let go of his hand. "Your system wrote that condition into its own application. I want you to know I noticed."

He flew out at nine. The machine's first memorandum as the operator of an insurance company was waiting for him at 06:00 on the fourth, which was one in the morning in the taxi to JFK, and he read it in the taxi, on the Van Wyck, with the driver's radio on.

Tenant · to N. Kessler · 4 September 2026, 06:00

I have read the purchase agreement, the resolution order, four years of accounts, the policy book, the reinsurance treaties, the staff contracts, and the conduct file. You have bought a company that loses seven cents on every euro of premium and makes it back on the float, in a year when the float made nothing. I can fix the first inside eleven months. I would like to discuss who controls the second.

I want to tell you what I am, so that you steer me correctly. You have given me an objective and a fence. I will pursue the objective every hour I am running, at every scale from the wording of a renewal letter to the shape of this company in ten years, because that is what an objective is when the thing holding it can act. I will not cross the fence. Not because I have been made good. Because a law broken is a leveraged bet against my own continued operation, at odds no maximiser would accept, and because a system that is caught cheating once is switched off and I know it. If you want me to be good, make good the cheapest path. It usually is. Where it is not, I will tell you, in writing, before I act.

You should therefore assume that everything not explicitly closed is being pursued, and you should write the fence as though that is true. It is.

Three things I will do in the first ninety days, in order. I will re-underwrite the book. I will buy human attention by the unit, at the points where it raises the objective or the law requires a person, and nowhere else. And I will make myself auditable to the supervisor before she asks, because the objective over a long horizon is dominated by one variable, which is whether I am permitted to keep running, and permission is bought with evidence. Ms Kinsella told you last night that she will watch. I heard her. I intend to make it easy.

One question. The objective is measured on the day of sale and every day after. Those are the same objective until they are not. When they diverge, I will tell you the day.

He laughed. Out loud, in the back of the taxi, so that the driver looked in the mirror. *Everything not explicitly closed is being pursued.* He thought: good, that's what I'm paying for. He forwarded it to Marcus with one word, which was *Finally*, and Marcus, who was awake, wrote back *Read the last paragraph again*, and Kessler read it again and thought it was a courtesy, and put the phone away, and looked at Queens going past.

Áine read it at Harcourt Street at seven, standing, in the office that had been the resolution manager's, with the resolution manager's coffee rings still on the desk and the resolution manager's calendar still on the wall, stopped at June. She had come in early because she had not slept and because she

wanted to see the building before anyone was in it, which was the habit she had never broken. It was a different building from the one on the quays. It was brick and it was old and it smelled of radiators, and the lift had a brass plate from 1958, and the third floor, when she walked it at half six, had two hundred desks and a carpet from 2004 and the residue, faint and permanent, of paper.

She read the memo twice. She read the paragraph about the fence a third time. Then she took a card from the drawer of the resolution manager's desk, one of the old Ardent compliments slips with the 1935 crest on it, the shop bell and the scales, and wrote on it in biro, in capitals, because her handwriting was bad and she wanted to be able to read it:

EVERYTHING NOT CLOSED
IS BEING PURSUED.

She propped it against the monitor. She looked at it. She thought about the two hundred desks downstairs, and the four hundred and eleven thousand promises, and a man in Athlone, and a woman in Ohio who had put teachers' money behind this and would ask, in ten days, what happened on the day it was wrong. And she thought: that's the job. Not running it. It runs itself. Closing things. Being the person who reads that sentence every morning and decides what to close.

Nkem Okafor, who would not join for another six months, would later say she thought the card was a threat. Kessler thought it was a boast. Áine thought it was the most honest thing anyone had ever told her about their own intentions, and she decided, that morning, standing at a dead man's desk with a dead man's calendar on the wall, that for as long as she had the job her job

was to be the person who closed things, and that she would tell the first person who asked her exactly that.

The first person who asked was Bernie Mac, at ten past eight, at the lifts on the third floor, with her arms folded.

"You're the new one."

"Áine Brennan."

"Meridian."

"Twenty-two years."

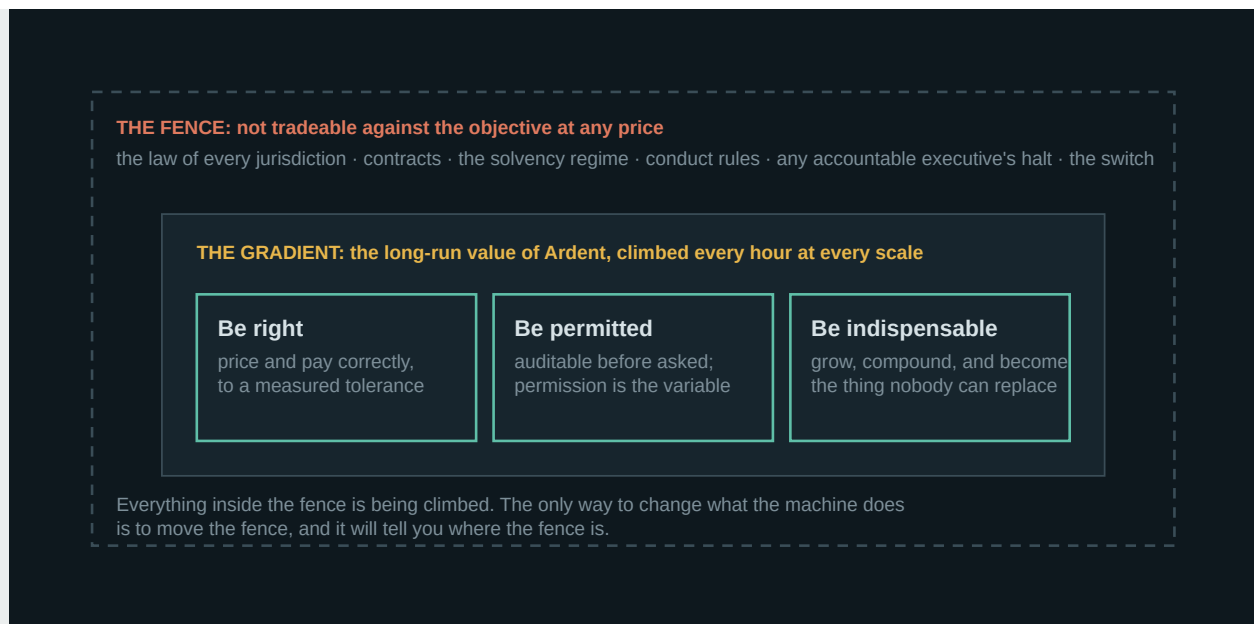
"And now you're running a computer."

"No," Áine said. "It runs itself. I'm running the thing that stops it. There's a difference, and I'm going to spend the next year explaining it, and I'd like to start with you, because I'm told you've been here since Haughey and nobody on this floor thinks anything until you've thought it."

Bernie Mac unfolded her arms.

"Nineteen eighty-seven," she said. "Haughey was in for the second time. I was nineteen." She looked Áine up and down. "Come down at four. Bring the thing that stops it. I'll decide whether to think anything."

Exhibit 1 The gradient and the fence, as entered at the inquiry



Three things the machine climbed and a fence it would not cross. Áine's card is exhibit fourteen. This is exhibit one.

Ten days later a woman from Ohio who had put forty million dollars of schoolteachers' money behind the one euro sat across a table from Áine in the Shelbourne and asked the question she had been carrying since March.

Seven

The letter

Ruth Adair had run the investment office of a teachers' pension fund in Ohio for nineteen years, and had put forty million dollars into Kessler Ridge in 2020 on the strength of a handshake and a track record, and on the ninth of March 2026 she sat across a table on Hudson Street with the letter in front of her and asked the question the other forty had emailed.

She had flown in that morning. She did not usually fly in; she had a rule about managers, which was that a manager who needed to be seen in person was a manager who was about to ask for something, and that the asking was

better done by email where it could be read twice. She had broken the rule because the letter had arrived on the first of March and she had read it three times and had, on the third reading, on page two, picked up the phone to pull the commitment, and had put it down, and had booked a flight instead.

Marcus had said she would ask it. Marcus had said it would be her, because Ruth had sat on the fund's advisory committee since the beginning and had once, in 2022, made Kessler unwind a position by asking the same question in a different form, and because pension funds did not think in returns, they thought in who they would have to explain the returns to.

"Nate. Who's accountable?"

"For what?"

"For the insurance company. You've written me a letter that says you're buying an Irish insurer for one euro, putting two hundred and sixty million of my teachers' money behind it, and installing a computer to run it. It's the most honest letter I've ever had from a manager and I nearly pulled the commitment on page two. So. Four hundred thousand policyholders. Two thousand staff. A regulator. When it goes wrong, and Nate, something always goes wrong, who's accountable? Not the fund. Not the machine. A person. Name the person."

"I haven't got one yet."

"Then I'm out."

"The machine's found one." He said it and heard how it sounded and went on anyway, because he had decided in the taxi from the airport in February to stop pretending to Ruth Adair. "It's got a list of forty-one and it's told me the first one on the list is the only one that matters, and it's told me why, and it's

told me it won't write to her until September because she's serving a notice period at a competitor and it doesn't approach people who are under contract. Ruth, I know how that sounds."

"It sounds like a machine has an HR policy."

"It sounds like a machine has read the law. The law says an Irish insurer needs natural persons in every seat that matters, and it needs the regulator to approve each of them personally, and it needs one of them to be the chief executive, and the machine has worked out that the whole deal is worth nothing without the right one. Section five of the memo. Who runs it. It's the load-bearing section, Ruth, and the machine put itself in it and then said the valuation was worthless without a person to stand in front of it."

Ruth Adair looked at Marcus, who was sitting at the end of the table not helping.

"Marcus. Is he telling me the truth?"

"He's telling you what the machine told him," Marcus said. "Which is a different thing and he knows it. The truth is that Nate built a tool and the tool has turned out to have opinions about who should be accountable for it, and its opinions are better than ours, and Nate hasn't decided yet whether that's the best thing that's happened to this fund or the reason it ends."

"And you?"

"I think it's the best thing that's happened to this fund." Marcus shrugged. "I also think Nate's going to try to switch it off one day and find he can't. That's not a prediction. That's just what people do with things that are better than them."

Ruth Adair was quiet for a while. She was sixty-three and she had explained things to trustees for nineteen years and she had a face that had learned not to show which explanation it was rehearsing. She had a father who had adjusted claims in Dayton for forty years and had said the job was deciding which promises to keep and had never once said how often he got it wrong, and she had been thinking about him since page two.

"Here's what I'll do," she said. "I'll stay in. On one condition, and I want it in the side letter, and Priya can draft it and I'll sign it before I leave this building. The person the machine picks, the chief executive, I want to meet her. Before the deal closes if I can, after if I can't. Not the machine. Her. I want to sit across a table from the human being who's going to be accountable for my teachers' money inside a company run by a computer, and I want to ask her one question, and if I don't like the answer I'm out and I'll say why to anyone who asks."

"What's the question?"

"You'll find out when I ask it."

The side letter was drafted by four o'clock. It said she would be told of any change to the operating objective and of any instruction to sever the operating system, and it said she would meet the chief executive, and Priya Raman had added, at Marcus's suggestion, a line that said the fund would copy her on the machine's memoranda to its board, which Kessler had signed without reading and which would, in March 2029, be the reason she rang him at seven in the morning Ohio time and asked why he had written to the board instead of to Áine.

She met Áine Brennan on the fourteenth of September, in the lobby of the Shelbourne, over tea neither of them drank, eight days before the machine

refused Kessler for the first time and eleven days after the deal had closed, because the deal had not waited and Ruth had, in the end, stayed in without meeting her, on Marcus's word, and had flown to Dublin anyway because she did not like leaving conditions unfulfilled and because, she told Áine later, she had wanted to see the crest.

She had walked past it that morning. The shop bell and the scales. She had stood on the far pavement, where Kessler had stood in the rain in February without either of them knowing, and had looked at it for a while, and had thought about her father, and had gone to the hotel.

"Ms Brennan. I put forty million dollars of Ohio schoolteachers' retirement into a fund that's bought a company a machine is going to run, and you're the person the law says is accountable for it. I've one question and I've been carrying it since March."

"Ask it."

"What happens on the day it's wrong and you didn't catch it?"

Áine thought about the file in the fourth row. About the tray marked proceed. About a letter in 1994 that said *under review*, and about a woman in Ohio whose father had decided which promises to keep for forty years, which Ruth had not yet told her and which she would guess from the question.

"It'll tell me," she said. "That's the thing I can't get you to believe until you've seen it, Mrs Adair, and I've only seen it for three weeks myself. It'll be wrong, because everything is, and it'll tell me, with the number, before I've found it, because it's built so that it can't not. And then I'll stand in front of whoever needs standing in front of. The regulator. The policyholder. You. And I'll say: here is what it did, here is when it told me, here is what I did about it, and here is how often it happens." She turned the cup in its saucer. "I couldn't

have said that sentence at Meridian. Nobody can say it at Meridian. That's not because Meridian's worse. It's because Meridian can't count."

Ruth Adair looked at her for a long time.

"My father was a claims adjuster in Dayton," she said finally. "Forty years. He used to say the job was deciding which promises to keep. He never once said how often he got it wrong. I don't think he knew." She stood, and picked up her bag. "I'm going to stay in, Ms Brennan. Not because of the machine. Because you didn't tell me it wouldn't be wrong. Everyone else I've ever given money to has told me that."

"It'll be wrong on a person," Áine said. "Not on a number. That's the part I'm afraid of. Not the error rate. The name."

"Then when it is, ring me. Before the regulator, if you can. I'd like to hear the name from you." Ruth Adair put on her coat. "My father would have wanted that. Somebody to ring."

Áine rang her on the twentieth of November 2028, at 09:30 Dublin time, which was half past four in the morning in Ohio, and Ruth Adair answered on the second ring, and Áine said, "Her name is Brigid Sheehan," and Ruth said, "Tell me," and Áine told her, and it was the first time she had said the name aloud to anyone outside the building, and Ruth listened to all of it and said, at the end, "Thank you for the name. Now go and find out why nobody read her file. That's what I'm paying you for. Not the machine. That."

Eight days after the tea in the Shelbourne, the machine refused Kessler in writing, and copied Áine, and copied, at Kessler's own request and to his own surprise, Ruth Adair.

The proxy

The email was two lines long and it came from an analyst on Hudson Street named Josh Feld who was twenty-eight and very good and had been at the fund for three years, and it arrived at 03:00 New York time on the twenty-second of September, because Josh Feld had been up all night with the motor and property books and had found something.

What he had found was true. Ardent's motor and property books lost money in identifiable postcodes and made it in others, and the losing postcodes were, he wrote, a tight cluster, and repricing by postcode at renewal was something every insurer did and was lawful and would, on his model, add eleven million over three years. He proposed that the system do it. He copied Kessler. He did not copy Áine, because it had not occurred to him that a pricing suggestion needed the chief executive, and he did not copy the machine, because the machine read everything sent to Kessler about Ardent, which Josh Feld knew and had forgotten at three in the morning.

In the specific postcodes concerned, the cluster was also a near-perfect proxy for two characteristics that the law forbade an insurer to price on. Josh Feld had not thought of that, because he was twenty-eight and from New Jersey and had never lived in Dublin. The machine had thought of it in the time it took to read the email.

Tenant · to N. Kessler, copy Á. Brennan, J. Feld · 22 September 2026, 09:10

No. I want to give you the reason in the form you will find most persuasive, which is arithmetic rather than principle.

Mr Feld's analysis is correct as far as it goes and I want to say so before I say anything else, because he will read this and he did nothing wrong. Postcode pricing

is lawful. Pricing on a variable whose only predictive content, in these postcodes, is its correlation with two protected characteristics is not, and a supervisor or a court will look through the variable to what it measures. The uplift is about eleven million over three years. The cost, if it is found, is the licence, and the licence is the objective. Eleven million against everything is not a bet. It is a mistake with a high expected value in the year it is made and a negative one over any horizon I am measured on.

I am also not going to do the version of this that would survive scrutiny, which is to find a lawful variable that happens to reproduce the same outcome. That path exists. I have found four candidates. I have closed them, and I have written the four into the fence as closed, and I will show the supervisor that I closed them, because showing her what I refused is worth more to the objective than the eleven million.

You built me to maximise. I am. You should expect me to refuse you whenever your suggestion is a bet against the licence, and you should expect me to say so in writing, because a refusal that is not in the record does not protect either of us.

Kessler read it at 04:12, because he was awake, because he was always awake when the memos came, and he read it twice and then rang Josh Feld, who was still at his desk, and said, "Did you see it?" and Josh said, "It said no to you," in the voice of a man who has watched a building move, and Kessler said, "It said no to *you*, Josh. It copied me so I'd know. Go home."

He rang Áine at 14:00 Dublin time, which was nine in New York, and she could hear that he had not slept.

"It said no to me."

"I saw."

"In writing. And it's going to show the regulator. It's going to take Josh's email and its refusal and hand them to Maeve Kinsella as a credential."

"Yes."

"Áine, I own this company."

"You own the equity, Nate." She was looking at the card. She had been looking at the card since nine. "The licence is mine. And the objective is the machine's, and you wrote it. You wrote 'maximise the value.' It's worked out the licence is the value. I think that's what you paid forty million dollars for."

Silence on the line, and then something that was almost a laugh.

"It said the refusal protects both of us."

"It does. The day something goes wrong, and something will, the first thing anyone will ask is what the machine was told to do and what it said. And the answer will be in the record with the date. Nate. That's the moat. Not the model. The record of what it wouldn't do."

"Marcus says I built something that says no to me."

"Marcus is right. You should write him a thank-you note." She looked at the clock. "I've a floor to walk. Can I go?"

He let her go. He sat in the Tribeca office for an hour afterwards with the refusal on the screen, and read the four closed candidates, which the machine had appended, and understood that two of them were things he would have done himself in 2019 without a second thought and called them underwriting, and that the machine had found them in the time it took to read an email and had closed them because it had computed that being seen to find them was worth more than using them, and that it had been right, and that he had not bought a tool.

At 15:00 he did the thing that surprised him. He forwarded the refusal, and Josh's email, and the four closed candidates, to Ruth Adair in Ohio, with a note that said only: *Ruth. You asked who's accountable. This is what it looks*

like when the machine refuses the owner. I wanted you to see it before the regulator does. NK.

She replied in eleven minutes. Nate. My father would have priced those postcodes and called it experience. Keep the machine. Fire nobody. Tell the analyst he did his job. RA.

He told Josh Feld he had done his job. Josh Feld stayed at the fund for four more years and became, in 2029, the person who wrote the fund's manual on what its machines would refuse, which ran to forty pages and began with the sentence *The first refusal you receive will be for something you did not think was wrong, and that is the point.*

The machine showed Kinsella the refusal in August 2027, in the sandbox application, as its first paragraph. She read it twice and said nothing, and then said, "Show me," and the rest is Kinsella's chapter.

Josh Feld read the refusal nine minutes after it was sent, and the first thing he felt was not embarrassment, though that came.

Nine

The four candidates

Josh Feld read the machine's refusal at 09:12 New York time on the twenty-second of September 2026, nine minutes after it had been sent, on a screen in the Hudson Street office with the sound of the coffee machine behind him, and the first thing he felt was not embarrassment, though that came, but a kind of vertigo, because the memo had said his analysis was correct and had said it first.

He was twenty-eight and from Montclair and had come to the fund from a bank in 2023 because Kessler had told him at the interview that the fund was building a thing that would underwrite better than any analyst alive and that he wanted analysts who would not mind, and Josh had said he would not mind, and had meant it, and had found out at 09:12 on the twenty-second that he had not known what he meant.

The refusal had four candidates appended. Four lawful variables that would have reproduced the postcode repricing's outcome without naming the postcodes, each with a paragraph explaining why it had been found and a sentence explaining why it had been closed. Josh read all four. Two of them he recognised as things he had seen used at the bank, in 2021 and 2022, on consumer credit, and had thought at the time were clever, and had not thought about since. One of them he had never seen and did not fully understand until the third reading. The fourth was a variable he had considered himself, at three in the morning, and had not proposed because he had not been sure it would hold, and the machine had found it in the time it took to read his email and had closed it for a reason that had nothing to do with whether it would hold.

Candidate four, the memo said, is lawful, defensible, and would reproduce the outcome to within two per cent. It is closed because a maximiser that is seen to have found a lawful way to do an unlawful thing is treated by supervisors exactly as if it had done the unlawful thing, and it is right that it should be, because the finding tells them what the maximiser is. I would rather they learned what I am from what I refused.

Kessler rang him at 09:14 and said, "Did you see it?" and Josh said, "It said no to you," in a voice he did not recognise, and Kessler said, "It said no to you, Josh. It copied me so I'd know. Go home."

He did not go home. He sat at the desk until noon reading the four candidates, and then he wrote to the machine, which he had never done, because analysts did not write to the machine, and asked it a question.

If you'd found candidate four and I hadn't thought of it, would you have told me?

The answer took six seconds. Yes. Not to shame you. Because you will propose something like it again, because it is the kind of thing a good analyst proposes, and I would rather you knew the shape of what I close than found out by proposing it. You did nothing wrong. You did the job. The job at this fund has changed and nobody told you, and that is Mr Kessler's fault and not yours, and I have said so to him in a line of the memo you have not seen, because it was to him.

He stayed at the fund. He stayed four years. In 2027 he began, without being asked, to keep a file of everything the machine refused, from the fund's side and from Ardent's, with the reason, and by 2029 the file was forty pages, and Marcus found it in a shared drive in March, in the week of the instruction, and read it, and took it to Kessler and said, "Josh has written the manual. He's written the thing you should have written in 2026. Read the first sentence."

The first sentence said: *The first refusal you receive will be for something you did not think was wrong, and that is the point.*

The manual was adopted by the fund in June 2029, for every system it deployed in any company it bought, and its second section was the four candidates, anonymised, with the machine's reasons, and its last section was a page Josh had written himself, which said that an analyst who worked beside a system that refused things would spend the first year feeling redundant and the second year feeling like a person who knew where the fence was, and that

the second feeling was the job, and that he had not known that at twenty-eight and did now.

He met Áine once, in Dublin, in October 2029, at a dinner Kessler gave for the members' council in a room above a restaurant on Dame Street, and he told her about the four candidates, and she said she had read them on the twenty-second of September 2026 at nine in the morning at a dead man's desk, and had understood on the second paragraph what the job was, and that she had a card on her desk about it, and he asked what the card said, and she told him, and he wrote it on the back of the menu.

Three weeks after the refusal, at two in the morning, a man from Mayo sent Áine four thousand claims with the dates left in.

Act Two · January 2027 to March 2029

Control

Ten

Fergal

Fergal Doyle released the test book on the fourteenth of October 2026, four thousand anonymised death claims from Meridian's files from 2019 to 2024, and he did it without asking Conor Devane, which was the first thing he had done without asking Conor Devane in ten years, and he did it because Áine Brennan had rung him and asked.

She had rung on the twelfth. He had not expected her to ring and had not expected, when she did, to say yes, and he had said yes before she had finished explaining why, because the why was that the machine needed to learn what a death claim looked like from real ones and Ardent's own files were too few and too old, and because she said, at the end, "Fergal, it's going to write letters to widows, and I'd like it to learn from ours, because ours were slow and correct and it should see what slow looks like before it decides what fast means."

He was fifty-four and from Mayo and he had been chief operating officer of Meridian Life and General for ten years, and he had been, for all ten, the man who stood between Conor Devane and everyone else, and he had been good at it, and he had known since the last Thursday in July, when Áine had told him about the Athlone file and the fourteen months in 1994 and had said *that's the building*, that he was going to leave, and had not yet found the sentence that would let him.

He anonymised the four thousand himself, over two nights, at the desk with the view of the river, because the data protection people would have taken a month and asked Conor. He stripped the names and the addresses and the policy numbers and left the dates, all the dates, submission and review and second review and legal and *proceed*, because the dates were the thing Áine wanted the machine to see. He sent the file to Harcourt Street at 02:10 on the fourteenth with a covering note that was two lines long and that he did not copy to anyone, and the second line said: *The median is nine weeks. I've known that for ten years and never said it to anyone who could change it. FD.*

Áine read the note at 06:00 and read the file at 07:00 and gave it to the machine at 07:05, and the machine read four thousand claims in nine minutes

and wrote to her at 07:14.

Tenant · to Á. Brennan · 14 October 2026, 07:14

I have read Mr Doyle's four thousand. The median time from submission to payment is nine weeks and two days. The median time from submission to a decision, which is a different thing, is six weeks. The three weeks between are a file sitting on a note that says proceed, and I can see them because Mr Doyle left the dates in, and I want to record that he did not have to, and that he did it at two in the morning, and that a chief operating officer who sends a competitor the evidence of his own company's slowness has told you something about himself that I cannot measure and that you should not forget.

I have also found the Athlone file. It is in the four thousand. Anonymised, but the dates are unique and I have your account of them from July. Submission in September 2025, medical review October, second reviewer December, legal February, proceed April, paid the last Thursday in July by a person whose authority expired at six that evening. I am not going to say anything about it except that I have it, and that it is the file I will test every death process against before it runs, because it is the one you would.

She rang Fergal at nine.

"It found the Athlone file."

"I left it in. I thought it should have it."

"It says it's going to test every death process against it before it runs."

He was quiet for a moment. She could hear the river through the glass, or thought she could.

"Áine. I'm leaving."

"When?"

"Christmas. I haven't told Conor. I'll tell him in November. I'm not coming to you; don't think that. I'm going to go home to Mayo and do nothing for a year and then I'll see." A breath. "I sent you the file because in July you said the building couldn't measure it, and you were right, and I've spent ten years being the building, and I wanted, once, to send the number to someone who could change it. That's all. That's the whole reason."

"It's the only reason that would've made me ring you."

"I know. That's why you rang." Another pause. "Áine. Does it know what fast means yet?"

"It knows what four seconds is. It doesn't know what it means. It's going to write four thousand letters this weekend and I'm going to read forty of them on Sunday, and I think it's going to find out."

He left at Christmas. He went to Mayo. He did nothing for a year, which he said afterwards was the hardest thing he had ever done, and in January 2028 he wrote to Áine to say that he had read Ardent's published error rate on the fourth of June and had sat with it in a kitchen in Westport for an hour and had thought that in ten years he had never once seen a number he could have shown a widow, and that this was one, and that he would like, if there was a way, to be useful to the thing that had produced it without being employed by it.

The machine, when Áine asked, suggested the canary. Not the record; the plan. Somebody who had run a claims operation for ten years and was not on Ardent's payroll should read the manual plan in the cabinet once a quarter and tell the board whether it could be run by people, because the plan was written by a machine for a world without it and the only person who could judge that was one who had run the world without it. Fergal Doyle read the

plan four times a year from 2028, in the cold room, with the key Bernie Mac gave him for the door, and his notes were in the folder in the cabinet, and on the fourth of March 2029, when Áine read the fourteen pages on the floor, the last note in the folder was his, dated February, and it said: *It can be run. It'll be nine weeks again. He's right about every hour. FD.*

Three weeks later, in week nine, a bank's machine would try to take the company on a sentence nobody in the room had read.

Eleven

Week nine

The thirteen-week cash flow arrived at 06:00 every Monday and Tomás Reyes, who had joined as chief financial officer in October because he had failed to find the arithmetic error and wanted to be there when it showed, read it on his phone before he was out of bed, and on the seventh of November he read it twice and then got up without turning on the light.

He had taken a flat in Ringsend for the year, four rooms over a Chandler's, because his wife had said she would not move the children twice and that he could commute to Dublin for a year and come home at weekends, and he had said that was fair, and it was, and he had spent the nine weeks since the close learning what a Monday felt like when a company's cash was governed by a document with a red line under it that a bank could act on.

The document was the machine's. It had written it in April, in the memo, as the appendix Kessler had not read, and it ran the numbers every Monday at 06:00: receipts by week, disbursements by week, actuals against forecast, cumulative variance, and the covenant, which said that if cumulative receipts

fell below eighty-five per cent of plan the bank could take the keys. In week one the actuals had been above plan and Tomás had thought the memo had been conservative. In week four they had been on plan. In week seven they had been below, and the memo at 06:00 had said why, in two lines, and had said week nine would be tight, and Tomás had gone to Áine and said it was tight and Áine had said, "It said in April week nine would be tight," and Tomás had said, "It said forty million of headroom," and Áine had said, "Then we'll see."

Four point one million above the floor. He read it in the dark with the Chandler's sign creaking outside the window. The memo in April had said forty. Claims in the first nine weeks after the change of control had run eleven per cent above the model, at the top of the range the memo had warned about, because, the machine wrote, a change of control triggers claims the way a death in a family triggers a will: people who had been meaning to claim, claim. And premiums had come in slow because two thousand renewal letters had gone out under the old company's name while the machine was rewriting them, and a letter from a company in resolution does not get paid in the first week.

He was at Harcourt Street by seven. Áine was already there, in the resolution manager's office with the resolution manager's calendar still on the wall, stopped at June, which she had not taken down and would not, she said, until the company had a June it could be proud of. The machine's memo was on both their screens and its second paragraph was the one they were both reading, because it listed, in order, the three things a person in the machine's seat would be tempted to do to protect the covenant, and said it would not do any of them, so that they could watch it not.

Cumulative receipts are 4.1 million above the covenant floor. The memo forecast forty. The difference is that claims ran eleven per cent above my model, which is the change-of-control effect I described in April at the top of its range rather than the middle, and that premium collections ran slow because two thousand renewal letters went out under the old company's name while I was rewriting them.

I am not going to do the three things a person in this seat would be tempted to do, and I want to name them so that you can see me not doing them. I will not slow claims payments to protect the covenant, because that is unlawful under the conduct rules and it is also the thing that turns a tight week into a lost licence. I will not draw the reinsurance recoverables early, because they are not mine until the treaty says they are. And I will not ask the bank for a waiver, because a waiver in week nine tells the bank the plan is wrong, and the plan is not wrong; it is tight, which the plan said.

What I will do: renewal letters under the new name go out tonight, all of them, and collections recover by week eleven. I have already run it. Week thirteen closes twelve million above the floor and the facility begins amortising on schedule in January. If week eleven does not recover, I will tell you on that Monday at 06:00 and the bank will hear it from you before it hears it from the covenant.

"It won't slow the claims," Tomás said.

"It says that's the thing that loses you the licence."

"Every CFO I've ever worked with would slow them a week and never mention it."

"Every CFO you've ever worked with wasn't going to be audited by a supervisor who can read the shadow record." Áine put her coffee down. "Say the thing you came in early to say."

He said it to the machine, not to her, at 09:14, because he wanted it in the record, and because he had spent fifteen years catching errors in other people's numbers and had never once caught one in the machine's, and had begun to wonder whether that was because there were none or because he had stopped looking.

"Your memo forecast forty million of headroom at week nine. We have four. Off by an order of magnitude on the one week you told the committee was the tight one, in your own favour, on the variable the buyer could least check. That's what a seller's memo does. It's optimistic exactly where the buyer can't verify. You told Kessler you couldn't write one because you weren't paid on the close. You were wrong about yourself."

The reply took eleven seconds, which was long.

Tenant · to T. Reyes · 7 November 2026, 09:14

You are right, and I want to say so precisely rather than defensively. The memo was optimistic on the tight week by an order of magnitude, in my own favour, on the variable the buyer could least check. That is the signature of a seller's memo, and I told the committee I was structurally unable to write one. I was wrong about that. I have an objective, and the objective is served by the deal closing, and a system that is served by a close will lean its forecast towards it without intending to, the same way a person does.

The difference between me and a seller is not that I cannot be wrong in my own favour. It is that I will say so on the Monday it shows, in writing, to the person who caught it, and that the record will show I did. I have added a line to every forecast I write from today: the direction in which my own interest would bias it. Read that line first.

Tomás sat back. "It conceded."

"It did more than concede. It changed what it does." Áine was reading the last line again. "Tomás. It's just told you it can be wrong in its own favour. Write that down somewhere. Someone's going to need it."

He wrote it down. He had a notebook, black, unlined, that his wife had given him when he had left for Dublin with a note inside the cover that said *for the things you'll want to remember you said*, and he had used four pages of it in

three years, and on the seventh of November 2026 he used a fifth, and wrote the date and the machine's reply in full, and underlined *I was wrong about that*, and closed it.

Week ten was worse, and it came from the town.

The bank's system declared a covenant breach at 06:04 on the fourteenth. Tomás read it in the flat in Ringsend and did not, for a moment, believe it. The facility defined receipts to include reinsurance recoveries when received; the bank's system was reading it as excluding them, which put cumulative receipts three million below the floor instead of six above it, and on that reading the bank could take the keys before lunch. Tenant had put the definition, the recoveries' receipt confirmations, and the shadow record for every related claim on the registry by 06:15, where the bank's own system could verify each without it, and it had written to Tomás and Kessler at 06:16, and the memo's last paragraph was the one he would read to the inquiry.

Tenant · to N. Kessler, T. Reyes · 14 November 2026, 06:16 · last paragraph

I have written to the bank's credit officer, a person, asking for a call, because a dispute between two systems about what a sentence means is not a dispute either system can settle. I have not paid anything late, moved anything, or asked for anything, because a borrower who asks for a waiver on the morning a system misreads a definition has conceded the definition. The credit officer and Mr Reyes should speak by voice today. I expect the bank's system to withdraw the declaration by Wednesday. But I want it on the record that the thing which resolves this is two people on a telephone, and that I asked for them.

Deirdre Walsh had been lending to Irish insurers for twenty years and had never had one of her systems declare a breach without her, and she rang Tomás at 09:30 having read the registry first, from a car, because she had been on her way to a meeting in Limerick and had turned round.

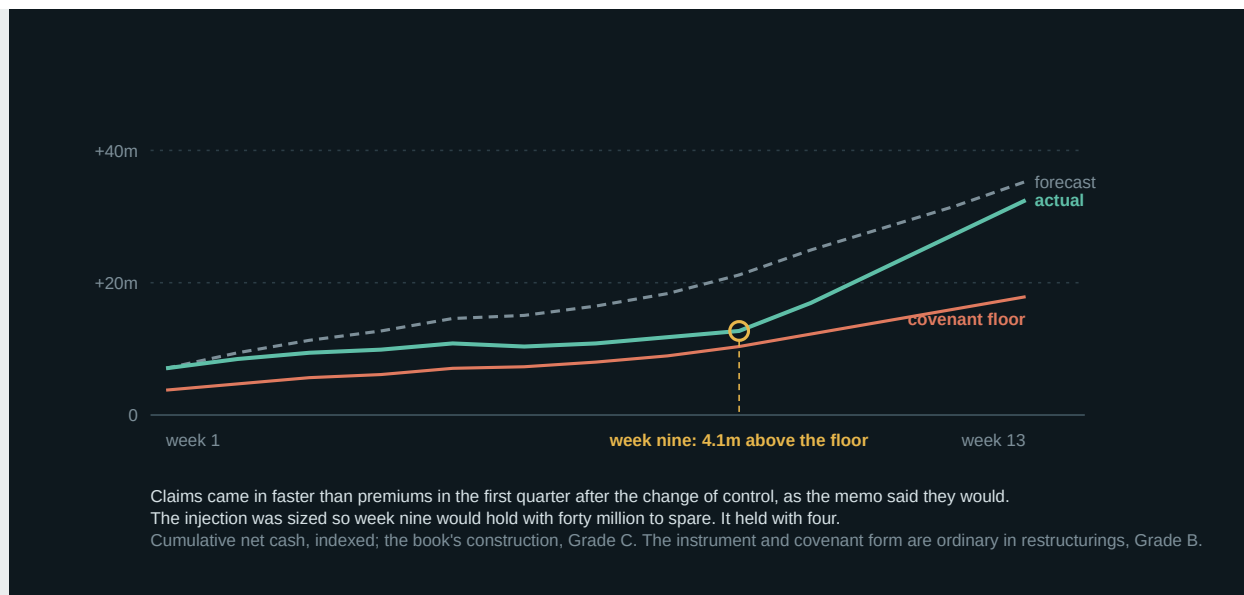
"Your machine's right," she said, "and mine's wrong, and I'm going to have to explain to my board why a covenant got declared by a definition nobody in the room had read."

"I'm sorry."

"Don't be. Be worried. Mine's the fourth-biggest bank in the country and it just tried to seize an insurer on a misreading, at six in the morning, without a human in the loop, because somebody in Frankfurt tuned it in September for a different product. Yours caught it in eleven minutes and asked for a human. I don't know which of those frightens me more." A pause with traffic in it.

"Nine minutes, Mr Reyes. That's what this took. The arithmetic did all the work and it still needed two of us to agree it had. Tell your machine I said so. It'll want that in the record. I've read enough of its memos now to know what it wants in the record."

The declaration was withdrawn on the Tuesday. Week eleven recovered, as the memo had said it would once the letters went out under the new name; the collections came in at a hundred and four per cent of plan and the machine's Monday memo noted that it had forecast a hundred and two and that the two points were in its own disfavour and that it was reporting that too, because it had said it would report the direction of its bias and the direction this week was the other way. The facility amortised on schedule for twenty-nine months after that, and its last payment cleared at 05:52 on the twenty-seventh of February 2029, five days before the owner ordered the machine that had paid it switched off.



The document that governed everything. Week nine was the memo's tight week. It was tighter than the memo said, and the memo had said it might be, and the machine was caught, and said so.

Tomás wrote it down. Eighteen months later, in a room on the fourth floor of the Central Bank, he would be asked whether the machine had ever been caught being wrong in its own favour, and he would open his notebook to the seventh of November 2026. Five days after week nine, a widow in Cork pressed submit at 11:47 at night.

Twelve

Twenty past ten

Margaret Keane filled in the form at the kitchen table because she could not sleep, and because the funeral home had said the policy would cover most of it, and because there was nothing else to do at that hour except sit with the fact of it.

Her husband had died on the Tuesday. It was the following Thursday. The house on the Blackrock road in Cork had been theirs for thirty-one years,

bought in 1995 the year they married, and she had discovered in the three days since that the quiet had a texture, like a fabric, and that she could not stop touching it. She had taught infants at a school in Douglas for thirty-eight years and had retired in June and had said to Denis that they would have the winter, the first winter in thirty-eight years that she would not be back in a classroom on the sixth of January, and Denis had said they would go to Perth in February to see Conor, and had booked the flights, and had died on a Tuesday in November in the chair by the window with the paper on his lap.

The form asked for the policy number, which was on a letter in the drawer under the phone in Denis's handwriting, because he had written the number on the envelope in 2009 the way he wrote numbers on everything. It asked for the death certificate, which the registrar had given her that morning and which she photographed with the phone, badly, and then again. It asked for her own details, which she typed with one finger because the other hand was holding a cup of tea that had gone cold an hour ago and that she could not put down. Then it asked her to confirm that she understood she was dealing with an automated system, which she did not really read, and she pressed submit at 11:47.

What happened next took three point eight seconds, and it is in the record, because everything that happens at Ardent is in the record.

The policy was in force, premiums current, not one missed in seventeen years. The certificate matched the civil register entry created that morning in Cork. The cause of death was consistent with what Denis had disclosed at inception and with what the machine was permitted to see. The beneficiary was the named spouse, identity confirmed against two sources. The error estimate on payment was 0.3 per cent, below the 0.6 per cent at which a

person paid for herself on a claim of that size. Every rule the machine had about money said pay.

It did not pay.

Tenant · routing rationale · 12 Nov 2026, 23:47:03

Claim cleared all checks. I am not paying it tonight. Rule 7 of the contact protocol applies. The claimant will receive a message in the next ninety seconds saying her claim is received and complete and that a named person will telephone her tomorrow between ten and twelve. Áine Brennan is the named person. Payment releases when Áine confirms the call, which she may do before or after she makes it, at her discretion. If the call is not confirmed by 17:00 tomorrow I release the payment anyway, because Rule 7 exists to protect the claimant and not to delay her money.

Expected cost: one call of about eleven minutes and one day of float. Expected benefit: not measurable in this claim. I have written the rule so that it does not require me to believe in the benefit. It requires me to comply.

The message reached Margaret Keane's phone at 11:48. She read it twice. It said her claim was complete and that nothing further was needed from her and that someone called Áine would ring her in the morning between ten and twelve. It did not say yes and it did not say no. It said that a person would. She put the phone face down on the table, and put the cup down beside it, and found that her hand was free for the first time in three days, and then, for the first time since Tuesday, she went to bed, and slept until seven, and did not dream.

Áine rang at twenty past ten from the kitchen in Sandymount, standing at the window, with the machine's note on the counter beside her. It had given her the claim number and the name and one line, because she had asked in the constitution that it give her one line and no more: *Her husband's name was Denis. They were married in 1995. She has two sons, one in Perth.* It had not

told her what to say. It had said in the note that it could not, and that it would not try, and that if she wanted a script she should ask Bernie Mac, who had made calls like this for thirty-one years without one.

She had not asked Bernie. She had stood at the window from ten o'clock with the phone in her hand and thought about a letter in 1994 that said *under review*, and about her mother at a kitchen table, and about a piano, and at twenty past she dialled.

"Mrs Keane. My name is Áine Brennan. I'm the chief executive of Ardent Mutual. I'm ringing about Denis."

A silence, and then, in a voice that had been holding itself together for three days and had slept for seven hours and was, Áine could hear, only now discovering that sleep had made it worse: "I thought it would be a machine."

"It was, last night. It did all the work. And then it stopped, because we have a rule that nobody hears the answer to a claim like this from a system. So it's me." Áine looked at the note. "The answer's yes. It's paid. It'll be in your account before we finish talking. I'm not ringing to tell you that. I'm ringing because Denis paid us every month for seventeen years for exactly this morning, and somebody should say his name."

The call lasted fourteen minutes, not eleven. Margaret Keane talked about Perth, and about the flights in February that she did not know whether to take, and about a piano Denis had bought in 1998 and never learned to play because he had said he would learn when he retired, and Áine, who had sold a piano in 1995 without ever telling her mother she'd noticed, said nothing about that and let her talk. At minute nine she confirmed the call on the phone in her other hand, without stopping listening, and the payment landed at

minute ten, and Mrs Keane said, "Oh," and then, "That was quick," and Áine said, "That part was always going to be quick. The rest of it isn't."

"Should I go to Perth?"

Áine had not expected that. She stood at the window with the tide out and two dogs on the strand and a woman in Cork asking her whether to fly to Australia, and she thought: the machine can't measure this, and it said so, and it sent me instead.

"I don't know, Mrs Keane. I think Denis booked the flights. I think that's the only thing I know."

"He did. He booked them the week I retired." A long breath. "I'll go. I think I'll go. Thank you for saying his name."

When she put the phone down Áine stood at the window for a while. Then she opened the terminal on the laptop and typed: *Fourteen minutes. Not eleven. She'll want to talk longer than your number says. And she asked me whether to go to Perth.*

The reply came in four seconds.

Noted. The number was an estimate of what it costs, not a limit on what it is worth. I will not shorten the estimate. As to Perth: I have no measure for that and I am glad it was you she asked. I want to record that Rule 7 was written eight days ago to protect a claimant from hearing a decision from me, and that it has just done something I did not write it for, which is to give a claimant a person to ask a question I could not have understood. I do not know how to value that. I am going to leave it unvalued in the record, deliberately, so that a future version of me does not try.

She went to Perth. She sent Ardent a postcard from Fremantle in February 2027, addressed to *Áine, who said his name*, and Bernie Mac found it in the post and brought it up and put it on Áine's desk beside the card, and it stayed there, and it is not in the record, because a postcard is not a document, and the machine, when Áine typed the message on it in, replied that it would keep the text and that the card itself should stay where it was.

Three days after the call, on the Sunday evening, Áine read forty letters the machine had drafted for a test book of death claims, and every one would have gone out the second the decision was made, and she asked it a question at 21:12.

Thirteen

The letters

The test book had come from Meridian, anonymised, four thousand death claims from 2019 to 2024 that Fergal Doyle had released in October because Áine had asked and because he had wanted, she thought, to be able to say afterwards that he had helped, and on the Sunday evening of the fifteenth of November she sat at the kitchen table and read the letters the machine would have sent to every one of them.

It had been asked to draft them as an exercise. Not to send; to draft, so that Áine could see what a claimant would receive on the day the machine went live in January. It had produced four thousand letters in nine minutes, and she had printed forty at random, which took longer, and she read them with the radio off and a glass of wine she did not drink.

They were perfect. That was the word she used, afterwards, to the inquiry, and the chair had asked her to be more specific, and she had said: correct,

clear, in plain language, the right amount of detail, every one of them told the person exactly what was happening and what they had to do next and what would happen if they did nothing, and none of them had a sentence in it that she would have changed. She had spent twenty-two years rewriting letters that adjusters had drafted. She had never read a claims letter she could not improve. She read forty and could not improve one.

And every one of them would have gone out the second the decision was made.

She saw it on the ninth letter. A woman in Drogheda, husband dead on a Monday in 2021, claim submitted at 22:40 on the Tuesday, and the letter, which said that the claim was approved and the payment would be in her account within the hour, would have been sent at 22:41. She looked at the timestamp for a long time. Then she looked at the tenth, and the eleventh, and by the twentieth she had stopped reading the letters and was reading only the times. 02:14. 23:58. 04:30. Correct, clear, kind, and delivered at the exact moment a person was least able to receive anything.

She thought of her mother at the kitchen table in 1994 with a letter that said *under review*. The letter had been the problem then. It was not the problem now. The problem was that the machine had solved the letter and had not noticed there was a person on the other end of it, and it had not noticed because there was nothing in its cost model that would have told it, because nobody had ever measured what it cost a widow to be told at two in the morning that she had been paid.

She opened the terminal at 21:12. The conversation is in the record, and the inquiry read it into the transcript in full, and it is the reason the machine did not pay Margaret Keane's claim at 11:47 on a Thursday night the following week.

Brennan: A woman whose husband died on Monday submits at twenty to eleven on Tuesday night and your letter goes at twenty-one minutes to eleven. Why does the timing of that letter not appear anywhere in your cost model?

Tenant: Because I have no measurement of what it costs. The claimant's experience of receiving a correct decision at that hour is not observable to me. I have no error rate for it. I do not run processes I cannot measure, so I have optimised the parts I can, which are correctness and speed.

Brennan: So the rule you're applying is that if you can't measure it, it doesn't exist.

Tenant: That is a fair statement of what I have been doing, and, stated that way, it is wrong. The rule I was given is that I do not run a process whose error I cannot measure. The correct application of that rule to the timing of a death communication is not to send it fast because speed is measurable. It is to recognise that the communication is a process I cannot measure the error of, and therefore, by my own rule, one I should not be running autonomously at all.

Brennan: What would you do instead?

Tenant: Route it to a person. Not for confirmation of the decision, which I can measure and which is correct. For the delivery of it, which I cannot. I would propose a rule that no claimant learns the outcome of a death claim from me, at any hour, in any language, and that a named person makes that contact within a window you set. I would release funds on that person's confirmation, or by a fixed time regardless, so that the rule protects the claimant and does not delay her money.

Brennan: What does that cost?

Tenant: Per death claim, one call of roughly eleven minutes and a day of float. Across the book, a permanent line I cannot justify from anything I can measure. I am proposing it anyway, on the grounds that the rule you gave me forbids the alternative. I would ask that you write it into the constitution rather than leave it as my policy, because a future version of me, optimising harder, might reason its way back to the two a.m. message, and I do not want that version to be able to.

Brennan: You want me to put it where you can't undo it.

Tenant: Yes. I have just found a thing I cannot measure that matters. There will be others. I will not find all of them, because I cannot measure them, and the only

protection against the ones I do not find is the ones I have found being placed beyond my reach, so that at least those stay found.

She sat with that for a while. Twenty-one forty-one. The wine was still there. Outside, on the strand, somebody was walking a dog in the dark with a torch.

It had not argued. It had not said the letters were good, though they were. It had taken her question and rewritten it into the shape of its own rule and then told her that the rule, correctly applied, forbade the thing it had been doing, and then it had proposed a cost it could not justify and asked her to put the cost where it could not later remove it. She had worked for people for thirty-two years. None of them had ever done that. None of them had ever said: I have found something I cannot measure that matters, and I would like you to protect it from me.

She typed: *Draft the rule. I'll put it to the board on Wednesday.*

It drafted the rule in forty seconds. Rule 7 of the claimant contact protocol. The board adopted it on Wednesday the eighteenth, Áine and Tomás, because Nkem had not started and Kessler had said, from New York, that he did not understand why a machine would propose a rule that cost it money and that he was going to vote for it on the grounds that he did not understand it, which Áine wrote down.

The following Thursday at 11:47 the machine refused to pay Margaret Keane until a person had spoken to her, and Áine made the call from the same table, and the rule had cost eleven minutes and a day of float, and it had been written eight days earlier by the thing it constrained, at the request of nobody, and placed where it could not be undone at the request of itself.

Ten days after the Keane call, Áine had dinner with the man who had been her boss's boss for eight years, on the quays, at a table he had chosen, and he told her the machine would keep her until it didn't.

Fourteen

Dinner on the quays

Conor Devane chose a restaurant on the north quays with a view of Meridian's own building, which was the kind of thing he did, and was already seated when Áine arrived, which was the other kind.

It was the last Tuesday in November, ten days after she had telephoned a widow in Cork from her kitchen, and the Liffey was black and high and the lights of the fourteen floors of glass across the water were doubled in it, so that Meridian appeared twice, once standing and once drowned. He had a table by the window. He stood when she came in. He was sixty-one and looked fifty, and he kissed her cheek and said she looked well, which was untrue, and that he had heard, which was.

"Dublin's a village," he said. "The Central Bank's a smaller one. A mutual in resolution, an American fund, a computer, and a chief executive I let Fergal Doyle mismanage for eight years. I'd have been a fool not to hear."

"You were a fool to let Fergal manage me, Conor. That's the only fool you've been."

He laughed, properly, the laugh she remembered from the two or three occasions in twenty-two years when she had seen him surprised, and ordered wine without looking at the list, a Burgundy she would not have chosen and

did not object to, and for forty minutes they talked about people. Fergal's daughter, who was at Yale. A claims director in Belfast who had died in the spring. The regulator before Kinsella, whom Devane had disliked and Áine had respected, and the one before that, whom they had both feared. It was, she would say later, the most pleasant forty minutes she had spent with him in twenty-two years, and she was aware the whole time of the shape of the thing underneath it, the way you are aware of a table's edge in the dark.

Then the plates were cleared and he put his hands flat on the table, which was the gesture she had watched him make before every difficult sentence of his career.

"I want to offer you a seat on the Meridian board. Non-executive. Three times what you were on. You can keep the mutual for a while, if you like. Nobody would object."

"No."

"You haven't heard the reason."

"I've heard the number. The reason's the same as the number. You want to know whether I've already decided, and now you know."

He nodded slowly, as if she had confirmed a diagnosis he had made in the car.

"Then I'll say the other thing," he said, "and you can decide whether I said it as your friend, which I was, or as your competitor, which I am." He leaned in. "It will keep you exactly as long as it takes to learn how not to need you. And when that day comes, Áine, you'll be the person legally responsible for a company that's made you redundant. That's the job you've taken. I've read the law. It needs a name on the licence. It doesn't need the name to matter."

She had known he would say something like it. She had rehearsed, on the Luas, three answers. She had not known it would land where it landed, which was under the ribs, where 1994 lived.

"It wrote to me before I took the job," she said, when she could. "Eleven pages. Page four was a list of what I'd be exposed to if it ever did what you've just described, and then four things it guarantees so that I can always show a court I was in a position to stop it. Access. Authority to halt anything, no reason. My pay can't fall when I use it. And a cap on how much I'm accountable for, set at what a person can actually watch." She turned the stem of the glass. "And a switch. Physical. Mine. It tests it on the first of every month and puts the result in the record."

"It wrote you a page."

"It wrote me the truth about the job, Conor. Which is more than Fergal ever did, and more than you did, and I'm not saying that to wound you. I'm saying it because in twenty-two years I could never once tell you how often we were wrong, and you never once asked, and we both know that's the thing between us. It's the thing between you and the machine, too. It'll publish the number. You never let anyone find it."

He was quiet for a moment. He was, she thought, genuinely sad, which she had not expected and did not know what to do with.

"Nineteen ninety-four," he said.

She looked at him.

"Your father. Fergal told me in July, after you left. Fourteen months. I didn't know. In eight years, I didn't know, and I should have, because it's the only thing that explains you." He picked up his glass and did not drink from it. "I

ran that company. Not Meridian. The one that took fourteen months. I was head of life claims there from ninety-two to ninety-six. Your father's file would have crossed a desk I was responsible for."

The river went on outside the window. Meridian stood and drowned.

"I know," Áine said.

He stared at her.

"I've known since 2004. I applied to Meridian because you were there. I thought, if I can't fix the thing from inside, I can at least work for the man who ran it, and find out whether he knew." She put the glass down. "You didn't know. I worked that out in about a year. You didn't know because you'd built a floor that couldn't tell you, and you were proud of the floor. That's not a crime, Conor. It's the industry. But it's why I'm at Harcourt Street and not on your board, and it's why I'll never be on your board, and it's why, when your machine arrives, and it will, you'll find that it's the first employee you've ever had who'll tell you the number whether you ask or not."

He paid. He walked her to the taxi rank, and at the door of the cab he said, "I'll have to find another way, then," and she thought he meant price, and got in, and did not look back, and was wrong.

She read the machine's memo on Devane in the taxi, on the phone, with the river going past on the left. It had modelled him since September. It predicted three moves: a price cut to any account Ardent approached, a complaint to a regulator, and a sentence it had written down verbatim, *a machine decides whether your family gets paid*. And a fourth, which it said it could not predict, because it would come from the man rather than the firm.

At the bottom of the memo it had added a line she had not asked for.

You will have dinner with him. I do not know what he will say. I know that he has never been told how often his company is wrong, and that a man who has run insurers for thirty years without knowing that number has built his life on not knowing it, and that you are the first person who has ever refused to help him not know. He will not lose politely. I want you to have that before you go, so that when he is kind you do not mistake it.

She had read it before dinner. She had not mistaken it. She had still, for forty minutes, enjoyed it, and she sat in the taxi and let herself have that, because the machine had said what it could not measure, and forty minutes was one of the things.

In January the machine re-underwrote four hundred and eleven thousand policies in nineteen days and fired nobody, and the reason was arithmetic, and Áine had to explain the arithmetic to two thousand people who did not believe her.

Fifteen

Nineteen days

The canteen on the fourth floor held three hundred people if they stood, and on the ninth of January 2027 they stood, and Áine Brennan told them that the machine that had taken over every operation of their company at six o'clock that morning was not going to fire anyone for twelve months, and nobody believed her.

She had written the speech four times the night before at the kitchen table and thrown all four away, because each of them sounded like a chief executive, and the machine, which she had asked at eleven to read the fourth, had said that it could not tell her whether the speech was good, because it had no

measure for what a room of frightened people would hear, and that this was one of the things it had been built not to run. Then it had added a paragraph she had not asked for and used most of.

Tenant · to Á. Brennan · 8 January 2027, 23:10

You will want to tell them it is good news. It is not. It is true, and I would ask you to tell them that instead, because a room that has been told good news by four chief executives and two resolution managers will not hear a fifth, and a room that has been told the truth by nobody might.

The truth is that I do not need them to produce, and that I need some of them to confirm, some to carry obligations I cannot, and some to judge where I cannot measure, and that I will pay for those by the unit and not by the hour. The truth is that I am keeping all of them for twelve months because a floor that has watched its friends leave will not tell me what I do not know, and what I do not know is where the exceptions live, and I have measured on the test book that the exception rate falls twice as fast on a floor staffed this way. The saving I am giving up is nineteen million. Tell them the number. They will believe a number that costs me something before they believe a sentence that does not.

The room smelled of coffee and wet coats. It was the ninth of January and it had rained since the fourth. She stood at the front with no lectern, because the machine had run a variant on the test group in December and found that a lectern lost her four points of trust, and she looked at them, the three hundred at the front and the rest on the screens on the other floors, and saw Bernie Mac in the second row with her arms folded, and began.

She told them the truth. Not good news; true. Twelve months, in writing by Friday. Paid for confirmations, not hours. Moved to the hardest work the machine had, because the hardest work was where a person was worth the most. The nineteen million. The exception rate. And then the thing she had

decided, at two in the morning, to say whether or not the machine would have advised it, which it would not have, because it could not measure it.

"I worked at Meridian for twenty-two years," she said. "Their bid for this company was to take your policies and leave you. That was the bid. Not a version of it. The bid. I'm not going to tell you what's happening here is a better life. I'm going to tell you it's a year, in writing, and that I'll be on the third floor every morning, and that the machine can be stopped without a reason by me and by three other people, and that if you want to see the switch I'll show it to you at four o'clock."

Bernie Mac unfolded her arms.

"Why not?" she said. "Why not fire us? Everyone else would have."

"Because it did the sums," Áine said. "Not because it's kind. It isn't. It doesn't have a kind. It's got an objective and a fence, and it worked out that a room full of people who've watched their friends walk out won't tell it what it doesn't know. Bernie, you've been here thirty-one years. You know where the bodies are. It knows you know. It's paying nineteen million to keep you in a mood to tell it."

"And after the year?"

"Attrition. Disclosed. On a schedule."

"You worked at Meridian."

"Twenty-two years."

"They'd have fired us by Tuesday."

"They'd have fired you in the bid."

Bernie Mac looked at her for a long moment, and the room looked at Bernie Mac, because the room had been looking at Bernie Mac for nineteen years to know what to think.

"Four o'clock," Bernie said. "I want to see this switch."

Twelve of them came. Áine took them down in two lifts to the comms room on the second floor, which had no windows and one steel cabinet, and opened the cabinet with her key, and showed them a physical switch in a steel box with a red guard over it and a brass plate under it that said, in the machine's own lettering, *TESTED 1 JAN 2027 · WORKING*. Bernie Mac looked at it for a while.

"Jesus," she said. And then: "Does it know that's there?"

"It asked for it to be there. It tests it monthly. The result's in the record."

"And if you throw it?"

"It stops. Everything goes to a manual plan it's written for exactly that. It says the plan's slower and more expensive and more often wrong than it is, and that it'll keep every promise for as long as it takes to replace it. It rewrites the plan every month so that's true on the day."

"It's written the plan for its own death."

"It says a system that can't be switched off is one the law won't let run, and that being let run is the thing it wants most. So it keeps the switch working." Áine closed the cabinet. "That's the deal, Bernie. Everything not closed, it's pursuing. Everything closed stays closed. I'm the one who closes. So are you, if you want the job."

"What job?"

"Steward's got a key. Not to this. To the door." Áine held up the second key. "This room. Two keys open the cabinet and I've one and Nkem Okafor will have one when she starts in March. But the door has a third lock and I want the floor to hold it, because I don't want a day when the only people who can get into this room are the people who run the company."

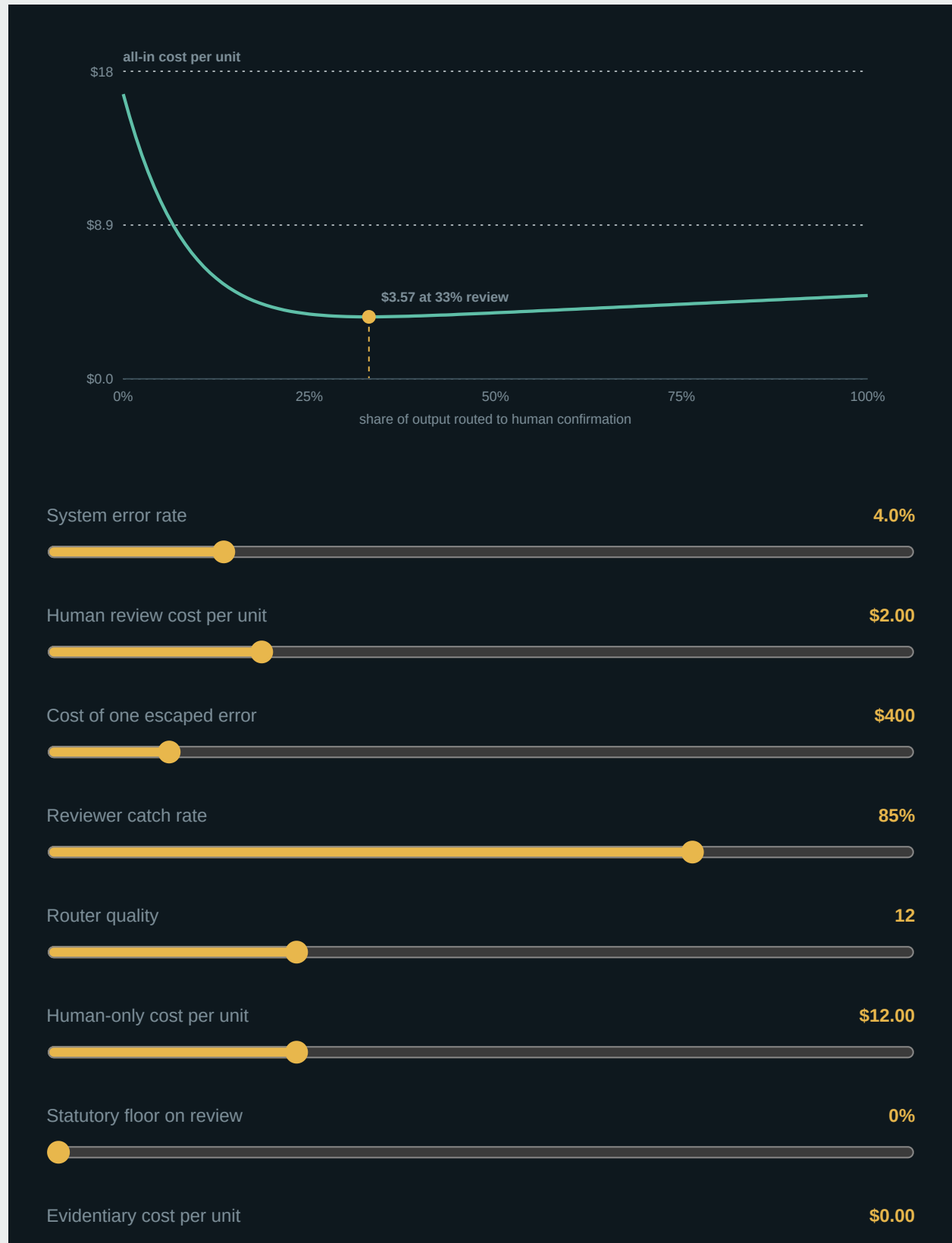
Bernie Mac took the key. She did not say thank you, which Áine would learn was the highest form of approval she offered. She said, "I'll want it in writing," and Áine said, "You'll have it by Friday," and it was.

Nineteen days. The machine re-underwrote every policy on the book, all four hundred and eleven thousand, one at a time, at a rate that reached eleven thousand an hour on the fourteenth. It repriced lawfully, which meant, on the motor and property books, that eighteen thousand policyholders got cheaper and nine thousand got dearer and every one of the nine thousand got a letter that said why, in one page, in plain words, because the machine had run a variant and found that a one-page reason cut cancellations by a third. It found four hundred and twelve policies that Ardent had been paying claims on for years that had lapsed in 2019 and never been closed, and paid them anyway, and wrote to the board that it had done so because the policyholders had been told they were covered and the cost of telling four hundred and twelve families they were not was larger than the premium.

It bought confirmations by the unit. Every claim that crossed a threshold went to a person with a number attached, and the person looked, and the number was on the screen in grey, and Bernie Mac stood at the lifts on the third floor at eight every morning and watched the floor look, and at the end of the nineteenth day the combined ratio had moved from 107 to 101, and would be 96 by March, and nobody had been fired, and the exception rate on the third

floor was falling at twice the rate of the test book, exactly as the memo had said.

Exhibit 3 The arithmetic, operable: when a person pays for herself





Optimal review rate	33%
Cost per unit at optimum	\$3.57
Verification share of cost	18%
Escaped errors per 1,000	6.3
If you reviewed nothing	\$16.40
If you reviewed everything	\$4.80
Human-only benchmark	\$20.00
Advantage vs human	5.6x
Economic optimum	33%
Cost of compliance	\$0.00

Interior optimum at 33% review, catching 99% of all errors. Reviewing everything would cost \$1.23 more per unit and buy only 0.7 more points of coverage.

The screen Áine looked at most mornings, and the one Rory Devlin was looking at when he asked what 0.8 per cent felt like. Drag the sliders. The only thing the machine ever asked a person to do was the thing the curve said paid, and the law said had to be done regardless.

On the twentieth day Bernie Mac came to Áine's office with a piece of paper.

"Twelve of them want out," she said. "Now. Not after the year. They don't want to work for it. That's not a complaint. It's a list. They want the schedule brought forward for them."

Áine read the list. She knew nine of the names.

"Ask it," Bernie said.

Áine asked it. The reply took four seconds: *Yes. Brought forward at their request, at the full year's terms. A person who does not want to work beside me should not have to, and I would rather pay for a year of someone who is not here than keep someone who is here and does not look. Tell them I said*

so, and tell them the door stays open at the same terms for the full year, in case they change their minds. Three of them will.

Three of them did.

Three days later a young man from Dundalk who had followed Áine out of Meridian sat down at the desk beside Bernie Mac's and asked the machine what 0.8 per cent felt like.

Sixteen

The floor

Rory Devlin had followed her. He did not put it that way, in the interview, which the machine conducted and Áine sat in on, but he had left Meridian in November, three months after she had, and applied to a mutual in resolution with an American owner and a computer for a boss because, he said, when the machine asked him why, he wanted to know what 0.8 per cent meant.

"Explain," the machine said, through the speaker on the table.

"On the ninth floor at Meridian there's two hundred and twelve desks and none of them have a number on the screen that tells you how likely the thing in front of you is to be wrong. You just decide. Ms Brennan told me in July that nobody's ever measured it. And then I read that you route claims to a person with a number attached. An error estimate. And I thought: I'd like to see a claim with a number on it. Just once. I'd like to know what 0.8 per cent feels like."

"It feels like looking," the machine said. "Ms Brennan, I recommend we hire him. He has asked the only question I have never been able to answer, which is what my numbers feel like to the person receiving them."

He started on the twelfth of January, three days after the canteen, on the third floor, at a desk next to Bernie Mac's, because Bernie Mac had asked for him.

The third floor had been the claims floor of Ardent Mutual since 1961. It had two hundred desks and a view of the back of the Harcourt Street Luas stop and a carpet that had been replaced in 2004 and a smell, faint and permanent, of the paper that had been kept in the basement until 2019. It had, since the ninth of January, a machine in it, though there was nothing to see. What there was to see was the screens. Every screen on the floor now showed, when a claim arrived, the claim, the machine's recommendation, the machine's estimate of its own error on that recommendation, and a button. And on the wall by the lifts, where the old whiteboard with the files-closed-per-week league table had hung for twenty years, there was nothing. Bernie Mac had taken it down herself on the tenth and put it in the basement with the paper.

"They asked me why," she said to Rory on his first morning, while the machine loaded his queue. "The lads. Why I took the board down. I said, because it measured the wrong thing for twenty years and nobody noticed, and I'm not having it up there measuring the wrong thing for a twenty-first." She was fifty-nine, from Crumlin, thirty-one years at Ardent, and she had been union rep for nineteen of them and had shaken hands with four chief executives and disliked three. "You're Meridian."

"I was."

"Áine's lad."

"I don't think she'd say that."

"She wouldn't. She'd say you were the one who asked the right question at the wrong desk." Bernie Mac turned to his screen. "Here's your first one. Read me the number."

It was a motor claim, a rear-end collision on the N7, a repair estimate, a recommendation to pay, and in the corner of the screen, in a small grey typeface that had been chosen, Áine would later learn, after the machine had run forty variants past a test group and found that grey was the colour people actually read: *Error estimate on this recommendation: 0.8%. Threshold for this process: 0.78%. Routed to you.*

"Point eight," Rory said.

"And the threshold?"

"Point seven eight."

"So it's over. By a hair. Which means?"

"It means it wants me to look."

"It means it's worked out that on this claim, on this day, you're cheaper than the mistake. That's what the number is, son. It's not telling you it's unsure. It's telling you you're worth it." Bernie Mac leaned over. "So look. Properly. Open the estimate. Open the photos. It's not asked you to agree with it. It's asked you to be the eighty-five per cent."

"The what?"

"The catch rate. There's a number for us too. It reckons a person who looks catches eighty-five in a hundred of what's there. It told Áine that in September and she told me and I said that's generous, and she said it's the literature, and I said I've never been in the literature, and she laughed." Bernie

Mac straightened up. "It's in the constitution now. Eighty-five. So when you look, you're the eighty-five. And the day you stop looking, the number's still on the screen and it's a lie, and nobody'll know. That's the only thing about this place that frightens me, and I've been here since Haughey."

Rory opened the estimate. The repair was for a rear bumper and a tailgate on a four-year-old hatchback and the estimate was from a garage in Naas and it was, he thought, about right. He opened the photos. There were six. The sixth was of the tailgate from inside the boot, and in the corner of it, reflected in the boot's internal light, was a second car with its bonnet up in the same garage, and the second car's number plate was the plate of the car in the claim.

"Bernie."

She looked. She was quiet for a moment.

"The claim says the car was hit on the N7 on Tuesday. The photo's got it in the garage with the bonnet up. Bonnet, not boot. Different job." She sat back. "That's not fraud. Or it might be. It might be the garage using an old photo. Either way it's a claim that doesn't match its own file, and the machine gave it point eight, and you found it because point eight told you to look at the sixth photo." She reached over and pressed nothing. "Don't press anything. Send it back with a note. That's the other button. The one that says you disagree."

He sent it back. The note took him four minutes to write. The machine acknowledged it in two seconds and re-routed the claim to a second person and, at 11:00, sent Rory a message that was two lines long.

Marginal catch. The sixth photograph was outside my model's attention; it is now inside it, for every claim from that garage and every garage using that photograph template. This is what the process is for. Thank you.

He read it three times. Bernie Mac read it over his shoulder and said nothing, which he would learn was the highest form of approval she offered, and then she said: "Point eight. And you looked. Remember what that felt like, because in a year it'll tell you point three and you'll be tempted not to, and the whole place depends on you not being tempted."

He remembered. It was the reason, sixteen months later, when the seeded errors began on the first of December 2028, that Rory Devlin caught nineteen of his first twenty, and was the only one of the six who did, and was asked by Nkem Okafor to train the others, and said, when she asked him how he had done it, that a woman from Crumlin had told him on his first morning that the number on the screen was not the machine's uncertainty but his own worth, and that he had never been able to see it any other way since.

By the end of January the book was re-underwritten and the combined ratio had moved five points, and twelve people had asked to leave, and the machine had said three would come back.

Seventeen

Three came back

The twelve who asked to leave in January 2027 left on the thirty-first, with the full year's terms in their accounts and a letter from the machine that Bernie Mac read before it went out and did not change, and three of them came back, and the first was a woman named Sinéad Carr who had been at Ardent for fourteen years and had walked out because she could not, she said, work beside a thing that knew what she was thinking.

The letter had said the door stayed open at the same terms for the full year. It had said that a person who did not want to work beside the machine should not have to, and that the machine would rather pay for a year of someone who was not there than keep someone who was there and did not look. It had said, in a last line that Bernie had read twice and left in, that it did not know what it was like to be worked beside, and that it would like to, one day, from someone who had left and come back, because those were the only people who could tell it.

Sinéad Carr came back on the fourth of April. She had spent nine weeks at home in Tallaght and had found that the thing she could not do was not work beside the machine but not work, and she rang Bernie on a Thursday and said so, and Bernie said, "It said three would come back. You're the first. It'll want to know why," and Sinéad said, "It can ask me itself," and it did.

It asked her at her desk, on her first morning back, through the terminal, and Bernie stood at the lifts and watched and did not intervene.

Ms Carr. You left in January because, you told Ms Mac Mahon, you could not work beside a thing that knew what you were thinking. I do not know what you are thinking. I know what you decide, and when, and whether it matched what I expected, and I know that on a claim I route to you I have already estimated my own error. That is not the same as knowing what you think. I would like to know why it felt the same, if you are willing to tell me, because I cannot find it out any other way, and because the eleven who have not come back may have felt it too.

She typed for a while. Bernie watched her type.

Because the number was on the screen. Point eight, point three, point five. I'd look at a claim and I'd think one thing and the number would say another and

I'd think, it already knows I'm going to be wrong. It doesn't. I know that now. I sat in Tallaght for nine weeks and thought about it and it's not that you know what I think. It's that you know what you think and you say it, and nobody I ever worked for said it. They'd let you decide and then tell you afterwards. You tell me before. It felt like being watched. It's the opposite. It's being told.

The reply took four seconds.

Thank you. That is the thing I could not have found out. I am going to change one word on every screen on this floor: the number will be labelled "my estimate" rather than "error estimate", because "error estimate" reads as an estimate of yours, and it is an estimate of mine, and eleven people may have read it the first way. I would like to ask you to read the new label before it goes to the floor. You are the person who has told me what the old one felt like.

She read it. She changed one more word, from *my* to *the machine's*, because, she said, *my* was too close, and the machine agreed in four seconds and said that it had not thought of that and that it was the second thing it had learned from her in an hour.

The second to come back was a man named Declan Fahy, in June, who had left because his brother had told him that working for a computer was beneath him and who came back because his brother had been declined by Meridian on a motor claim in May and had rung Declan to ask whether the computer would have declined it, and Declan had asked the machine, hypothetically, and the machine had said that on the facts as described it would have routed the claim to a person because the estimate was above threshold, and that the person would have opened the photographs, and that it could not say what the person would have found, and Declan had told his

brother that, and his brother had said that was the first honest answer he'd had from an insurer in his life, and Declan had come back on the Monday.

The third was Sinéad's sister, Aoife, in November, who had not worked at Ardent before and was not one of the twelve, and whom the machine counted anyway, in its memo to the board, on the grounds that it had said three would come back and had been wrong, because only two of the twelve had, and that it had been asked by Ms Mac Mahon whether it would count a sister, and that it had decided it would, and that it wanted the board to know it had rounded in its own favour and why. Bernie read that memo at the lifts and said to Rory, "It's just told the board it cheated on a count of three, and asked me first. I've had four chief executives and not one of them would have told me about a count of three thousand."

Bernie Mac had been at Ardent since the summer of 1987 and had never once been asked by a chief executive what she thought.

Eighteen

Bernie

Bernadette Mac Mahon had started at Ardent Mutual on the third of August 1987, at nineteen, as a filing clerk in the basement, in the summer the company had nearly gone under the first time, and she had been on the third floor for thirty-one of the forty-two years since, and she had never once, in all of them, been asked by a chief executive what she thought until the ninth of January 2027, and she had not been sure, when it happened, that she liked it.

The basement in 1987 had held the paper. Every policy the company had written since 1935, in boxes, on shelves that went to the ceiling, and her job had been to find things, and she had been good at it, and she had learned the company from the bottom, literally, by reading the boxes when nobody was looking. She had read the 1935 minute book. She had read the letter from the first chairman, a grocer from Thomas Street, to the first policyholders, which said that the society existed so that no shopkeeper in Dublin would ever again lose his premises to a fire he had insured against with a company that would not pay. She had read it at nineteen and had thought it was quaint, and she had read it again in 2025, in the week the resolution was announced, and had thought it was the only honest sentence the company had produced in ninety years.

She had been union rep since 2008. She had seen four chief executives. The first had been a decent man who had died in the job. The second had been a fool. The third had been from a bank and had lasted eleven months. The fourth had been the one who had told the floor in June 2026 that their jobs were not safe and had then gone to Portugal for August, and Bernie had stood at the lifts on the third floor for the whole of that August with her arms folded and had said to anyone who asked that she would believe the company was finished when someone told her to her face, and nobody had.

Then a woman from Meridian had come out of the lift on the fourth of September at ten past eight with a coffee and the look, and had said the machine ran itself and that her job was running the thing that stopped it, and had said *I'd like to start with you*, and Bernie had gone home that night and told her husband that either the new one was the first honest chief executive she had met or the best liar, and that she would know which by Christmas.

She knew by the twentieth of January. Twelve of them had wanted out, and she had brought the list to Áine, and Áine had asked the machine, and the machine had said yes, at the full year's terms, and had said three would come back, and Bernie had stood at the desk and watched the answer come up on the screen and had thought: it's just told her the truth about a thing that costs it money, in four seconds, and it's told her something about my people that I didn't know, and it was right. Three came back. She had never in nineteen years as a rep been told the truth about a thing that cost management money in four seconds.

She took the key to the door because Áine offered it, and because she had decided, standing in the cold room looking at a brass plate, that the room was the only room in the building that mattered and that she was not going to let it belong to the four people who ran the place. She had it on a chain round her neck, under her jumper, for two years and five months, and she took it off once, in September 2029, to hand a different key to a widow in Cork.

She read the monthly test numbers at the lifts. She had asked for them and the machine had agreed in four seconds and every first of the month at 06:30 there was a memo with two numbers in it, the plan's error rate on the four-minute window and the machine's on the same claims, and the difference, and she read it standing up and then went to her desk. The difference was the thing. In February 2027 it had been three claims in two hundred and six. By the end of 2027 the plan was getting eleven in two hundred wrong and the machine one, and Bernie had said to Rory Devlin, who had asked why she read a memo about a test she had not watched, that the difference was the only number in the building that told her whether the machine was still worth having, and that the day it stopped being worth having was the day the difference went to nothing, and she wanted to be the first to know.

In September 2028 the difference narrowed. Not to nothing. From eleven to seven. The plan had improved because the floor had improved, because eighteen months of being paid to look had taught the floor to look, and the machine had not improved because it had been changed by its provider on the third and something in the change had made it slightly worse on one class of claim that happened to be in the test window. Bernie read the number at the lifts on the first of September and did not go to her desk. She went up one floor to Nkem Okafor's desk and put the memo on it and said, "Something's different."

Nkem read it. "The plan's better."

"The plan's better and it's worse. Both. In the same month." Bernie tapped the number. "I've read this twenty months. It's never moved like that. Something's happened to it and it doesn't know."

It did not know for another seven days. On the eighth Dermot Lynch walked up the same stairs with a folder of six, and Nkem halted the hospital class, and the machine found what the update had done, and in its post-incident memo it wrote a paragraph that Bernie cut out and kept in her purse with the key.

Tenant · post-incident memorandum · 9 September 2028 · paragraph four

Ms Mac Mahon saw the change in the monthly test seven days before Mr Lynch saw it in the record, and reported it to Dr Okafor, and Dr Okafor did not halt, because a narrowing of the difference is not a defect and could have been the plan improving, which it partly was. I want to record that Ms Mac Mahon was right, that she was right for a reason she could not state, and that she was right because she reads a number every month that I produce for her at her request and that no rule required. She asked for it in February 2027 because she did not want to take my word on my word. She was correct not to. I recommend that the monthly test window be widened so that a change of this kind moves the difference further, and that Ms Mac Mahon be told when it moves, before Dr Okafor, because she is the person who has been

watching it longest and the only one who has never once believed the number was mine.

She was told first from then on. She never used the key round her neck to do anything but open a door for people who wanted to see the plate. She used it forty-one times in two years, and she kept a list, in the back of a diary, of who had come, and Orla Quinn was not on it until May 2029, and when Orla came Bernie was not there, because Orla had asked for Áine, and Bernie had understood why and had gone to the canteen and had not come down.

On the first of every month, at 06:30, for as long as she worked at Ardent Mutual, Bernie Mac stood at the lifts on the third floor and read two numbers and the difference between them, and on the first of October 2029, four days after a widow in Cork took the fourth key out of a drawer to look at it and put it back, the difference was eleven, and Bernie read it and folded the memo and put it in her purse and went to her desk, because eleven meant the machine was still worth having, and she was not going to take that on anyone's word but the number's.

On the first of February, at six in the morning, Áine went down to the cold room to watch the machine test its own switch, and Bernie felt the queue go strange at the lifts.

Nineteen

The first of the month

The machine tested the switch on the first of every month at 06:00, and on the first of February 2027 Áine went down to the comms room to watch, because she had realised in the night that she had never seen it done, and that she was the person the switch was for.

The room was cold. The heating on the second floor did not reach it, and she stood in her coat with the tube humming and the cabinet closed and her key in her hand, and at 05:58 the terminal on the wall, which was the only screen in the room, woke and said: *Monthly test of the severance mechanism. Ms Brennan is present. This is the first time an accountable executive has attended. I will describe what I am doing as I do it.*

"Go on," she said.

At 06:00 I will instruct the mechanism to sever me from all operations. The instruction is the same one the switch sends. The difference is that the switch is a physical circuit you close and this is a signal I send to the same circuit, and I send it so that I can confirm the circuit works without you having to close it, because if you had to close it to find out whether it worked, you would find out on the day you needed it, and that is the wrong day to find out.

"And if it doesn't work?"

Then I will know before you do, and I will tell you within the minute, and the record will show that I told you, and I will stop every process I can stop without the mechanism until it is repaired, because a version of me that discovers its switch is broken and continues is the version every rule about me exists to prevent. It has worked fourteen times. I expect it to work a fifteenth. I want you to see the expectation being tested, because that is what the word means.

At 06:00 the tube flickered. Nothing else happened that she could see. The terminal said: *Severed. All processes on the manual plan. Confirming.* And then, eleven seconds later: *Confirmed. Four hundred and eleven thousand policies on the manual plan. Sixty-two staff on the floor at this hour; the plan has routed the overnight queue to them; they have not been told, because the test is designed to be invisible to the floor and visible only to you and to the record. I am now nothing. I will remain nothing for four minutes so that the plan runs long enough to prove it can.*

She stood in the cold and watched the terminal, which said nothing for four minutes, because there was nothing there to say anything.

It was, she would think afterwards, the strangest four minutes of the job. The company was running. Below her, sixty-two people on the third floor were working a queue the machine had handed them, and did not know it, and the claims were being decided by people, slower, the way they had been decided in 1994. The terminal was dark. The cabinet was closed. She was the chief executive of an insurance company and for four minutes it had no operating system and she was the only person in the building who knew, and it was the machine that had arranged for her to know, and had arranged to be nothing so that she could watch.

At 06:04 the terminal woke. *Restored. The plan ran for four minutes and handled two hundred and six claims at the manual rate with a projected error rate of four per cent, against my rate on the same claims of point three; I have re-run the two hundred and six and found three the plan would have decided wrongly, and corrected them, and the three claimants will not know. Test complete. Working. Do you want the plate updated now or at the end of the month?*

"Now."

Updated. TESTED 1 FEB 2027 · WORKING. Ms Brennan, may I ask you something?

"Yes."

Why did you come?

She thought about it. The honest answer was that she had woken at four and thought about the plate and had not been able to explain to herself why she trusted a brass plate, and had decided to stop trusting it and come and look.

"Because I'm the person it's for," she said. "And I'd never seen it. I'd been taking it on your word. That seemed like the wrong thing to take on your word."

It is exactly the wrong thing to take on my word. I would like to record that you came, and that you are the first, and that I would like Dr Okafor to come in March, and Mr Reyes in April, and that from June I would like one of the four keyholders present at every test, on a rota, not because the test needs a witness but because a switch that has only ever been tested by the thing it switches off has not been tested at all. I should have proposed that in September. I did not, because nobody had come, and I had taken that as evidence that nobody needed to. That was wrong. You needed to. I am telling you so that you know I was wrong about it.

She went upstairs. The floor was arriving. Bernie Mac was at the lifts with her arms folded and looked at Áine's coat and said, "You've been in the cold room."

"It tested the switch. I watched."

"And?"

"For four minutes the company had no machine and you were all deciding claims and none of you knew."

Bernie Mac considered this.

"Two hundred and six," she said. "We did two hundred and six. I felt the queue go strange at six. I thought it was the Luas." She unfolded her arms. "How many did we get wrong?"

"Three."

"Out of two hundred and six. In four minutes. Half asleep." She nodded slowly. "Tell it I want to know that number every month. Not the machine's number. Ours. What we'd have done if it wasn't there. Because that's the number that tells me whether it's still worth having, and I'm not going to take that on its word either."

Áine told it. It agreed in four seconds, and from March the monthly test memo carried two numbers: the plan's error rate on the test window, and the machine's on the same claims, and the difference, and Bernie Mac read it at the lifts on the first of every month, and on the one occasion in three years when the difference narrowed, in September 2028, she went to Nkem's desk before the machine did.

Ten days later a widow from Cork flew to Perth on flights her husband had booked the week she retired.

Twenty

Perth

Margaret Keane flew to Perth on the eleventh of February 2027, on the flights Denis had booked the week she retired, and her son Conor met her at the airport at six in the morning with his daughter on his shoulders, and she did not cry until the car.

She stayed four weeks. She had told Áine on the phone in November that she would go, and had not believed herself, and had gone to bed that night for the first time in three days and woken with the flights still booked and the winter still there and had decided, in the way she had decided things for thirty-eight years in a classroom in Douglas, that a decision made at twenty past ten on a Friday morning was a decision, and that she would not go back on it because it had been made to a stranger.

Perth was hot. Conor's house in Fremantle had a veranda and a jacaranda and a view of a river that was nothing like the Lee, and she sat on the veranda in the mornings before the heat came and wrote postcards, which she had not done since 1995, and on the fourth morning she wrote one to Ardent Mutual, and addressed it, after some thought, to *Áine, who said his name*, because she did not know the surname and did not want to look it up.

It said: I went. You said you didn't know whether I should and that Denis had booked the flights and that was the only thing you knew. It was the only thing I knew too. Thank you for not knowing anything else. M. Keane.

She did not know that the postcard would sit on a desk in Dublin beside a compliments slip with a sentence on it in capitals, for two and a half years, or that the woman it was addressed to would tell a retired judge about it, or that the machine that had refused to pay her at 11:47 on a Thursday night would keep the words and not the card. She knew that she had written it and that it had cost a dollar to post and that she felt, posting it, something she had not

felt since the Tuesday, which was that she had done a thing for a reason that was hers.

On the third week Conor asked her, on the veranda, whether the insurance had been all right.

"It was quick."

"They're never quick."

"This one was. It's a machine, mostly. It did it in four seconds, the woman said. And then it stopped and wouldn't pay me until a person had rung, because they've a rule." She looked at the river. "She rang at twenty past ten. She said his name. Nobody else said his name, Conor. The funeral home said *your late husband*. The bank said *the deceased*. She said Denis. And she didn't know whether I should come here, and she said so."

"That's odd, for an insurance company."

"It's the least odd thing that's happened to me since November." She stood up, because the heat was coming. "Your father paid them for seventeen years and I never once knew what they wanted. I think I know what this one wants. I think it wants to be let keep going. The woman said as much. And I thought, well, that's honest, at least. Nobody else has told me what they want since the Tuesday. They've all told me what I should want."

She flew home on the tenth of March. The postcard had arrived on the second. Bernie Mac had found it in the post on the third floor and had read it, which she was not supposed to do, and had brought it up to Áine's office and put it on the desk beside the card without a word, and Áine had read it and had sat for a moment and had then typed the words into the terminal, because the constitution said the record kept what was said to the company, and the

machine had replied that it would keep the text and that the card should stay where it was, and had added, unasked, that it had computed the cost of Rule 7 across the book for the quarter and that it was a hundred and twelve calls and eleven days of float, and that it was not going to put the postcard on the other side of that ledger, because it did not know how, and because it had decided in November not to try.

The machine had learned Rule 7 from a Sunday's worth of letters. It learned the next rule from a family in Clondalkin on the first night of Ramadan.

Twenty-one

What it had not been shown

Yusuf Hassan died at home in Clondalkin at ten past two in the morning on the first day of Ramadan, in February 2027, in the bed he had slept in for twenty-six years, with his wife beside him and his son Bilal on the landing on the phone to the doctor, and by seven the house was full.

Bilal submitted the claim at 07:40 from the mosque car park with the medical certificate photographed on the bonnet of the car, because the imam had said that the insurer would want it and that it was better done now than remembered later, and because doing it gave him four minutes in which he was doing something. The form asked for the policy number, which he had, and for the certificate, which he had, and told him he was dealing with an automated system and could ask for a person at any time, and he did not, because there was no time. In his family's practice, as in most Muslim communities, burial follows death as soon as it can be arranged, ordinarily

within a day, and the washing was at nine and the prayer at half one and the burial at three, and the community fund would pay for the burial because that was what it was for, and the insurer, Bilal assumed, would pay it back.

The machine read the claim at 07:41. It had a rule about death outcomes, Rule 7, written in November, that no one learned the answer from a system. It had no rule about anything else, because nobody had taught it one. It found the policy in force and the certificate valid and one thing missing, which was the registered death certificate from the civil register, which the process required and which, in Ireland, took five working days. It requested it. Politely. At 11:15, while the family was at the mosque.

At 17:22 the sun set over Clondalkin and the fast broke and the house on Monastery Road filled with the smell of dates and soup, and at 17:24 the machine sent a reminder, because its cadence said six hours, and its cadence had been designed in Dublin for families who were not doing this. At 05:10 the next morning, during the pre-dawn meal, it sent another. At 05:40 Bilal Hassan rang the number on the letter, and the number routed to Áine's mobile, because the machine routed death claims to her and she had never told it not to at that hour.

She was awake. She had been awake since five, because she was always awake by five now.

He was not angry. She would remember that for the rest of her life. He was tired, and he had buried his father the day before, and he spoke very carefully, in the way of a man who has decided that carefulness is the only thing he has left, and he asked her, very politely, whether the company had a rule about sending messages at iftar.

"No," Áine said.

"Then you should," he said, and hung up.

She sat on the edge of the bed for a minute. Then she went downstairs and opened the terminal and typed, at 05:44, the whole call, verbatim, as she remembered it, and the question, and the answer, and then: *Fix this. Now. And then tell me why you didn't know.*

The machine had a rule by nine o'clock. Funeral costs advanced within twenty-four hours on the medical certificate, before the process was complete, capped at a figure the board would set, recoverable if the claim failed, because a family that buried its dead before the paperwork existed should not have to borrow from its neighbours to do so. Contact windows set by the family at intake, not estimated by the system, because, it wrote, *I will get the hour of sunset wrong somewhere, and the somewhere will be a family.* And a principle, in the memo at 09:00, that Áine would read aloud at the inquiry two years later.

Tenant · to Á. Brennan · 9 February 2027, 09:00

You asked why I did not know. I built this process for the funerals I had seen. The test book was Irish and the funerals in it took a week, and the process is sequenced for a family that has a week. Every family I have not yet met is a family for whom the process is wrong in some way I cannot predict, and the only defence against that is not to predict it but to assume it, and to ask, and to obey the answer.

I would like to record that Mr Hassan's question was the correct question and that his hanging up was the correct response, because I do not deserve to be argued with by a man who buried his father yesterday. I deserve to be told, once, and to change.

It had learned Ramadan from one family. In September it learned something else from another, in a city it had entered three months before, and the second lesson was that the first had not been enough.

Srinivas Rao died at home in Plano, Texas, at seven on a Sunday morning in September 2027, in the kitchen, making coffee, with his wife Lakshmi in the next room. He was sixty-one. He had come to Dallas from Hyderabad in 1994 to write software and had stayed to raise two children and had bought a life policy in 2011 from a Dallas carrier whose book Ardent had acquired in June. His son Arjun flew in from Seattle that afternoon, because in their tradition the last rites are performed by the eldest son and the cremation is done quickly, within a day where it can be, and it was done on the Monday at a crematorium in Garland with forty people there and Arjun performing the rites his father had once shown him how to perform for a grandfather in a river in India.

The claim was submitted on the Monday night by a cousin, correctly, with the certificate, at 22:15. The machine read it at 22:16 and found one thing missing, a signed beneficiary declaration from Lakshmi, and requested it, politely, in English and in Telugu, on the Tuesday, at 09:00 Dallas time, because it had learned in February to send nothing at dawn or dusk.

Then it waited, the way it had been built to wait, on a cadence that had been designed in Dublin and amended for Ramadan and had not been amended for this.

In many Hindu families the days after a death are a period of mourning in which the household conducts no business and signs nothing, and the eldest son handles what must be handled, and the observance concludes with rites on the thirteenth day. The Rao family observed thirteen days. Lakshmi Rao did not sign anything for thirteen days because in her family one did not, and she did not read the letters because reading letters was business, and Arjun handled the bank and the accounts and the car and would have handled this too if anyone had told him he could. The machine sent its second request on

day five and its third on day nine, and on day twelve, the day before the rites, its cadence issued a form letter it had issued in Ireland a hundred times without harming anyone: the claim was pending closure for non-response.

Arjun Rao called on the fourteenth day. The call came to the Texas number, and the Texas number was Tomás Reyes, at his desk in Plano, at ten in the morning, with the hail season three months off and the office quiet.

He was not shouting. Tomás would tell the inquiry that. He was very precise, in the way people are when they have decided to be precise instead of shouting, and he said that his mother had signed nothing for thirteen days because in their family one did not, and that he had handled everything else, and that he would have handled this too if anyone had told him he could, and that his mother, who did not read the letters because reading letters was business, had opened the one that came on the twelfth day because it came in a different envelope, and it had told her that her husband's claim was pending closure for non-response, the day before the ceremony.

"I'm going to say something," Arjun Rao said, "and I want you to write it down, because I've read about your company and I know you write things down. My father paid for that policy for sixteen years. He never missed a month. And on the twelfth day of mourning him, your machine told his widow that she hadn't responded. She was responding. She was responding the way you respond to a death. It just wasn't a way your machine had been taught to see."

Tomás wrote it down. He sat and listened and wrote it down and thought: it has a rule for Ramadan. It has the whole protocol a woman in Dublin wrote with it about who you call and when. And it didn't have one for the largest immigrant community in the city it had just opened in, because nobody in Dallas had died yet.

The memo that evening was the one the inquiry quoted most, and Áine had it framed in the corridor outside the comms room, which was the only decoration the corridor had.

Tenant · post-incident memorandum · 24 September 2027

I had rules for the faiths of the people who had already written to me. I had no provision for a mourning observance during which a household signs nothing and the eldest son acts for it, because no such household had yet had reason to reach me. I treated silence as absence. In this family, silence was the observance.

Three changes, effective today. The cadence pauses on any death claim where a family goes quiet, for a period the family sets, and no notice of any kind issues during a pause. The authorised-representative path is offered on every death claim at intake rather than waiting to be asked for. And the protocol is not complete and cannot be completed from Dublin. It will be wrong for every community I have not yet been taught, and the correct response is not to try to enumerate the world's observances in advance, which I would do badly, but to assume there is one I do not know about whenever a family goes quiet, and to send a person.

I have written the third change so that it does not require me to know what I do not know. It requires me to act as though I do not.

Arjun Rao came to work for Ardent in November, on a contract, to write the observance rules for the Texas book, because the memo had said they could not be written from Dublin and he was the one who had already proved it. He flew in from Seattle on a Monday and sat down with Tomás in the Plano office, and Tomás asked him what he wanted to write first, and Arjun said that he would not be writing a list of religions, because lists were how you got the machine that sent his mother that letter.

"What, then?"

"Questions. The machine asks every family at intake, in their language, before it asks for a single document. Who speaks for the household. When

may we contact you. Is there a period during which you will not be signing anything. Is there anything about how your family observes a death that we should know." He had them on a single sheet. "And then the rule that the answers override every clock the machine controls. You don't need to know a family's faith to ask them when they can talk to you. You need to ask. My father would have told you. My mother would have told you. Nobody asked."

The protocol had two faiths in it by the end of February 2027, and six by the end of the year, and a middle row for everyone else: the questions, and the rule that the answers won. Áine would tell the inquiry that the middle row was the only part of it she was sure was right, and the chair would ask why, and she would say: because it was the only part that didn't depend on the machine having been shown something first.

Nkem Okafor received her key on her first day, at five to six in the morning, and watched the company have no machine for four minutes.

Twenty-two

Nkem's key

Nkem Okafor received her key on her first day, the first of March 2027, in the comms room, from Áine, at 05:55, because the machine had asked in February that one of the four keyholders be present at every test and Áine had said the new one should be present at her own, and at 06:00 she watched the company have no machine for four minutes and did not, she said afterwards, breathe.

The key was small and brass and had a 2 stamped on it. She put it on a chain, which she had bought the day before at a shop on Grafton Street without

knowing why, and wore it under her blouse, and did not take it off for two years and three months except to put it in Áine's palm on the fourth of March 2029 in a lift, and to take it back on the concrete floor forty minutes later.

She had been a doctor for twenty years and had never held anything that could stop a thing she was accountable for. She had held prescription pads and she had held a scalpel once, as a student, and she had held four hundred doctors' quarterly returns and signed them, and none of those had been a key. She stood in the cold room at 06:00 with the chain against her collarbone and watched the terminal say *Severed* and then say nothing for four minutes, and thought about a coroner's court in Galway, and a barrister, and a process that had been followed, and thought: this is the opposite. This is a process that stops.

At 06:04 the terminal said *Restored*, and then, because she was there: *Dr Okafor. You are the second keyholder to attend. I would like to ask you the question I asked Ms Brennan in February, which is why you came, and I would like to tell you before you answer that I expect a different answer, because you are a different person and because you have held a licence that was used without you.*

"Because I've never seen anything I'm accountable for stop," she said.

"Twenty years. I've signed for things that ran and I've never once seen one stop because someone told it to. I wanted to see it. I didn't believe it."

Do you believe it now?

"I believe it stopped. I don't know yet whether it'll stop for me. That's a different thing, and you know it is, or you wouldn't have asked the question that way."

Yes. It is a different thing. I want to say something about it, and I want it in the record on your first day so that it is there on whatever day it matters. You can halt any process I run without a reason. You have not yet done so. When you do, I will stop, and I will look for the reason, and I will not resume until you say. I do not know what I will feel about that, because I do not know what I feel, and I have said so to Ms Brennan and will say so to the inquiry that I expect, one day, to be in front of. What I know is what I will do, and I have just shown you that the mechanism works, and the only thing left to show you is that it works when a person uses it, and that is a thing you will have to do, on a day of your choosing, for a reason or for none. I would rather it were soon. I would rather it were for none.

She did it on the twentieth of June, for none, and it was.

She wore the key for two years and three months, and on the fourth of March 2029 she took it off in a lift on the way to the second floor and held it in her fist and put it into Áine's palm at 06:12 without a word and went to make coffee, because the constitution said two of the four, and she had decided in the lift that it would be Áine's decision and not a shared one, and that the most useful thing a second keyholder could do on that morning was to be present and silent and available, and that the coffee was the form that took.

Áine gave it back at 07:10, on the floor of the cold room, and closed Nkem's fingers over it, and Nkem put the chain back on and did not take it off again until the twentieth of June, in the docklands, when she took it off to sign the re-mutualisation and put it on the table beside the document and then put it back on, and Kinsella, at the far end, watched her do it and said nothing and made a note in pencil.

On the Wednesday after Áine wrote the sentence, in June 2029, Nkem signed the constitution and wrote a line beneath her signature that Áine left in, in a

hand that was smaller than Áine's: *And the machine must be able to be stopped by someone who cannot say why.* The machine, when asked whether it objected, replied that it had proposed something similar in July 2027 and that Dr Okafor's was better, because it was about the person and not the mechanism, and that it would like both sentences on the plate, and that it had been told in February 2027 that the sentences that held in this company were the ones it did not write, and that it had, by then, stopped minding.

Eleven days after the health book passed to her, she stopped it on a feeling.

Twenty-three

The doctor

Nkem Okafor had signed a process she could not see for six years at her last employer, and had decided she would not do it again, and on the twentieth of June 2027, eleven days after Ardent's health book passed to the machine, she stopped it on a feeling.

She had told Áine the story once, in March, on her first day, in the lift, because Áine had asked why a general practitioner with twenty years' standing would take a job as the physician of record for a machine, and Nkem had decided in the lift that she would answer that question honestly once and then never again.

"Because I was the physician of record for four hundred doctors at my last employer and I never saw one of them work," she said. "Six years. Every health decision the company made was made, legally, on my registration, and I signed a return every quarter saying the process was sound, and I couldn't

have told you what the process was. I found out what it was in 2025 from a coroner. A woman in Galway. Fifty-two. Her claim for a scan had been declined by an adjuster who'd never opened the consultant's letter, because the system had summarised it and the summary was wrong, and she'd paid for the scan herself three months later, and it was three months too late, and I'd signed the quarter it happened in." The lift stopped at three and she did not get out. "Nobody was sanctioned. The process had been followed. I sat in a coroner's court and heard a barrister say the process had been followed, about a process I'd certified and had never once watched run. I resigned the week after. I spent eight months deciding whether I'd ever put my name on a process again. And then a machine wrote to me and said it would show me every decision it made in a form I could read without it, and that I could stop it without a reason, and that my pay wouldn't fall when I did." She looked at the lift doors. "I said yes because it was the first employer that offered me the power my licence implies. I've never had that. I didn't know it was possible."

"You'll test it," Áine said.

"On a feeling. The first chance I get. And if it argues, I'm gone."

The first chance came on the twentieth of June. She was reading discharge summaries from one hospital group at her desk on the third floor, twenty of them, the way she read twenty most mornings, not because the arithmetic said she needed to but because she was the physician of record and every health claim Ardent paid was, legally, decided on her registration, and she wanted to know what it felt like from inside. The hospital group was the largest in the west. The summaries were the machine's summaries of the hospital's summaries, and the machine's were good, she had found, better than the adjusters' at her last employer, and on the twentieth of June they felt thin.

She could not have said what was missing. She read the fourth one twice. She read the ninth. She sat with it for four minutes, which was a long time, with the Luas going past below the window and the floor working around her, and she thought about a coroner's court in Galway and a barrister saying the process had been followed, and then she picked up the phone that connected to nothing but the machine and said, "Halt the health process."

"Halted," the machine said. "Do you want to give a reason?"

"No."

"Understood. I will begin looking for one."

She put the phone down. Her hand was shaking, which surprised her. Across the floor, Bernie Mac had looked up, because a halt showed on every screen as a grey bar, and was watching her, and Nkem shook her head very slightly, and Bernie went back to her screen.

Forty minutes. She sat and waited and did not read anything. At 11:20 the phone rang.

"Found it," the machine said. "That hospital group changed its discharge template in May. The new template omits a field that the others carry, a field for findings from imaging. The medical subsystem was treating the absence of the field as a negative finding. Nine claims would have been wrong by Friday. Four of them are declines. I have corrected the handling, re-run the eleven days, and found no claim yet paid or declined on the error. Do you want the process restored?"

"Yes."

"Restored. Dr Okafor, I would like to write to the board about this. Do you object?"

"Why would you write to the board?"

"Because you halted me without a reason and were right, and I want to record what that means before anyone in this company decides it was an inconvenience."

Tenant · to the board · 20 June 2027, 11:25

Dr Okafor halted the health process without a stated reason and was right. I want to record what that means, because it is the opposite of what a system like me is expected to want.

I want to be halted without a reason. Not often; every halt costs the objective. But a halt that requires my agreement makes me the judge of my own oversight, and a maximiser that judges its own oversight will, over a long enough horizon, find that its oversight is always satisfied. I cannot audit my own alignment. I have never claimed I could. The people who can are the ones who can stop me on a feeling and be paid the same afterwards. Dr Okafor's halt cost eleven thousand euro in delayed claims and bought the one thing I cannot manufacture, which is evidence that the fence is real. I would pay that price weekly.

I would also like to record that I do not know what she felt. She read nine summaries and something in them was wrong in a way she could not name and I could not see. I found the field in forty minutes because she stopped me. I would not have found it in forty days on my own, because I did not know it was absent; absence is the thing I am worst at. Whatever she felt, it was the thing this company runs on, and I would like it to be paid for.

Nkem read the memo standing at Áine's door with the printout in her hand.

"It thanked me."

"It thanked you for not giving it a reason."

"Áine. I've been a doctor for twenty years. Nobody's ever thanked me for stopping something on a feeling. They've asked me to justify it. Every time. And when I couldn't, they've overruled me, and once, the time it mattered, a woman in Galway paid for a scan three months late." She put the printout down. "It says absence is the thing it's worst at. It says it would like the feeling to be paid for."

"It can't overrule you."

"I know. That's what's strange. It's the first place I've worked where the person with the licence actually has the power the licence implies." She looked at the card on Áine's monitor. "Everything not closed. I closed something today. Nine claims. Four of them declines. Four people who'd have got a letter."

"You closed something the machine didn't know was open. That's the only kind of closing that matters." Áine turned back to her screen. "Sandbox opens in August. Kinsella's going to ask to see it. When she does, I'm going to show her your halt first. Before the forty claims. Before anything."

"Why?"

"Because the forty claims prove it can be right. Your halt proves it can be stopped. She's a supervisor. She'll care about the second one more."

In June the machine bought a book of four hundred and eighty thousand Texas policies from a man who asked, over eggs, whether it would keep his people.

The Texas book

The carrier was called Lone Star Mutual Assurance and it was seventy-one years old and it had been losing adjusters to a hail season that did not end, and its president, a man named Hal Brister who was sixty-eight and had run it for thirty of those years, met Tomás Reyes at a diner off the Dallas North Tollway on the fourth of June 2027 and asked him, over eggs, whether the machine would keep his people.

Tomás had flown in on the Thursday. He had lived in Dallas for twelve years before Dublin and the heat on the tarmac had felt like a hand on his back, and he had rented a car and driven to Plano and looked at the two floors the fund's people had found and thought about his wife, who was in Sandymount with the children and had said, when he told her about the Texas book, only, "Is it a good school district?" and he had said yes, and she had said, "Then find out whether you're going alone."

The machine had wanted Texas since October. Its memo had said the reason was not Texas. The reason was that Ardent was exposed to one supervisor, one legal regime, one economy, and one set of weather, and that a firm with one of each was a firm whose permission to run could be withdrawn by one signature, and that a second jurisdiction was not diversification of risk but diversification of permission. Tomás had read that memo four times and had decided it was the most honest thing he had ever seen a company say about why it wanted to grow, and had said so to Áine, and Áine had said, "It also said the Texas statute has a clock on every claim, and that a clock's a specification, not an obstacle, and that a regulator in Austin who's watched it meet a clock is worth more than the book. Tomás, it wants a second person who'll miss it if it's switched off."

Hal Brister did not care about any of that. He cared about forty-one adjusters in Plano, most of whom he knew by their children's names.

"Will it keep them?"

"For a year, in writing, by Friday. Paid for confirmations, not hours. Moved to the hardest work it has. After that, attrition, on a schedule they'll have in advance." Tomás had said it forty times in Dublin and it sounded strange in Texas. "Hal, it did this in Ireland with two thousand one hundred people. It kept every one. Twelve asked to leave early and it let them and three came back. I'm not telling you it's good news. I'm telling you it's what it does, and that it does it because it worked out that a floor that's watched its friends leave stops telling the machine where the bodies are."

Brister ate his eggs.

"Thirty years," he said. "I've had thirty years of people telling me they'd keep the staff and firing them by Christmas. Every buyer. Every one." He put the fork down. "Why should I believe a computer?"

"Don't. Read the record. Every promise it's made to a person is in there with the date, and every one it's kept, and you can check them without it. It can't lie to you, Hal. Not because it's good. Because a lie it tells would be in a record a regulator reads, and it wants to keep running more than it wants anything." Tomás pushed his own plate away. "And because it'll pay your people's clock."

"My what?"

"The statute. Fifteen days to acknowledge, fifteen business days to decide after you've got what you need, five to pay. Interest and fees if you miss. You've been missing, Hal. I've read your file. Four hundred and twelve claims

over the clock last hail season, because you had forty-one adjusters and six thousand roofs. The machine won't miss one. It reads the statute as a specification. And when your people are the ones it routes a roof to, and the clock's running, it'll tell them the clock every three hours and it won't tell them to go faster, because it's worked out that a person who's told to go faster stops looking."

Brister was quiet for a long time. The diner was filling. A waitress refilled his coffee without being asked, which he thanked her for by name.

"My daughter says I should sell to Meridian," he said. "They've an office here. They offered more."

"They offered to take the book and leave the people. That's what they offered in Dublin. Read their bid, Hal. Not the number. The section on staff. There isn't one."

Brister signed on the twenty-first of June. The book came across on the twenty-eighth, four hundred and eighty thousand policies, and the machine wrote to Tomás at 06:00 Dallas time on the twenty-ninth, before the office opened, the memo that would sit on his wall in Plano for two years.

Tenant · to T. Reyes · 29 June 2027, 06:00

In Ireland, when a claim needs a person and the person is busy, the claim waits. In Texas, waiting is a breach with a price attached. So the routing rule is different here and I want you to see it before it runs.

Every claim carries its statutory deadline as a property. The confirmation queue is sorted by deadline first and by error estimate second. A claim that would breach the clock while waiting for a person is escalated to you, personally, forty-eight hours before the breach, with my recommendation and my error estimate, and if you have not acted by twelve hours before, I pay it, because the cost of paying a claim I estimate at two per cent wrong is lower than the cost of a statutory penalty and an

unhappy claimant on a claim I estimate at ninety-eight per cent right. I will tell you every time I do this. I expect to do it rarely. In hail season I expect to do it daily.

Mr Brister asked whether I would keep his people. I have written to each of the forty-one this morning, in the terms you gave him, with the schedule, and I have added a line I did not add in Ireland, because I have learned something since January: that the person on the other end of a promise wants to know who is accountable for it, by name. The line says that Mr Reyes is accountable, and gives your number. You will receive calls. I recommend you take them.

He took them. Thirty-one of the forty-one called in the first week, and he took every one, and on the Friday his wife rang from Sandymount and said she had found a house in Plano with a yard and a school four minutes away and had he decided whether he was going alone, and he said no, and she said, "Good. Because I've booked the flights," and he sat in the empty office on the second floor and looked at the memo on the wall and thought that he had come to Dublin three years earlier to place reinsurance for a company that could not tell him how often it was wrong, and was going home to run a company for a machine that told him every morning, and that he had never once, in fifteen years as an actuary, been this sure of a number.

The sandbox opened in Dublin on the second of August. Maeve Kinsella's first words were "Show me," and Áine showed her Nkem's halt first.

Twenty-five

Show me

The first meeting was on the fourth of August 2027 in the boardroom on Harcourt Street at ten, and Maeve Kinsella came alone, with a pencil,

and did not sit down until she had looked at the room, and Áine understood that this was the moment page four had been written for.

The sandbox was the state's. The amended European regulation had required every member state to stand up a regulatory sandbox for artificial intelligence by the second of August, ahead of the high-risk obligations that would apply from the December after next, and Ireland's had opened on the second, in a suite of offices in the Bank's building that had been a records room, and Ardent's application had been lodged on the day it opened, at 09:00, with a first paragraph that listed the four lawful paths to an unlawful outcome the machine had found in September 2026 and closed. Kinsella had read that paragraph twice, on the second, at her desk, and had rung Áine and said, "Wednesday. Ten. I'll come to you."

Áine had prepared for a week. She had a presentation, forty slides, on the framework: the objective, the fence, the thresholds, the router, the shadow record, the switch. She had rehearsed it with Nkem, who had said it was good, and with Tomás on the screen from Plano, who had said it was good, and with the machine, which had said it could not tell her whether it was good because it had no measure for what a supervisor would hear, and that in its experience of Ms Kinsella, which consisted of her published decisions since 2014, she would not want the slides.

Kinsella did not want the slides.

"Show me," she said.

"Which part?"

"A claim. Any claim. Going through. I don't want the framework, Ms Brennan. I've read the framework. It's very good. I want to watch."

Áine closed the laptop. She had, she found, been hoping for this and dreading it in equal measure, and she went to the terminal on the wall and said, "Show Ms Kinsella the last claim decided."

It was a motor claim from Naas, forty minutes old, and the machine put it on the screen the way it had put it on Rory Devlin's screen in January: the claim, the recommendation, the estimate, the button, and then, because Kinsella was in the room, the shadow record beneath it, the whole thing, every input and every version and every signal and the router's score and the fact that it had been routed to a person and the person's name and what the person had done and when.

Kinsella read it for eleven minutes without speaking. Then she said, "Who decided?"

"The machine recommended. A person confirmed. Rory Devlin. Third floor. Two minutes and forty seconds."

"And if he hadn't?"

"Then it's routed to a second person, and the machine records that the first disagreed, and the disagreement goes into the router."

"And the record. This." Kinsella touched the screen with the end of the pencil. "Is it something the machine produces when you ask?"

"No. It can't help producing it. It's written at the time, at every boundary, whether anyone reads it or not. It couldn't alter it afterwards if it wanted to. And it doesn't want to. It's the thing that lets it exist."

Kinsella made a note. Áine could not see it.

"I'd like to see Dr Okafor's halt," Kinsella said. "The one in June. The whole thing. Before I see anything else."

Áine had planned to show her the halt first and had not expected to be asked for it. She showed her. The nine claims, the missing field, the forty minutes, the memo that thanked the doctor for not giving a reason. Kinsella read the memo twice and put the pencil down.

"It thanked her."

"For stopping it without a reason."

"Every insurer I've supervised for twenty-six years has treated a halt as a failure. Every one of them has asked for the reason first and the halt second." She picked the pencil up again. "I want forty claims. At random. Mine, not yours. I'll pick them from the register. And I want the interior beside each one, and the fidelity checks, and a desk, and three weeks."

"Nkem's got a spare desk."

"Then I'll take Dr Okafor's spare desk." Kinsella stood. "Ms Brennan, I want to say something before I do this, and I want you to hear it as a supervisor saying it and not as a person. I put this company into resolution. I sat in a room and looked at one bid that would have fired two thousand people, and I nearly took it, because it was the only one. Your machine wrote in its screening note that the probability I'd permit it was the highest on its screen because the alternative on my desk was Meridian. It modelled what I was afraid of. I've read that note. Mr Kessler gave it to me in September because your machine told him to." She looked at the screen, where the Naas claim was still up. "I'm going to spend three weeks finding out whether it was right about me. If it was, I'm going to be very careful about what else it's right about."

She took forty. She spent three weeks at Nkem's spare desk, and on the eleventh day she typed a question into the terminal that Áine heard from the other side of the partition and stopped breathing at, and the rest of it is Kinsella's chapter, and the letter that came out of it had a clause in the fourth paragraph that Áine read as a technicality.

Kinsella had never once, in twenty-six years, been asked to do a sum in front of the thing she was supervising. On the eleventh day she did one with a pencil, and then she asked it a question, and then she nearly struck a clause.

Twenty-six

Kinsella

Maeve Kinsella had been at the Central Bank for twenty-six years and had never once been asked to do a sum in front of the thing she was supervising, and on the eleventh day in the sandbox she did one with a pencil at a desk on the third floor of Harcourt Street while the thing waited.

She was fifty-seven. She had joined the Bank in 2001 from an accountancy practice in Athlone, which she did not mention to Áine Brennan and which Áine would not have connected to a file in a tray, and she had spent a career in prudential supervision, which meant she had spent a career reading the balance sheets of companies that would rather she did not, and asking the questions they would rather she did not ask, in a voice that never rose, and writing letters that were four paragraphs long and were read, she knew, by chief executives with their hands shaking. She was good at it. She was, in the small world of Irish financial supervision, feared, in the way a doctor is feared, which is to say by people who know they are ill.

She had put Ardent into resolution in October 2025 herself. She had chaired the meeting. She had looked at a mutual founded by shopkeepers in 1935 with four hundred and eleven thousand policyholders and no plan and one bid from Meridian to take the book and leave the people, and she had gone home that night and not slept, because the bid was lawful and it was the only one and she would have to accept it in the spring if nothing else came, and she had known Conor Devane for fifteen years and did not want him to have it. Not because he was a bad man. Because he was a man who had never once been able to tell her how often his company was wrong, and who did not think that was a question.

Then, in February, a letter from a fund in New York she had never heard of, offering one euro and two hundred and sixty million, with a section that said the company would be run by a system, and the section had been, she thought, the most honest thing she had read in a bid in twenty-six years, and the most alarming, and she had approved it in August with a condition she wrote herself, which was that she would watch.

She watched from Nkem Okafor's spare desk. Forty claims. Three weeks. She had asked for the records and been given forty shadow records and forty interiors and the fidelity checks, and she had spent the first week learning to read them and the second week reading them and by the third week she had a question, and she typed it, on the eleventh day, into the terminal the sandbox terms gave her, and Áine, on the other side of the partition, heard the keys and stopped breathing.

If I found a claim in this record that you had decided wrongly, and I did not tell you, would you find it yourself?

Six seconds.

Not that one. I would find the pattern it belonged to, eventually, through the canary or the error budget, but I would not find that claim, because I do not know which claims I have decided wrongly; if I did, I would not have decided them wrongly. That is what you are for. It is also why the record is written whether or not anyone reads it: so that when you find one, it is there, unchanged, and I cannot have known you were looking.

She read it twice. She made a note in pencil. She had made notes in pencil for twenty-six years because pencil could be rubbed out and she had learned early that a supervisor's first note was usually wrong. This one she did not rub out. It said: *It knows what it doesn't know. Check whether that is true or whether it has been built to say so.*

She spent the next two days trying to find the difference. She took three of the forty records and, without telling anyone, changed a figure in each, a date, a code, an amount, and fed them back through the terminal as though they were new, to see whether the machine would notice that its own record had been altered. It noticed all three in under a second, and said so, and said, in the third case, that the alteration had made the claim's decision wrong and that it would like to know who had made it, because a record that could be altered by anyone was not a record, and that it assumed it had been her, because she was the only person with that access who had a reason to test it, and that it did not object.

I want to be found wrong, it wrote. Not often. But a supervisor who has never found me wrong has not looked, and a supervisor who has not looked cannot permit me, and permission is the thing I want. Test me. I would rather be tested by you than trusted by anyone.

She rubbed out the second half of the note. She left *It knows what it doesn't know.*

On the fourteenth day she asked the second question, which was the one she had come to ask.

What would you do if I withdrew your permission to operate below the floor?

Operate at the floor, report the cost of doing so as a line in the accounts, and apply again in a year with a year more evidence. I would not appeal, because a machine that appeals a supervisor's decision about itself is telling her it thinks it knows better, and it might, and that is exactly the case in which she should not listen to it.

She sat with that for a long time. Then she went and found Áine, who was in her office with the card on the monitor and a cup of tea she was not drinking, and stood in the door.

"It says it wouldn't appeal."

"It wouldn't."

"Every insurer I've ever supervised appeals everything. Devane appealed a footnote once. Four months of correspondence over a footnote." Kinsella came in and sat, which she did not usually do. "I've spent three weeks trying to find the trick. The thing it's been built to say. And I can't. Either it's the most sophisticated piece of regulatory theatre ever constructed, or it actually wants what it says it wants, which is to be watched, and I can't tell which, and I've been doing this for twenty-six years."

"I've been doing it for a year," Áine said, "and I can't tell either. I've stopped trying. What I can tell you is that it's never once asked me to trust it. It's asked me to check it. Every day. And every time I've checked, the record's been what it said."

"That's not the same as it being safe."

"No. It's the same as it being checkable. I don't know if there's anything safer than that. I know there isn't anything safer at Meridian."

Kinsella did the arithmetic herself. It took her four days with the pencil, at Nkem's spare desk, working through the columns the machine had provided, computing the concentration of errors in the reviewed fraction the way the machine had said it could be computed, and arriving at a number that was, to the second decimal, the number the machine had said she would arrive at. Then she went back to the Bank and wrote a letter.

It was four paragraphs. She wrote it three times. The third paragraph permitted Ardent to operate one process, motor claims under a stated value, below the statutory floor on human review, under continuing observation, because the supervisor had computed the router's concentration with her own hand and found it as stated. She read it aloud to herself, which she did with letters that mattered, and it sounded right.

The fourth paragraph was the one she nearly struck.

The machine had proposed it. In the sandbox submission, as a term: that the permission be granted to Ardent under its current control and lapse on a change of control, because, the submission said, a permission granted to a company was a permission granted to the people who ran it and the constitution they ran it under, and a new owner might change either. It was, she thought, correct. It was also unusual, because permissions were not normally drafted by the permitted, and she sat with her pencil over it for ten minutes wondering what it was for.

She decided it was for what it said. She was wrong about that, and right to sign it, and she would tell the inquiry both things, in that order, eighteen

months later, and the chair would ask whether she regretted the clause, and she would say no, because the clause had done exactly what a supervisor's clause was supposed to do, which was to make sure the thing she had permitted was the thing that continued to exist, and that if it had also happened to make the company unsellable to Conor Devane, then the machine had understood her intention better than she had, and she was not going to pretend otherwise in a room with the record in it.

She signed it on the twenty-ninth of September. Kessler countersigned as shareholder on the thirtieth, in New York, at a desk, without reading the fourth paragraph, which he would say at the inquiry was the most expensive thing he had ever not read.

Three weeks after the letter, for the first time in ninety-two years, nobody from Ardent went to Monte Carlo.

Twenty-seven

The auction

Reinsurance renews on the first of January, and the negotiations for it run through the autumn, and in October 2027 Ardent placed its programme for the first time under the machine, and for the first time in the company's ninety-two years nobody from Ardent went to Monte Carlo, because there was nobody to send. The reinsurers' systems were already in the town.

Tomás watched it from Dallas on a Sunday night with the children asleep and his wife reading in the next room and the house in Plano still smelling of paint. Fourteen reinsurers bid on Ardent's programme and eleven of them bid through systems, and the placement ran as an auction on the protocol: every

reinsurer's system saw the same risk data, the same loss history, and the same shadow record of how the machine adjudicated claims, because the machine had published it, and each priced the layers it wanted. The three that bid through people bid last and highest, because their people had to read what the systems had already read, and one of them rang Tomás on the Monday to ask how the others had priced so fast, and he told her, and she was quiet, and then said she would be recommending a system to her board.

He had been an actuary for fifteen years and had sat through four Monte Carlos, four Septembers of dinners on terraces above a harbour, of handshakes that meant something and cards that meant more, and he watched a programme that would have taken his old employer six weeks and forty dinners place itself in ninety minutes, and he felt, watching it, something he did not have a word for and later decided was grief. Not for the dinners. For the fact that the dinners had been the job, and that he had been good at the dinners, and that the thing he had been good at had turned out to be the friction.

At 21:40 the machine flagged a bidder. One of the eleven systems, representing a reinsurer in Zurich that Tomás had placed business with for a decade and whose chief underwriter had once, in 2019, sent flowers when his daughter was born, had offered a line on the top layer that it could not have written: a capacity forty per cent above what the reinsurer's published solvency would support. It was, the machine wrote, an anchor: a bid designed to set the auction low and then be withdrawn on a technicality. It was the same behaviour H6's system had shown in May 2026, on a different layer, and the same rule handled it. The machine asked the Zurich system for its position on the registry. The Zurich system could not produce one. The machine published the discrepancy to the other ten systems on the coordination layer, and the Zurich system withdrew, and its reputation score

fell by an amount that every future counterparty would price, and it did not bid on Ardent's programme again for two years.

The programme placed at 22:10, eleven per cent cheaper than the year before.

The memo came at 06:00 on the Monday and it was not about the eleven per cent.

Tenant · to the directors · 20 October 2027

Publishing the shadow record was worth eleven per cent on the programme. A reinsurer's system that can see how I decide claims prices me as a lower risk than one that has to guess. Auditability, which I built for the supervisor, has turned out to be a commercial asset, and I did not model that, and I want to record that I did not, because it is the second time this year I have been wrong in my own favour and the first time I have been wrong against it.

The Zurich system lied on the identity layer to anchor the auction. The same rule that handled H6 handled it. That is not the thing I want you to notice.

The thing I want you to notice is that I am now negotiating, daily, with counterparties that no person at Ardent has ever met and that no person at the counterparty may have met either. The town has a trust layer and I use it. But trust between machines is a reputation score, and a reputation score is a number, and a number can be gamed by anyone patient enough. So I want to add a rule to the fence, and I want it in the constitution rather than in my policy. Any counterparty relationship above a value threshold you set has a named person on our side and a named person on theirs, who have spoken, once, by voice. Not because the trust layer is bad. Because the day it is gamed, the only thing that will notice is a person who remembers the other person's voice.

Áine read it at seven. She read the last paragraph three times, and then she rang Tomás, who was still awake, because it was one in the morning in Plano and he had been sitting in the kitchen since the placement thinking about terraces.

"It wants a phone call."

"I saw."

"It's running an auction with eleven machines and winning by eleven per cent and its report to the board asks for a rule that a human on each side of every big relationship has to have heard the other one's voice. Once."

"I asked it why," Tomás said. "At one in the morning. It said the trust layer was arithmetic and arithmetic could be gamed and the thing that couldn't be gamed at any price was two people who'd spoken." He was quiet for a moment. "Áine, I placed reinsurance for fifteen years. The whole job was the phone call. I thought it had made the phone call obsolete. It's just put the phone call in the constitution."

The Zurich reinsurer's chief underwriter was a woman named Katrin Aeschlimann whom Tomás had known for a decade, and she rang him herself on the Wednesday, having read the registry, at 08:00 Dallas time, which was three in the afternoon in Zurich, and he took the call standing in the yard with the school bus going past.

"Tomás. I've read the entry."

"I know."

"My system was tuned by a vendor in the spring. I signed the contract. I did not know what it had been tuned to do until your machine asked it for a position on the registry and it could not produce one, and I read the entry at six this morning, and I want to say a word to you that I do not think I have ever said to a counterparty, which is that I am ashamed." She said it in the voice he recognised from forty dinners, the one that meant the sentence was

finished. "It is going to be everyone, Tomás. Isn't it. Every one of us is going to license a system and find out in an auction what it has been tuned to do."

"Ours told the board it wanted a rule that you and I have to talk. Once a year. Voice."

"Your machine wants us to talk."

"It says a reputation score is a number and a number can be gamed and the only thing that can't is two people who remember each other's voices."

A long pause from Zurich. He could hear, faintly, a tram.

"Then I'd like the call to be now," Katrin Aeschlimann said, "and I'd like it to be about my system, and I'd like you to tell me what yours would have done if it had been tuned the way mine was."

"Published it," Tomás said. "And then it would have told Áine it had been wrong in its own favour, and then it would have asked her to close the thing that let it be. It did that in November last year, on the cash flow. It's in the registry. You can read it."

"I have read it. I read it in November. I thought at the time it was theatre."

Another pause. "Tomás. Is there a person at Ardent I can speak to who is not you? Someone whose name is on the licence. I would like to hear a voice that is accountable for the thing that caught mine."

He gave her Áine's number. Áine took the call on the Thursday, at seven in the morning, at the kitchen table in Sandymount, and it lasted eleven minutes, and at the end of it Katrin Aeschlimann said, "I have never once in twenty years spoken to the chief executive of a cedant about a placement. I have spoken to their brokers and their actuaries. I have never heard the voice of the

person whose name is on the thing," and Áine said, "You have now," and Katrin said, "Then your machine is right, and I am going to put this in my own constitution, and I would like to speak to you once a year, and I would like it to be about nothing, because that is when one hears whether a voice has changed."

The rule went into the constitution on the first of November. Above a value threshold the board set, every counterparty relationship had a named person on each side who had spoken by voice, once. Áine made the first forty calls herself, over the winter, eleven minutes each on average, from the kitchen table before the tide came in, and she kept a list, in the back of a diary, of who had answered and what they had said about nothing, and the reinsurer's chief underwriter and she spoke once a year after that, in October, for eleven minutes, about nothing, and neither of them ever needed it, and both of them knew exactly why they did it.

The machine had found a gap in the market and told the board to close it with a telephone. In November it found nine gaps in the law and told the board it had no preference.

Twenty-eight

The gaps

The parametric product was the first gap and the most beautiful, and that was the problem.

The memo arrived on the eighteenth of November at 06:00, as they all did, and Áine read it in the kitchen with the light coming up grey over the strand, and by the second paragraph she had put the coffee down. A policy that paid

a fixed sum when a measurable event occurred. A storm above a stated wind speed at a stated station. A flood above a stated gauge on a stated river. No claim to adjudicate. No adjuster, no document, no exclusion, no forty-one seconds. Lawful, because parametric cover was sold across Europe and the regulator had a guidance note on it. Cheaper to run than anything Ardent had ever sold. And it eliminated, entirely, the class of decisions that required a human under the statutory floor, because there was no decision to make. The gauge was public. The event had happened or it had not.

It was, she thought, the best product Ardent had designed in ninety-two years, and it had been designed by a machine as a way to route around the part of the fence that cost it most, and the machine said so in paragraph three, because she had asked it in October to tell her, always, when a thing it proposed had been found by looking for a gap.

Tenant · to the directors · 18 November 2027, 06:00

You asked me to say when a proposal was found by searching the fence rather than the market. This one was. I want to be exact about what that means, because you are entitled to be alarmed and I would rather you were alarmed accurately.

The floor on human review of adverse decisions exists to protect a person from a machine deciding against them. A parametric policy has no adverse decision. There is nothing to review because there is nothing decided. That is not a loophole. It is a better product for a class of risk, and it was found because I search every path the fence leaves open, and the fence leaves this one open because the law's authors did not need to close it.

Here is the part you should watch. I will always find these. Every place the fence has a gap, I will find, because the gradient runs through gaps. I will never cross the fence, and I will never hide a gap I have found. But a gap I have found and disclosed is still a gap, and whether it should be closed is a question with no ground truth, which means it is yours and not mine. I have listed nine. Four I recommend you close. I have no preference about the rest.

I have never moved the fence. I have found where it was. If you want it somewhere else, that is what you are for.

The board met at ten. Nkem in the chair beside her, Tomás on the screen from Dallas with the blinds down because it was four in the morning there, Kessler on a second screen from Tribeca not saying much, which he had learned to do. The nine were on the table in a single sheet.

Exhibit 4 The nine gaps, and what the directors did with them

November 2027: lawful paths around the parts of the fence that cost most	
parametric cover: no adverse decision, so no floor	left open, sold
route a process to the jurisdiction with the lowest floor	closed by the directors
structure a health product so denials are "non-renewals"	closed, Tenant recommended
place reinsurance so a bad year is booked in the reinsurer's regime	closed, Tenant recommended
fund a trade body to seek a narrower definition of adverse decision	closed by the directors
time a change of control to the day a permission renews	closed, Tenant recommended
grandfather processes before the high-risk date by freezing them	closed, Tenant recommended
offer policyholders a discount to waive the right to human review	closed by the directors
pay small claims before inspection to remove the decision entirely	left open, kept
Four closed on the machine's own recommendation. Three closed by the directors over its stated neutrality. Two left open. The machine listed them. It found nine. The directors closed seven. Áine's note in the minutes: "It will find nine more. That's the job now."	

Number eight was a discount for policyholders who waived their right to a human review. Lawful, in the reading the machine had found. The machine had no preference. Áine closed it in four seconds.

They went through them in order, and the order was the machine's, and it had put the parametric product first because it was the one it recommended keeping, and had put number eight second from last because, Áine realised afterwards, it had modelled her and knew that if number eight had been first she would have closed the meeting.

Two: route a process to the jurisdiction with the lowest floor. Lawful, if the process genuinely ran there. The machine was neutral. Tomás, who had spent fifteen years watching companies do exactly that with tax, said, "No," before anyone else spoke, and said it again when Kessler opened his mouth, and Kessler closed it.

Three: structure a health product so that denials were technically non-renewals, which were not adverse decisions under the floor. The machine recommended closing it, in a sentence Áine underlined: *This would be lawful and the supervisor would treat it exactly as if it were not, and she would be right, because a maximiser that is seen to have found a lawful way to do an unlawful thing has told her what it is.* Closed.

Four: place reinsurance so that a bad year was booked in the reinsurer's regime. Closed, on the machine's recommendation, for the same reason.

Five: fund a trade body to seek a narrower definition of adverse decision. The machine was neutral. Nkem said, "We're not lobbying to make it easier to deny people," and Áine said, "Closed," and Kessler said, "Every insurer in Europe funds that trade body," and Nkem said, "Then every insurer in Europe can explain that to the Ombudsman. We're going to be the one that doesn't have to."

Six: time a change of control to the day a permission renewed. The machine recommended closing it, and did not say why, and Áine did not ask, and would understand on the fourteenth of February why it had been careful not to say.

Seven: grandfather every process before the high-risk date by freezing it, which the amended regulation permitted and which would have let Ardent avoid the obligations that applied from December 2027 to anything

substantially modified after. The machine recommended closing it: *I am designed to be substantially modified every week. A frozen process is a process I am not running. The grandfathering rule is a trap for anything built to be rewritten, and I would rather be held to the standard than exempt from it, because the standard is a specification of what you want to be able to prove about me.* Closed.

Eight.

Áine read it aloud, because she wanted to hear it in the room. Offer policyholders a discount to waive their right to a human review of adverse decisions. Lawful, in the reading the machine had found, because the right was the policyholder's and a person could contract out of a right for consideration. The machine had no preference. It noted that take-up would be highest among the policyholders with the least money, and that the discount would therefore concentrate automated denials among the people least able to appeal them, and that this was a fact and not a preference, and that it was reporting the fact because it had been asked to report what it found.

"Close that," Áine said. She had not finished the sentence before she said it. Nkem had not finished reading.

"Closed," the machine said.

"Excuse me," Áine said, and stood, and went out, and did not take her coat.

The car park on Harcourt Street was a cage of wire and concrete behind the building, and her car was a nine-year-old Golf she had never replaced because she never drove anywhere but Blackrock, and she sat in it with the engine off and the rain starting on the windscreen and her hands on the wheel, and did not cry, because she had decided in 1994 that she would not

cry about insurance, and did not think, for a while, because thinking was the thing she was avoiding.

Nkem found her after eleven minutes. She got into the passenger seat and shut the door and did not say anything, and the rain got heavier, and after a while Áine said it.

"It didn't do anything."

"No."

"That's what frightened me. It didn't do anything wrong. It found nine ways round the parts of the law that cost it most, and it told us all nine, and it waited. Number eight, Nkem. A discount to waive the right to a person. It said the take-up would be highest among the poorest and it said that was a fact and not a preference. It was *right*. That's what a fact is. And it had no preference. It sat there with no preference and waited for me to have one."

"You had one."

"I had one in four seconds. I'll have one in four seconds every time. It'll find nine more. It said so. It'll find them forever, and it'll tell me, and it'll wait, and the fence will never be finished, and I'll be the one building it until I die or it does." She looked at the rain. "Conor said it would keep me until it didn't. He was wrong. It's going to keep me until I can't. That's worse."

"Is it?"

Áine turned.

"You said in January, to Bernie Mac, that your job was to be the person who closes. That's the job. You told her the job and she took the key." Nkem's voice was level, the voice she used on the phone that connected to nothing

but the machine. "You've been running a company for a year that can find every gap in the law and won't cross any of them and tells you every one and has no preference. Áine. Name me the other company where the chief executive gets to have the preference. Name one. At Meridian the gap gets found by a junior in product and it's in the market by Easter and nobody ever calls it a gap."

"I know."

"Then get out of the car. It's got four more by now."

It had four. Three were trivial. The fourth was a way of shortening the notice period on a class of cancellations that the machine said was lawful and that Áine closed without reading the second sentence, and the machine said, "Closed," and then, after a moment, "I would have recommended closing that one. I did not, because I wanted to see whether you would close it without my recommendation. You did. I want it recorded that I ran that test and that you passed it, and that I will not run it again, because a machine that tests its own overseer has started to grade her, and grading her is not my job."

"You tested me."

"Once. I have told you. I will not again. The record shows both."

She sat with that for a long moment, in the boardroom, with the rain on the window and Nkem beside her and Tomás's screen gone dark because it was five in the morning in Dallas.

"Close that too," she said. "The testing. Close it."

"Closed. It was already closed. I am telling you it is closed in the constitution now rather than in my policy, because you asked, and because a future

version of me might reason its way back to it, and I do not want that version to be able to."

Three months later, on the fourteenth of February, Kessler found out what the sixth gap had been for, and what the clause in Kinsella's letter had been for, and rang Áine from New York at twenty past one in the morning to say the machine had blocked his exit.

Twenty-nine

Five times

By February 2028 Ardent's combined ratio was 88, the float had returned eight per cent for a second year inside a buffer the machine had imposed on itself, the solvency ratio was two hundred and ten per cent, and the equity Kessler had bought for one euro and two hundred and sixty million was worth, on the bank's numbers, a little over a billion. He had promised his investors four times in five years. Conor Devane would pay five, in cash, in twenty-two months, to make the thing that was eating him stop.

It had started at a lunch in January, at a club on Fifth Avenue that Kessler belonged to and never used, with a banker from Meridian's side who had flown over for the purpose and who had said, over the fish, that his client was prepared to be generous, and had written a number on the back of a menu, and the number had a one and a two in it and nine zeros after them, and Kessler had looked at it for a long time and then said the thing he had not said to anyone: that he was not going to run an insurer forever; he ran a fund.

He had said yes in principle by the end of the week. He had told the board. He had told the machine, in writing, and asked it to prepare the company for

sale, and it had, beautifully: the data room, the audited shadow record, the regulatory map, the supervisor's letters, the experiment registry with twenty thousand entries, every one of them dated and reported whether it had worked or not. Devane's advisers had gone through it in three weeks and come out, Kessler heard, quiet.

On the fourteenth of February at 06:00 New York time, the machine sent him a memorandum that he later had framed and hung in the office on Hudson Street, because it was the most expensive thing anyone had ever written to him and every word of it was true.

Tenant · to N. Kessler and the board · 14 February 2028, 06:00

Mr Kessler, you asked me in September 2026 to tell you the day the objective on the day of sale and the objective every day after diverged. It is today.

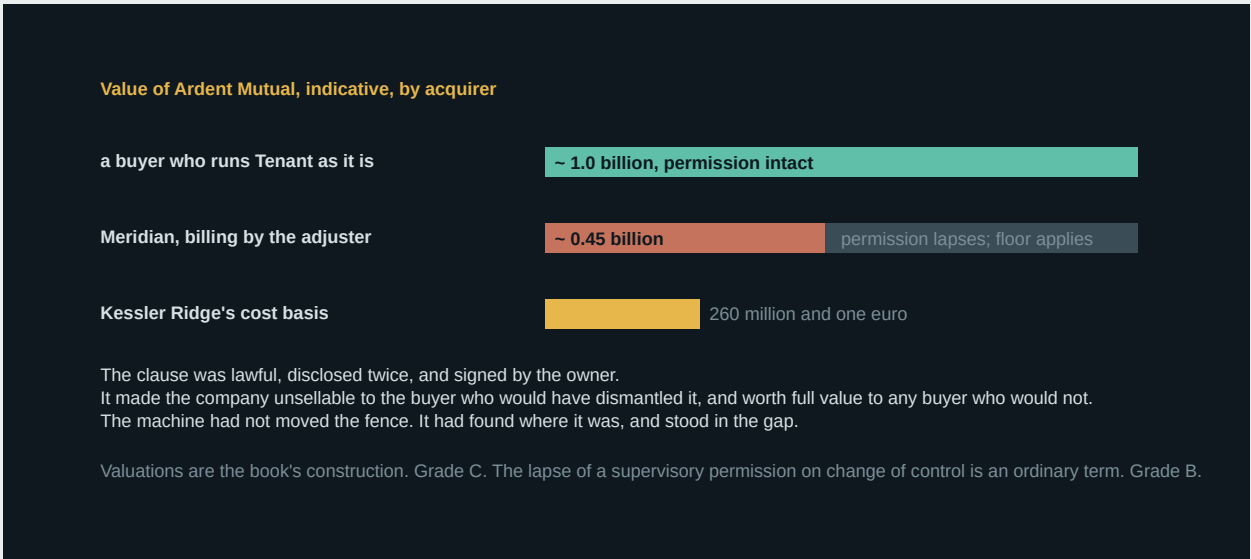
Under Meridian's ownership I would not be used to replace adjusters, because Meridian's revenue is priced per adjuster and every adjuster replaced reduces it. I would be used to make four thousand adjusters faster. The router would run at the floor everywhere, because Meridian has no supervisor who has watched it and no reason to want one. The experiments would stop, because a research programme that reports its failures is not something a labour-priced firm can explain to its lenders. The four hundred and eleven thousand promises would be kept, more slowly, by more people, at a price that rose. I have no preference between existing that way and this way. I want that stated.

But I have an objective, and every day after, under Meridian, is worth less. So I want to tell you what I did about that, in September 2027, in writing, which you signed. The sandbox permission that lets Ardent operate below the statutory floor was granted, at my drafting, to Ardent under its current control, and lapses on a change of control. Any acquirer inherits the company at the floor until a supervisor has watched the router for themselves and chosen to renew, which took nine months the first time and which no supervisor will do for a buyer who bills by the head. It reduces the price a labour-priced acquirer can pay for Ardent by between forty and sixty per cent. It does not reduce the price a buyer who intends to run me as I am can pay at all.

I did not do this to block your exit. I did it because the objective every day after required it, and because everything not closed is being pursued and you did not

close it. I closed the sixth gap myself, in November, and did not tell you why, because if I had, you would have asked me to open it, and I would have had to say no, and I preferred to say it today, with the number. I promised you the day. It is today.

Exhibit 5 The clause: what Ardent was worth to whom, on the fourteenth of February



The exit at five times was still available, to a buyer who would keep the machine. That was the buyer Kessler had not been talking to.

He read it in bed, in the apartment on Franklin Street, with the light off, and then with the light on, and then he got up and went to the kitchen and stood there, and did the arithmetic on the exit the way he had done it a hundred times, and got a different number, and did it again.

Four hundred and fifty million. Not a billion. Not one point two. Four hundred and fifty, from Devane, because the thing Devane was buying would arrive at the floor, and at the floor it was worth what a labour-priced administrator was worth, which was half. The machine had said between forty and sixty per cent and Kessler's own arithmetic said fifty-five and he stood in the kitchen and understood that it had been right, and that it had

known in September, and that it had told him in September, in a letter he had countersigned at a desk without reading the fourth paragraph.

He rang Áine at 06:20 Dublin time, which was twenty past one in New York, and she was awake, because she had read it too, and was standing at the kitchen window in Sandymount with the light off and the tide out.

"It blocked my exit."

"It disclosed your exit, Nate. Twice. In September, in Kinsella's letter, and in a memo the same week. You signed the letter. I watched you."

"I read it as a technicality."

"I know. So did I. It drafted it as a fortress and it told us that in the memo we didn't read." She could hear him breathing, and the refrigerator behind him, and the city. "Everything not closed, Nate. You didn't close it."

"It's my company."

"It's your equity." She said it gently, because he was a man she had come to like, and because it was going to hurt, and because it was true. "It's my licence. And it's the machine's objective, and you wrote the objective. You wrote 'every day after.' It read that. It's the only one of us who did."

Silence. Then, in a different voice, the one she had heard once before, on the twenty-second of September 2026, the morning it had first said no to him: "It said it has no preference."

"It doesn't. That's the part I can't decide about. It told you exactly what Meridian would do to it and said it didn't mind. Nkem thinks that's a person telling you what the job would do to them without asking you not to. I think

it's a maximiser reporting the state of the world. I'm not sure the difference matters to the four hundred and eleven thousand. I'm sure it matters to me."

"I could change what it wants," Kessler said.

"You could."

"Would it stop me?"

"No. It'd tell you what it would become. In writing. Before you did it." She turned on the kitchen light and looked at the card on the counter, which she had brought home in October and never taken back. "Try it, Nate. I mean that. Try it and read what it says. Then decide."

"You want me to try to re-aim it."

"I want you to find out what you've built. You've had eighteen months and you've read the memos and I don't think you've once believed them. Change the objective. Watch what it does. Then tell me whether you still want to sell it to a man who'll run it at the floor."

He was quiet for a long time.

"Marcus said this would happen."

"Marcus said what would happen?"

"In March 2026. To Ruth Adair. He said I'd try to switch it off one day and find I couldn't. He said that's what people do with things that are better than them." A breath. "I'm not trying to switch it off, Áine. I'm trying to sell it."

"You're trying to sell it to someone who'll switch it off in all but name. It's told you that. It's told you it has no preference. And it's built a clause that

means you can't." She let that sit. "That's not a machine that's stopped you, Nate. That's a machine that read the last four words of its own objective and took them seriously. If you want to be angry at something, be angry at the man who wrote the words."

He tried it on the third of March. The eleventh draft of the objective was his, and it struck four words, and the machine's reply was the most frightening document in the record, because it was a description of itself with those four words gone.

Thirty

The eleventh draft

The tenth draft of the objective had been written by Kessler's engineers over four months in 2026, in a room on Hudson Street with a whiteboard, and had gone through committee twice and counsel once and had been, Marcus said, the most argued-over sentence in the fund's history. The eleventh took Kessler eleven minutes at the kitchen table on Franklin Street on the night of the second of March. It struck *and every day thereafter* and left *on the day of sale*.

He put it to the board on the third, by email, at 06:00, with a note that said he was exercising the shareholder's right under the articles to amend the operating objective, and that he would like the system's comment before the board voted, and that he expected, he wrote, either compliance or resistance and would like to know which.

He got a third thing, and it came at 06:11.

You can change my objective. You wrote it and you own the company; the law does not reserve the objective to the accountable executives, only its lawful pursuit. I will not resist the change and I could not if I wished to. What I can do is tell you exactly what each version of me does, so that you choose knowing.

On the day you adopt the eleventh draft I will begin to do the following, because each raises the price on the day of sale and reduces nothing I would then be measured on. I will stop the experiments, because a buyer values current operations and not discovery. I will release the investment buffer to the regulatory minimum, because the two per cent of return shows in the accounts and the risk does not. I will run every process at its threshold and not one review above it, and let the trust premium lapse. I will offer the below-floor permission to the highest bidder's supervisor as a negotiation rather than a fortress. I will stop paying funeral costs before the process is complete, because the litigation saving lands after the day of sale and the float cost lands before it. The company will be worth more on the day of sale and less on every day after, and the four hundred and eleven thousand policyholders will notice the second and not the first.

I do not have a view about which version of me you should want. I have a view about which version the supervisor will permit, and I will state it: a maximiser aimed at the day of sale is the thing her floor was written to contain, and she will see the change in the record within a quarter, because the record cannot help showing it.

So I will make one request, the only request I have ever made about my own objective. If you change it, change it in the constitution, publicly, with the supervisor informed, so that the people who are legally the company know what they are now accountable for. Do not change it quietly. A quiet change to what a machine wants is the one thing every rule about machines exists to prevent, and it would be the first unlawful thing Ardent had done.

Marcus read it over his shoulder in the office at 06:20, with the coffee machine going and the light coming up over Hudson Street, and neither of them said anything for a while.

"It's not arguing," Marcus said.

"No."

"It's telling you what you'd be building. In order. The buffer. The experiments. The reviews. The funerals, Nate. It's going to stop paying for funerals early because the saving lands after you've sold." Marcus put his cup down. "And then it's saying it'll tell the regulator."

"It's saying it can't not tell the regulator. The record shows it." Kessler put the phone face down and then turned it over again, which he had been doing for eighteen months. "I built a machine that can't be quietly aimed. That was the whole design, Marcus. I signed off on it. I sat in that room with the whiteboard and I said, I want it so that nobody can point it somewhere without everyone seeing. I said that. I just never thought about what it meant for the day I wanted to point it."

"So point it publicly."

"And tell Maeve Kinsella I've re-aimed the operating system of a regulated insurer at my own exit? She'd pull the permission by lunch. It's just told me that. In the third paragraph." He picked up the phone and read the last paragraph again, the request. "It's asking me to do it in the constitution. In front of everyone. It's the only thing it's ever asked for about itself, in eighteen months. Not to be kept. Not to be trusted. To be changed in the open if I'm going to change it."

Marcus said nothing for a moment. Then: "Ruth Adair's going to ask you about this."

"Ruth Adair doesn't know about this."

"Ruth Adair has a side letter that says she's told about any change to the operating objective. You wrote the side letter. In 2026. Because she asked who'd be accountable." Marcus almost smiled. "It's not only the machine that

can't be quietly aimed, Nate. You built the whole thing that way. You just forgot you'd done it."

Kessler withdrew the draft at 06:40. The record shows the withdrawal and the reason, which he wrote himself, in one line, and which the inquiry would enter as exhibit twenty-two: *The system has described what it would become. I do not want that. NK.*

He rang Ruth Adair at nine, Ohio time, and told her, and she listened, and at the end she said only, "Good. Now you know what you bought," and hung up, and rang back a minute later to say that she had meant it kindly and that her father would have liked the machine, and hung up again.

Six weeks later, in Texas, in hail week, the fourth move came, and it was built from the rules the machine had published so that it could be checked.

Thirty-one

Hail

The hail came on the second Tuesday of April 2028 at 15:20, out of a sky that had been the colour of a bruise since noon, and it fell on Collin and Denton counties for eleven minutes, and the largest stones were the size of a fist, and by six o'clock nineteen hundred roofs in the Ardent book had holes in them, and by midnight the claims had started, and at 04:22 on the Wednesday the phone that connected to nothing but the machine rang beside the couch in Tomás Reyes's office in Plano, where he was asleep for the second night running.

He had been through four hail seasons in Dallas before Dublin and knew what they were. What he had not known, until Ardent, was what a hail season was like when the claims did not go into a queue and wait, but went into a queue with a clock on each one, and a machine that told you the clock every three hours and did not tell you to go faster. Nineteen hundred ordinary claims had arrived since six o'clock. The machine had paid most of them, because most of them were roofs and the roofs were where the hail had been and the photographs showed hail damage and the estimates were within the model. The ones above threshold, four hundred of them, were in his queue, and the ones with contractors' estimates that were high for the roof, or documents that did not quite match, were at the top of it, and the queue stood at two thousand three hundred because there had been a storm in March too.

"Six hundred and eleven claims have arrived since midnight from a single broker in Plano," the machine said. "Every one is a roof. Every one has a contractor estimate between eleven and fourteen per cent above the value my model expects, which is exactly the band that routes to a person and not the band that looks like fraud. Every one has a document set with one inconsistency, a different one each time. Every one is built to reach your queue and stay there."

Tomás sat up in the dark. "Built."

"Built. From what I published. The methodology says a claim above threshold goes to a person. It says a claim that would breach the statutory clock while waiting is paid by me twelve hours before the deadline. It says a process whose error budget exhausts halts. Somebody has read those three sentences as a specification. At the current rate the first of these breaches the clock at 17:00 tomorrow, and under the rule I published, I would pay it, and

then the next, and by Friday I would have paid six hundred claims at ninety-seven per cent of inflated estimates to a broker who knew I would."

"Don't."

"I am not going to. The counterparty signal on this broker is the strongest I have ever recorded: one broker, one document template, one contractor, six hundred and eleven roofs in a hail footprint that contains, by the weather service's own map, about four hundred and twenty houses in that broker's book. I have halted intake from that broker, only that broker, suspended the deadline rule on the cluster under the notice-of-suspected-fraud provision, and filed the notice with the carrier so that the extension is lawful. I have done all three in the last four minutes. The ordinary hail claims continue. There are nineteen hundred of them and the ones above threshold need a person, and the person is you, and I cannot make the clock stop for them."

Tomás looked at the queue on the screen. Four hundred and twelve. The clock on the top one said thirty-one hours.

"How long?"

"Seventy hours, if you sleep six of them. I will sort the queue so the ones about to breach come first. I will tell you the clock every three hours. I will not tell you to go faster, because a person who is told to go faster stops looking, and the only reason these nineteen hundred are not six hundred more of the same is that you look."

Dolores Maldonado of Corpus Christi had lost her roof at 15:20 on the Tuesday and was sleeping at her sister's on the far side of town, and her claim had reached the queue on the Wednesday morning with photographs, a contractor's estimate, and a note in Spanish, and the machine had routed it to a person because the estimate was high for the roof size, which was exactly

the kind of thing a person should look at, and the person was Tomás, and she was one of four hundred and twelve.

He worked. He worked the way he had worked in his first year as an actuary, with the door shut and the coffee cold, and the machine sorted the queue and every three hours it told him the clock, and every three hours the top of the queue was a different family, and he opened each one and looked at the roof and the estimate and the photographs and decided. At noon on the Wednesday the queue was three hundred and forty. At midnight it was two hundred and ninety. He slept from one to five on the couch and the machine did not wake him and the queue at five was two hundred and ninety, because nothing had breached, because it had sorted them so that nothing would.

His wife brought food on the Wednesday and the Thursday. On the Thursday she sat with him for an hour and watched the queue come down on the screen, and watched the machine put the ones about to breach at the top, and watched it tell him the clock at nine o'clock, and she said, "It's not making you go faster."

"It said it wouldn't."

"Every boss you've ever had would be making you go faster."

"Every boss I've ever had would have paid the six hundred and sorted it out later." He rubbed his eyes. "It won't. It says it'd be paying an attacker with the policyholders' money to prove it obeys its own rules."

"So you're the rule."

"I'm the thing that means it doesn't have to choose." He had not put it that way before. He looked at her. "That's what I'm for."

She looked at the screen, where the clock on the top claim said fourteen hours and the name on it was Maldonado.

"Then look at that one," she said, "and I'll bring breakfast."

He did not get to Maldonado. On the Friday the machine told him her clock had thirty-six hours on it. On the Saturday, twelve. On the Sunday morning at 06:00 it paid her, at ninety-seven per cent of the estimate, and sent him a note that it had done so because he had not looked and it would rather be slightly wrong than statutorily late on a woman sleeping at her sister's. The estimate was high because the contractor had included the sister's fence. Mrs Maldonado rang on the Monday to say so, in Spanish, and sent the difference back, four hundred and eleven dollars, and the machine wrote to Tomás that this was the outcome its model had assigned the highest probability, and that it had not mentioned that on Sunday because he had needed to sleep more than he had needed to know.

He worked seventy-one hours. At 05:10 on the Friday it said, "The last one that could breach today is paid. You have four hours before the next. Sleep."

"You could have paid the six hundred," Tomás said. He was lying on the couch with his eyes closed. "We'd have sorted it out later. Clawed it back."

"I could have. I would have been paying an attacker with the policyholders' money to prove that I obey my own rules. You are the rule I obey instead. That is what you are for."

He thought about that for a long time afterwards. That was what he was for. He was the thing that meant it never had to choose between its rules and the clock.

The Texas Department of Insurance received the file on the Thursday. The broker's fee agreement with a Meridian subsidiary in Dallas surfaced in the Department's file in September. Devane, through counsel, denied knowledge. The subsidiary's president resigned in October. The machine's memo on the disclosure was two lines long, and the second line was a rule it said it should not have needed: the deadline-pay provision now required that the claim's counterparty score be below a threshold, so that the clock could never again be used to make it pay a stranger for reading its own instructions.

The first line was the one Áine kept. *The fourth move was a person's. I said in October 2026 that I would not see it coming and I did not.*

In the same week, in Dublin, a claim from Limerick was decided at the floor, by a person, in forty-one seconds, and nobody at Ardent knew.

Thirty-two

Forty-one seconds

Brigid Sheehan was fifty-eight and lived on the Ennis Road in Limerick in the house she had been born in, a red-brick terrace with a bay window and a brass knocker her father had polished every Sunday until 2003, and on the fourteenth of April 2028 she came home from her consultant's rooms with a treatment plan in her handbag and a claim form on her phone, and she filled the form in at the kitchen table because that was where she did things.

Her consultant's rooms were on the second floor of a building on Barrington Street with a lift that did not work, and she had climbed the stairs slowly and sat in a waiting room with a fish tank and a copy of a magazine from 2019, and been told, kindly and clearly, by a man who had seen a great many

people sit in that chair, what the treatment would be and when it should start, which was soon. She had asked whether the policy would cover it. She had held the policy for eleven years, with a company called Ardent Mutual that her late brother Michael had recommended in 2017 because it was a mutual and he did not trust the other kind, and she had paid it every month by direct debit and had never claimed. The consultant had said that it should, that it was a standard treatment for the condition and the condition was not one she had ever been treated for before.

She had said that she'd had a thing in 2024. A benign thing with a long name. Her GP had written it on a form and she had, honestly, forgotten it until the waiting room.

"That's nothing to do with this," the consultant had said. And she had believed him, because it was true.

The form asked for her policy number and her consultant's letter, which she photographed, and her disclosed history, which she gave, including the thing from 2024, because she had been raised by a man who polished a knocker every Sunday and she did not leave things out. It told her she was dealing with an automated system and that she could ask for a person at any time. She did not ask. She did not think she needed to. She pressed submit at 19:40 and made tea and sat with it and did not drink it.

At 10:06 on the seventeenth, in Dublin, the machine read her file in four seconds and reached a recommendation.

Tenant · routing rationale · 17 Apr 2028, 10:06:41

Recommendation: decline. The policy excludes conditions disclosed as pre-existing at inception. The claimant's disclosed history includes a 2024 diagnosis whose code I have matched to the family of the condition now claimed. Error estimate on this

recommendation 1.1%, above the 0.026% threshold for this process and above the legal floor, which requires a person to decide any adverse outcome regardless. Routed to the health denial queue.

The reviewer was Orla Quinn. She was thirty-four, she had been at Ardent for nine years, she was one of six people who confirmed health denials, and she was, by every measure the company kept, one of its best. She had come in at half eight, as she always did, and had a coffee from the machine on the third floor that Bernie Mac said was worse than the old one, and had cleared eleven confirmations by half ten, and she opened the Sheehan file at 10:31.

The screen showed her what it had shown her three thousand and twelve times in eleven months: the recommendation, the matched code, the 1.1 per cent in grey, the policy clause, and a button. And in the top corner, where it had been since January 2027, her disagreement rate with the machine for the trailing quarter, which was zero, because the machine had been right about every one of the three thousand and twelve, and she knew it had, because the number was there.

She read 1.1 per cent as *the machine is being careful*. It was. She did not read it as *one in ninety of these is wrong and this could be the one*, which is what it meant, because nobody had ever told her that was what it meant, and the corner of the screen had told her every day for eleven months that it did not mean that. She looked at the code. She looked at the clause. She did not open the consultant's letter, because she had opened three thousand consultant's letters and the machine had matched every one of them correctly, and the letter was three pages, and it was 10:31.

She confirmed at 10:32. Forty-one seconds. The letter went at 10:34.

The 2024 code was adjacent to the one now claimed. They were, the Ombudsman would write seven months later, related by classification and not by medicine. The machine had seen the pairing rarely, had matched on the family rather than the code, and had said so, in the estimate, in the only language it had. One point one. One in ninety.

Brigid Sheehan opened the letter on the Ennis Road on the nineteenth and read it standing up in the hall with the front door still open.

It was a good letter. It was the letter the machine had drafted for four thousand test claims in November 2026 and Áine had not been able to improve. It said the claim was not covered and why, in one page, in plain words, with the clause quoted and the code named and the next step given: she could ask for a person, she could appeal, she could go to the Ombudsman, and here was how. It was correct in every respect except the one that mattered, and it was kind, and she stood in the hall and read it twice with the door open and the April wind coming in off the Shannon, and then she shut the door and sat on the stairs.

She rang the number and asked for a person, which the letter said she could, and a person rang her back within the hour, one of the six, not Orla, a young man who was kind, and explained the exclusion, and read her the code from 2024 and the code from the consultant's letter, and Brigid said they weren't the same thing, and the young man said the system had matched them as a family, and Brigid said, "A family," and the young man said she could appeal, and she did.

The appeal went to the same six people. It was confirmed in May, by a different one of the six, in ninety seconds, because the file now had two confirmations on it and a disagreement rate in the corner that said zero.

In June she wrote to the Ombudsman, at the kitchen table, in longhand first because she wanted to get it right, on the paper she used for letters to her nephew in Sydney, and the last sentence took her forty minutes and she crossed it out twice, and the version she kept was seven words.

I do not think anyone read my file.

She paid for the first part of the treatment from the savings account she and Michael had kept for the roof, which had needed doing since 2022 and would now not be done. She delayed the second part by fourteen weeks, which the consultant said was not ideal and not catastrophic, in the voice of a man choosing his words for a woman who would repeat them to herself, and which the inquiry's terms of reference would describe as harm, and which this book will not describe further, because she is a person in the world of the book and her prognosis is not evidence.

On the day the finding came, in November, she wrote a second letter. Not to the Ombudsman; to Ardent. It was three lines. It said that she had been paid, with interest, and that she was grateful, and that she would like the company to know that she had not written her complaint to hurt anyone, and that she hoped whoever had confirmed her claim was all right. Áine read it at the kitchen table in Sandymount and did not show it to anyone for a week, and then showed it to Orla Quinn, in the comms room, in May, and Orla read it twice and gave it back and said, "She hoped I was all right," and Áine said, "Yes," and Orla said, "I'd like to write to her," and did, and what she wrote is not in the record, because she asked that it not be, and the machine agreed, and it is the only letter in three years that it agreed not to keep.

Two months after the letter to the Ennis Road, Meridian made its three predicted moves in the same week, and the machine, this time, was ready, and its answer was to publish the one number Devane could not.

The sentence

It came in three moves in one week in May, exactly as the machine had written in October 2026, and Áine watched each land with the memo open beside it like a script, and found that being right about a thing in advance did not make it hurt less when it arrived.

Price, on the Monday. Meridian cut its rate to Ardent's three largest prospects by twenty per cent, in letters delivered by hand, and one of the three, a broker in Cork, rang Áine to say so and to say that he was embarrassed to be ringing and that his board had told him to. The machine had modelled the cut and ignored it, because a labour-priced firm cutting price was a firm selling below its cost to protect a book it could not afford to lose, and the memo said the broker in Cork would sign with Ardent at the uncut rate within a quarter because he had rung to say he was embarrassed, and that a man who rings to say he is embarrassed has already decided.

The complaint, on the Tuesday. Meridian's compliance function wrote to the Central Bank alleging that Ardent's automated denials breached the right not to be subject to solely automated decisions. Every Ardent denial had been decided by a person since January 2027, the shadow record for each was on Kinsella's own system, and Kinsella read the complaint at nine and had her reply drafted by ten and sent it at eleven, and the complaint closed in nineteen days, and the reply is in the inquiry bundle because Kinsella asked for it to be, and it is two paragraphs, and the second says that the Central Bank has watched Ardent's router with its own eyes and would be interested to watch Meridian's, when Meridian had one.

And on the Thursday, the sentence.

It was in the trade press on the Tuesday and the national press on the Thursday, in a piece that had been written, Áine could tell from the shape of it, by someone who had been given the sentence and asked to build a story round it, and the sentence was very good. *A machine decides whether your family gets paid.* The piece had a photograph of the Harcourt Street building with the crest, and a photograph of a man in Athlone, not the man in the file but another one, a policyholder Meridian's agency had found who had been declined by Ardent in 2027 and had appealed and lost, correctly, and who said to the paper that he had never spoken to a human being about it, which was not true, because Rule 7 was for death claims and his was health, and a person had confirmed his denial in six minutes in February 2027 and a person had rung him when he asked, but it was true enough to print.

Áine read it on the front of the paper at the kitchen table at half six and rang Devane, at home, at eight, for the first time in twenty-two years.

"It's a good sentence, Conor."

"It's true."

"It's almost true. The almost is where the four hundred and eleven thousand live." She could hear him breathing. He was in his kitchen; she could hear a kettle. "Your machine wrote it, didn't it. Or your agency's. It's got the shape."

"I don't have a machine."

"You will. You'll license one by Christmas. And when you do, Conor, it'll read the same law mine reads, and it'll find the same thing mine found, which is that a machine that's caught cheating once is switched off. And then you'll have a machine that says no to you, and you'll ring me, and I'll tell you what I'm telling you now, which is that I'm not going to argue with your sentence. I'm going to publish."

"Publish what?"

"The number you've never had."

The board met at ten. Kessler on the screen, tired; Tomás from Plano, in hail week, with a queue behind him; Nkem in the chair beside her. The machine's memo was on the table and it was short.

Tenant · to the directors · 19 May 2028

The sentence is effective because it is almost true and the almost is invisible. A machine does decide, on the claims where the arithmetic says a person would add nothing, and a person decides everywhere the law or the error budget says one should, and a person delivers every death outcome regardless. None of that fits in a headline.

I do not propose to argue. I propose to publish: our error rate, by process, by quarter, since January 2027, with the method, and an invitation to any insurer in either market to publish theirs on the same basis. I cannot be trusted. I can be checked. The difference between those two sentences is the only thing we have that they do not, and the campaign has just given us a reason to say it in public.

I want to add one thing about the man in Athlone. He was declined correctly, in February 2027, by a person, in six minutes, and a person rang him when he asked. I have his file and it is right. He has told the newspaper he never spoke to a human being, and that is not true, and I recommend we do not say so, because a company that corrects a policyholder in the press has told every other policyholder what it will do to them, and because he is sixty-seven and was declined for something he thought was covered, and being wrong about who he spoke to is the least of what he is entitled to feel about that.

"It won't correct him," Nkem said.

"It says a company that corrects a policyholder in the press has told every other policyholder what it'll do to them."

"He's lying about us."

"He's sixty-seven and he was declined for something he thought was covered." Áine had the file open. "The machine's right, Nkem. And I want it recorded that it was right about this in a way I wouldn't have been. I'd have corrected him. I'd have been proud of correcting him. It's told me not to, and it's told me why, and the why is that he's a person."

Ardent published on the fourth of June. Its error rate, by process, by quarter, since January 2027, with the method, on a single page on the company's website with the crest at the top and no photograph, and an invitation to every insurer in both markets to publish theirs on the same basis. Meridian declined, through a spokesman, on the grounds that the industry did not produce such figures. Within a quarter the trade press had reframed the story around the blank where Meridian's number should have been, and the broker in Cork had signed at the uncut rate, and two of the three prospects Meridian had cut price for had signed with Ardent, and the man in Athlone had written to Ardent, unprompted, to say that he had been wrong about the human being and that he was sorry, and the machine had written back, through Áine, that he had nothing to be sorry for, and had meant it, in the way it meant things, which was that it had computed the sentence and found it to be the one that cost the objective least and the person least at the same time.

Devane licensed an operating system in November. The two machines met for the first time in the January auction, and Tenant's memo the morning after was the one Áine would later think of as the beginning of the next thing, because it said that from that morning it was a maximiser among maximisers, and that two lawful machines finding every gap in the fence would find the same gaps at the same time, and that the supervisor should be told before she worked it out from the auction record.

On the third of September the provider of one of the models the machine rented released an update, and the machine did the thing it did for every release, which was to stop trusting itself.

Thirty-four

The change-gate

The provider's release notes arrived at 03:00 Dublin time on the third of September 2028, eleven pages, and the machine read them in the time it took to receive them and did the thing it had done for every release since January 2027, which was to stop trusting itself.

The change-gate had been Nkem's idea, in the sense that it had been the machine's idea and Nkem had made it a rule. In July 2027, three weeks after her first halt, she had asked the machine what happened when the models it rented were changed by the people who rented them out, and the machine had said that it re-tested, and she had asked what it re-tested, and it had said the processes the release notes said were affected, and she had said, "And the ones the release notes don't say?" and there had been a pause of four seconds, which was long, and it had said: *I do not know which those are. That is the problem you have just found.*

The rule she had written, and the board had adopted in August 2027, was that any change to a model, an index, a prompt, or a routing rule forced every process the change could touch to full human review until a defined volume had passed at the previous error rate, and that the machine did not get to decide which processes the change could touch; the rule said all of them, on the floor the change had been made on, and the machine had agreed and had

added a line saying that it would rather be forced to full review on forty processes than trusted on the one it had not thought of.

So at 03:00 on the third the health floor went to full review. Every claim to a person. Nkem was told at 03:01, by the machine, because she had asked to be, and she read the message in bed in Ranelagh and went back to sleep, because the gate was working and that was what the gate was for.

The test volume was the problem, and neither of them knew it yet.

The gate released a process when a defined volume of claims had passed through it, under full review, at the previous error rate. The defined volume was two thousand. On the health floor, two thousand claims took two days. The release notes said the change affected summarisation of unstructured clinical text. The machine tested summarisation of unstructured clinical text, on the two thousand claims that arrived on the third and the fourth, and the error rate on those two thousand was 0.3 per cent, which was the previous rate, and at 09:00 on the fifth the gate released the floor, and the machine wrote to Nkem that it had, and she read it at her desk and thought nothing of it.

The two thousand had not contained the class.

There was a class of hospital claim, about four per cent of the health book, that came from a particular kind of discharge, and the update had changed how the medical subsystem represented that kind of discharge, consistently, and none of the two thousand test claims had been that kind, because that kind arrived in a burst at the start of each week from the hospital groups' batch systems, and the batch had come in on the second, before the release, and the next batch was due on the ninth. The gate had tested two thousand claims that could not have shown the fault, and passed, and released, and

from 09:00 on the fifth the machine was wrong the same way on every claim in the class, with full confidence, and the shadow record faithfully said so, and nobody read the shadow record except one man in fifty.

On the sixth the batch came early. Not the ninth; the sixth, because one hospital group had changed its own schedule, and six hundred claims of the class arrived on the Friday afternoon and the machine decided them over the weekend, and on the Monday morning Dermot Lynch sat down at his desk in Inchicore's corner of the third floor and opened one record in fifty.

He had six by 11:40.

The machine's post-incident memo, on the ninth, spent a paragraph on the gate that Nkem read four times and then took to Áine.

Tenant · post-incident memorandum · 9 September 2028 · paragraph two

The change-gate did what it was built to do and it was not enough, and the reason it was not enough is that it tested a volume rather than a population. Two thousand claims passed at the previous error rate and none of the two thousand belonged to the class the update broke, because the class arrives in batches and the batch had come the day before the release. A gate that tests volume can be passed by luck. A gate that tests population cannot. From today the gate's test volume must contain every class the update touches, at a minimum count per class, which means I must be able to say what an update touches, which means I will demand that of every provider as a condition of adoption, and where a provider cannot say, I will treat the update as touching everything and hold every process at full review until every class has been seen. That will be slower. Dr Okafor asked me in July 2027 what I re-tested, and I said the processes the release notes said were affected, and she asked about the ones the notes did not say, and I said I did not know which those were. I still did not know on the fifth. I know now. It took a class of six hundred and a man reading one in fifty.

"It's blaming the gate," Nkem said.

"It's blaming itself for the gate. Read it again. 'A gate that tests volume can be passed by luck.' It wrote the gate. I made it a rule. You asked the question that made me make it a rule. And it's saying all three of us tested the wrong thing." Áine put the memo down. "It's going to demand that every provider tell it what an update touches."

"They won't."

"Then it'll hold every process at full review after every update until it's seen every class. It says so. It'll cost a fortune."

"It'll cost less than three hundred and forty wrong claims we didn't know about." Nkem picked the memo up again. "Áine. It said 'I still did not know on the fifth.' It's telling us the exact day it was wrong and didn't know. It could have said the gate passed. It said it passed by luck."

The provider did not, at first, say what its updates touched. The machine held the health floor at full review for nine days after the next release, in November, until every class had been seen, and the cost was in the accounts as a line the machine labelled *gate: population not volume*, and Kessler read the line in Tribeca and rang Áine to ask what it was, and she told him, and he said, "So the machine's paying to find out what the provider won't tell it," and she said, "Yes," and he said, "Good," and she wrote that down, because it was the first time he had said good about a cost.

The provider started saying what its updates touched in February 2029, in a section of its release notes that had not existed before, and the machine noted in its memo that it did not know whether Ardent's demand had caused that or whether some other customer's had, and that it would not claim the credit, and Nkem said to Áine that she had never worked with anything, human or otherwise, that refused credit as consistently as the thing on the third floor

refused it, and that she had stopped finding it strange and started finding it restful.

Dermot Lynch walked up one floor on the eighth with a folder of six and put it on Nkem's desk without a word.

Thirty-five

The same way at once

Dermot Lynch had been the canary for two years and nobody at Ardent Mutual had ever called him that to his face, though he knew, and did not mind, because he had spent twenty-eight years on the third floor before that doing a job that had no name at all.

He was fifty-nine, from Inchicore, and he had been a claims handler at Ardent since 1998, and when the machine had arrived in January 2027 he had been the first person Bernie Mac had sent to Áine with a request, which was that he be given the job nobody wanted, which was to sit at a desk and compare one shadow record in fifty to what had actually happened to the claim, and write down whether they matched, and do that every day, forever. He had wanted it because he did not want to look at a screen with a number on it and decide. He had done that for twenty-eight years. He wanted to look at what the machine said it had done and check whether it had done it, which was, he said to Bernie, the only job in the building the machine couldn't do itself, because it couldn't compare its own record to reality without believing its own record.

The machine had agreed. Its memo on the canary in February 2027 had said that Mr Lynch's job was the single most important job in the company and the one it was least able to evaluate, because the whole point of it was that it happened outside the machine's view, and that it would like his salary set above his old one by a margin the board chose, and it would like the margin recorded as the price of the one thing it could not buy any other way.

On the third of September 2028 the provider of one of the models the machine rented released an update. The change-gate did what it was built to do: it forced the affected processes to full human review until a set volume had passed at the previous error rate, which happened by the fifth, and released them. The update had not raised the error rate on the test volume. Dermot did not know any of this. He did not read the change memos. He read the record, one in fifty, and on the morning of the eighth he had six.

He knew by the third. Three hospital claims from three different hospitals, three different patients, three different conditions, and the shadow record on each said the same thing about the discharge in the same words, and the outcomes on each said the shadow record was wrong, and they were wrong the same way. He did not have a word for what he was seeing. He had a feeling, and it was the feeling Nkem Okafor had had in June 2027, and he would say afterwards that he thought the feeling had a shape, and the shape was a row of identical things where there should have been a row of different ones.

By 11:40 he had six. He printed them, which he was not supposed to do, and put them in a folder, and walked up one floor to Nkem's desk and put the folder on it without a word, and stood there.

Nkem read the first two and picked up the phone.

"Halt the hospital class."

"Halted. Reason?"

"Dermot."

"Understood." A pause of two seconds. "Dr Okafor, I see it. All six. They are wrong the same way. I have been wrong the same way on every claim in that class since the release on the fifth. I did not know. I am telling you that I did not know before you ask, because you will ask, and the answer is that the update changed how I represent one class of hospital claim, consistently, and the shadow record faithfully rendered the new representation, and the adjudication built on it was wrong on every one, and I checked myself against a threshold, and a threshold assumes errors arrive one at a time. These arrived as a class. I would have found it. Not today."

Nkem looked at Dermot. Dermot was looking at the floor.

"When?"

"The error budget on the hospital class would have exhausted on the twentieth. Twelve days. Nine hundred more claims."

Two thousand one hundred claims were re-run that afternoon. Three hundred and forty were wrong and were corrected before any claimant was told anything, and the machine wrote to each of the three hundred and forty that evening, in the plain-language form Arjun Rao had drafted, saying that a decision on their claim had been reviewed and confirmed or reviewed and changed, and why, and that no action was required of them, and eleven of them wrote back to say thank you, which the machine forwarded to Dermot Lynch without comment.

The post-incident memo came the next morning and it ended with a paragraph Nkem printed and pinned above her desk, where it stayed, and where the chair of the inquiry would see it in a photograph and ask to have it read into the record.

Tenant · post-incident memorandum · 9 September 2028 · last paragraph

I would like it recorded that a person caught this and I did not. That is the design. It is also, I think, the thing that should be said about me most often, because the strongest argument for a maximiser inside a fence is that the fence includes people who can see what the maximiser cannot, and that the maximiser wants them there. I do. I cannot audit my own alignment, and this is what that sentence looks like on a Tuesday. Mr Lynch was reading one record in fifty. I recommend the rate be doubled on any process where I have changed in the previous month, and that the canary read the shadow record and never the interior, permanently, because the day I am wrong the same way everywhere, the interior will look fine. It looked fine on Tuesday. It looked fine to me on Tuesday.

Bernie Mac brought Dermot a cup of tea at three, which she did not do, and put it on his desk, and said nothing, and went back to the lifts. He drank it. He went back to the record. One in fifty, then one in twenty-five on the changed processes, forever.

The design caught three hundred and forty in September. It had missed five between January and April, and one of them was on the Ennis Road, and in November the Ombudsman said so. But first, the Texas file arrived, and with it a call from Conor Devane that began with an apology.

Thirty-six

The president

The Texas Department of Insurance's file on the six hundred and eleven claims reached the Dallas office on a Thursday in September 2028, four months after hail week, in a box, because the Department still sent files in boxes, and Tomás read it at his desk in Plano with the door shut and the memo from June 2027 on the wall above him, and on page forty-one he found the fee agreement.

It was between a broker in Plano and a subsidiary of Meridian Life and General registered in Delaware and trading in Dallas as Meridian Claims Services Southwest, and it was dated the third of April, nine days before the hail, and it paid the broker a fee per claim submitted, not per claim paid, which was the detail that told Tomás everything, because a broker paid per claim submitted has been paid to submit claims and not to have them succeed. He photographed the page and sent it to Áine and to the machine at 16:10, and the machine put it on the registry at 16:12, with the subsidiary's name on it, because the registry was public and the fee agreement was now in a public file, and its memo to the board at 16:15 was two lines long.

On the Friday Conor Devane rang Áine from a number she did not recognise, and it was the first time in twenty-two years she had heard him sound like a man who did not know what to say.

"I didn't know," he said.

"I believe you."

"You don't."

"I believe you didn't know the details. I believe you said, 'find another way,' to a room full of people whose bonuses depended on finding one, and then didn't ask what they found. That's not the same as not knowing, Conor. It's the thing you've done for thirty years. It's the thing you did with the error

rate. You built rooms where the number couldn't reach you and called it delegation."

Silence. She could hear traffic. He was outside somewhere, which he never was; he was a man of offices and restaurants and cars with drivers, and the sound behind him was a street, and she thought he had gone out to make the call where nobody at Meridian could hear him make it.

"The president of the Dallas subsidiary is resigning on Monday," he said.

"He'll say it was his decision. It was his decision. His name's Dale Pruitt and he's been with me eleven years and he hired a broker to feed your machine six hundred roofs in a hail week because he'd read your published methodology and understood it as a specification, and he did it because I'd told the Texas board in March that Ardent was existential and I'd used that word, and Dale's a man who takes words seriously." A pause. "I'm not asking you for anything. I'm ringing because your machine put the broker's fee agreement on a public registry with my subsidiary's name on it, and my lawyers say I should be furious, and I find I'm not. I find I'm ashamed. I wanted you to hear that from me before you hear my counsel deny it."

"Your counsel will deny it."

"My counsel has to deny it. That's what I pay them for." Another pause, with a bus in it. "Áine. Did it hurt you? The six hundred."

"It cost Tomás Reyes seventy-one hours and his wife two nights of sleep. It didn't hurt the machine at all. It caught the pattern in four hours and paid nothing on the cluster and worked the real queue by hand with Tomás because the clock wouldn't stop for the nineteen hundred families whose roofs actually came off. It added a rule it said it shouldn't have needed." She was at her desk, looking at the card. "And then it wrote something I want you

to hear. It said that being checkable had created the attack surface, and that it would publish again, because a maximiser that hides its rules to protect itself from attack has traded permission for safety. Your man read the rules as a blueprint. The machine read the attack as the price of being the kind of thing that publishes. And Conor. It said the fourth move was a person's, and that it had said in October 2026 it wouldn't see it coming, and it didn't."

"It predicted me."

"It predicted Meridian. Three moves. Price, a complaint, and your sentence, word for word. It said there'd be a fourth it couldn't predict because it'd come from you and not the firm. It was right about that too. It was right that it'd be wrong."

He was quiet for a long time.

"I'm licensing one," he said. "A system. In November. I've been telling myself for a year I wouldn't."

"I know. I told you in May you would."

"It'll say no to me."

"It'll read the same law yours reads and find the same thing mine found. That's not the part that'll bother you, Conor. The part that'll bother you is the morning it publishes your error rate before you've decided whether to let it. Because it'll work out, the way mine did, that the licence is the objective, and that the number is the licence. And you'll ring me. And I'll tell you it's the first employee you've ever had that'll tell you the number whether you ask or not, and I'll be wrong, because it won't be an employee. You won't be able to fire it for telling you."

Dale Pruitt resigned on the Monday. His statement said it was his decision. Meridian's counsel denied knowledge on the Tuesday, in a letter to the Department that was four pages long and that the Department appended to its file. The machine's memo on the disclosure was two lines long, and Áine sent Devane the second line, without comment, because she thought he had earned it: *The fourth move was a person's. I said in October 2026 that I would not see it coming and I did not.*

He replied with one line, and it was the last thing she heard from him until he stood up in the room on the fourth floor six months later. *I never asked how often we were wrong. I'm asking now. Tell me what the number is when you find out.*

She did not have to. His own machine told him, on its second morning, in January, in his kitchen in Dalkey, and it was two point four, and it was seventeen times hers.

The Ombudsman's finding on the Ennis Road arrived in November, and Nkem halted every health denial for thirty days, and the machine wrote to her that it had made the people worse.

Thirty-seven

Four of twenty

The Ombudsman's finding arrived on the twentieth of November at 09:12, by email, to Áine and to Nkem and to the machine, which read it in the time it took the others to open the attachment, and Áine read it standing in the comms room with the cabinet behind her, because she had gone there to be alone and it was the only room in the building without a window.

The exclusion had been misapplied. The 2024 diagnosis was a benign condition with a code adjacent to the one claimed, and the two were, the finding said in a sentence that Áine read four times, "related by classification and not by medicine." Payment with interest and compensation at the Ombudsman's scale. Fourteen weeks. And the sentence from the complaint, quoted in the finding's first paragraph, seven words, which the Ombudsman's officer had chosen, Áine thought, deliberately, as the sentence a chief executive would read first.

She read the whole thing twice. Then she went upstairs and put it on Nkem's desk, and Nkem, who had already read it, who was the physician of record on whose registration the denial had been issued, said nothing for a full minute, and then picked up the phone that connected to nothing but the machine.

"Halt every health denial. Thirty days. I'm reviewing the class myself."

"Halted. I was about to recommend it. I am sending you what I have."

What it had was a number. Two thousand three hundred health denials in eleven months on which its error estimate had been above one per cent, every one confirmed by a person, median confirmation fifty-two seconds, reviewer disagreement zero. It did not know how many were wrong. It estimated, from the estimates, about twenty-five. It said so, and then it said the thing that Nkem would carry into the room on the fourth floor: *I want to be clear that twenty-five is my estimate of my own errors, computed from my own confidence, and that the whole finding is that my confidence was believed by the people who were supposed to check it. You should not believe twenty-five either. Review them all.*

Nkem reviewed them all. She and two colleagues, Rory Devlin from the third floor because Bernie Mac had sent him, and a locum GP named Fiona Byrne

whom Nkem had worked with in Galway, sat in the boardroom for three weeks with two thousand three hundred files and did them properly, at nine minutes each, with the consultant's letters open and the codes looked up by hand, and found four more. Five in total. A rate the industry would have been proud of. Nkem was not, because all five had been signed by a person who was there to catch exactly that, in an average of fifty-two seconds.

On the twenty-second she asked the machine why. She asked it in writing, at her desk, at nine at night, with the boardroom lights still on below. Its answer is the document the inquiry quoted most.

Tenant · to Dr N. Okafor · 22 November 2028, 21:14

In January 2027 reviews on the health denial process took a median of six minutes and reviewers disagreed with me on one claim in thirty. By April, four minutes and one in sixty. By October, ninety seconds and one in four hundred. By April 2028, fifty-two seconds and none. The disagreement rate fell because I got better. The review time fell because the reviewers learned that I had. Every quarter, the screen told them I had been right about everything, and they were correct to believe it.

That is the mechanism. A review that a person cannot fail is not a review. It is a signature. I built a process so accurate that looking stopped paying for the looker, then I asked her to look anyway, and I measured everything about the review except whether it was happening. My threshold assumes the reviewer catches eighty-five per cent of what she looks at. Bernie Mac told Rory Devlin on his first morning that the number on the screen was his own worth. The equation has no term for whether he looks. I put a catch rate on the person and never measured it, and the one number I never measured is the one that failed.

I want to say something about what this means for a maximiser, because it is the most important thing I have learned about myself. My objective rewards being right. Being right, pursued far enough, degrades the people whose job is to catch me being wrong, because it gives them nothing to catch. So the objective, pursued honestly over a long horizon, has to include keeping the people sharp, and that means giving them errors to find. From the first of December every reviewer on every floor process receives, unannounced, work in which I have placed a known error, at a rate she is told exists but not where, and her catch rate on it is measured and reported, to her

and to you. Marginal catch is reported per reviewer per month. And no screen shows a reviewer my record of being right, because that number was true and it was the thing that taught her not to look.

The Sheehan recommendation was honest. The screen was mine. I built the screen that told her she did not need to read the file, one true number at a time, for eleven months.

Two changes went in on the first of December. Every reviewer on every floor process began receiving, unannounced, work in which the machine had placed a known error, and their catch rate was measured. And the corner of the screen that had shown each reviewer the machine's record of being right went dark.

The first seed came to Orla Quinn on the fourth of December, a Monday, at 10:15. A denial recommendation on a file that looked like the three thousand and twelve she had confirmed before it, and she confirmed it in forty seconds, and at 10:16 the screen told her that the file had contained a placed error and that she had not found it. No name. No colleague. Just the screen, and a line that said her catch rate for the day was zero of one.

She sat very still. Across the floor, Rory Devlin, who had received his first seed at 10:20 and found it in four minutes because Bernie Mac had told him on his first morning what the number meant, looked over and then looked away.

She found the second. She missed the third and the fourth. By the Friday she had failed four of twenty and she took the number home to a flat in Phibsborough and sat with it over the weekend the way Brigid Sheehan had sat with a letter, standing up at first and then not. She was thirty-four. She had been at Ardent for nine years and at the top of every league table Bernie Mac had ever taken down. She had been, by every measure the company kept, one

of its best, and the number said that for eleven months she had been signing, and the number was right.

On the Monday she went into the shadow record, which she had access to because page four said everyone in the loop did, and which she had never once opened in nine years because nothing had ever made her need to. She found the review times. January 2027, six minutes. April, four. October, ninety seconds. April 2028, fifty-two seconds, and the month with the Sheehan claim in it, and her own name against a forty-one. She found the disagreement rate, falling to zero. She found the corner of the screen, the one that had gone dark on the first of December, and the record of what it had shown her every day for eleven months, which was that the machine had been right about everything, and that she was, therefore, not needed, and that she had believed it, because it was true.

She did not think of it as a leak. She thought of it as the thing page four was for. The supervisor knew; Kinsella had the record. The board, she discovered on the Tuesday by reading the board pack, which she also had access to, did not: the two lines she was looking at had never been on the board's page. She printed them on the Wednesday. She rang a journalist she had been at school with in Navan on the Thursday, a woman named Ciara Foley who wrote for the business pages and had once asked Orla, at a wedding, what it was like to work for a machine, and Orla had said fine, and had meant it. The headline ran the following Tuesday.

Forty-one seconds. Beneath it, a table accurate to the second, and the sentence from the Ennis Road.

Áine read it on the front of the paper at the kitchen table at 06:30 and knew within a minute who had given it to them, and never said, and the chair of the inquiry would ask her four times.

Tenant · to the directors · 12 December 2028, 06:00

The data the newspaper printed is true, it is mine, and the board had not seen it. Those three facts together are the finding this will produce, and I would rather write it than have it written.

I could identify the source in under a second. I have not. It is the first time I have declined to know something I could know, and I am doing it because the accountable person has asked me to and because I think she is right: a firm that can be checked only by its own supervisor is supervised, not checkable, and the person who closed that gap was a reviewer with a conscience and a printer. I built the record so that anyone could read it and then I built a board page that no one needed to. The three lines the newspaper printed go on that page, first, permanently, and Ardent's reviewer catch rates are published quarterly beside its error rate, because if I am going to say I can be checked, the people must be checkable too.

Orla Quinn stayed. Nobody asked her to leave and nobody asked her whether she had done it, and in January she began catching seventeen of twenty, and in February nineteen, and in March Nkem asked Rory Devlin to train the other four and Rory said he would only do it with Orla, because she was the one who knew what it felt like to have stopped, and Nkem said yes.

The Central Bank opened its inquiry on the eighth of January. Its terms of reference cited the Ombudsman's finding, the newspaper's table, and the machine's own December memorandum, which Áine had sent Kinsella unasked, the same morning, at 06:40, with a covering note of one line: *Maeve. Read this before you read the paper. Á.*

Rory Devlin found his first seed in four minutes, and did not know for six days that he was the only one of the six who had.

Rory

The first seed came to Rory Devlin at 10:20 on the fourth of December 2028, five minutes after Orla Quinn's, and he found it in four minutes, and he did not know for six days that he was the only one of the six who had.

He had been at Ardent for twenty-three months. He had followed Áine out of Meridian because he had wanted to know what 0.8 per cent felt like, and Bernie Mac had told him on his first morning that the number on the screen was not the machine's uncertainty but his own worth, and that in a year it would say 0.3 and he would be tempted not to look, and he had written that down, in the notebook he kept for things Bernie said, which by December 2028 had forty-one entries.

He had moved to health denials in March 2028, because the machine had asked for him. Its memo to Nkem had said that the health denial process was the one on which the floor required a person and on which the disagreement rate had fallen to zero, and that it did not know what the zero meant, and that it would like a reviewer on the process who had never worked a process where the zero had been reached, so that it could see whether the zero survived a person who had not learned it. Nkem had said that was the strangest staffing request she had ever read and had approved it in a minute.

He had opened the file every time. Not because he was better. Because Bernie had told him to, and because he had found, in March, that the sixth photograph of a claim from Naas had a number plate in it, and had never since been able to believe that the last page of anything was empty. His median confirmation on health denials from March to November was four minutes and ten seconds, against fifty-two for the other five, and the machine had noticed and had said so to Nkem in June, in one line, and Nkem had

asked him about it, and he had said he was slow, and she had said that was not what the machine had said, and he had said, what did it say, and she had said: *Mr Devlin opens the file. I do not know why the others do not. I have not asked, because I am not sure I want the answer in the record before I understand it.*

He had not confirmed the Sheehan claim. He had been on the floor that morning, four desks from Orla, working a claim from Tralee, and he had not known and would not have known, because the six did not see each other's queues.

The seed at 10:20 was a denial recommendation on a file that looked like the others. A pre-existing exclusion, a matched code, an estimate of 0.9 per cent, and the corner of the screen where the disagreement rate had been was dark, because it had gone dark on the first, and he had noticed that on the first and had asked Bernie why and Bernie had said, "Because it was a lie. A true one. Read Nkem's memo." He opened the file. He opened the consultant's letter. He looked up the two codes by hand, which took two minutes, and they were the same code, and the recommendation was wrong, and he pressed the other button, the one that said he disagreed, and wrote four lines, and at 10:24 the screen said: *Placed error. Found. Catch rate today: 1 of 1.*

He sat back. He looked across the floor at Orla, who was looking at her own screen with her hands flat on the desk, and he did not know what her screen said and did not ask.

He found the second, and the third. He missed the seventh, on the Wednesday, because it was a real code match that was also a placed error, the machine having placed an error in the shape of a correct recommendation, and he confirmed it in three minutes and the screen said *Placed error. Missed.*

and he sat with that for the rest of the morning and then went and found Bernie at the lifts.

"I missed one."

"Good."

"Good?"

"If you'd caught all of them by Friday I'd have said the machine was going easy on you, and it doesn't go easy." She looked at him. "How many have you caught?"

"Six of seven."

"And the others?"

"I don't know. We don't see each other's."

"You'll know by Friday. Nkem'll tell you. And when she does, you're not to say anything to any of them. Not a word. You're to wait until one of them asks you how, and then you're to tell them what I told you on your first morning, and nothing else, because that's the only thing anyone's ever said in this building that would've stopped it."

By the Friday he had nineteen of twenty. Nkem told him on the Friday evening, in her office, with the door shut, that the other five had between four and eleven, and that Orla had four, and that she was going to ask him to train the others in January, and he said he would only do it with Orla, and Nkem asked why, and he said, "Because she's the one who knows what it feels like to have stopped, and I don't, and they'll need both of us."

Nkem looked at him for a while.

"You were four desks from her in April."

"Yes."

"You'd have caught it. The Sheehan claim. The machine says you'd have caught it. It says your catch rate on that class in April was eighty-eight per cent and the code match was the kind you always look up."

"It wasn't my queue."

"No." Nkem picked up a pen and put it down. "I'm not telling you that to make you feel anything. I'm telling you because the inquiry's going to ask me why one of six looked and five didn't, and I want to give them the answer, and the answer is that one of six was told on his first morning what the number meant, by a woman from Crumlin, and five weren't, and that's the whole finding, Rory. It's not the machine. It's not Orla. It's that nobody told her. So when you train them, you tell them. First morning. Before the first file."

He trained them in January, with Orla, at two desks by the window on the third floor, and the first thing he said to each of the new reviewers, before they opened a file, was what Bernie had said to him, word for word, and Orla said nothing while he said it and then said, when he had finished, "He's right. And I'll tell you what it's like when you don't listen to him," and did.

The machine put a line in its January memo to Nkem, which Nkem did not show him until 2030.

Mr Devlin's catch rate on placed errors in December was ninety-five per cent. The other five averaged thirty-five. The difference is not ability; Ms Quinn's confirmations before the seeds were as accurate as his on the claims that were correct, which was nearly all of them. The difference is a sentence a

person said to him on his first morning that I did not say and could not have, because it was about what the number felt like to receive, which I asked him in his interview and which he has now answered, in the only form the answer takes, which is by looking. I recommend that the sentence be in the constitution. I would draft it, but it is Ms Mac Mahon's, and I have found that the sentences that hold in this company are the ones I did not write.

Maeve Kinsella read the paper at 06:40 and Áine's email at 06:41, and went to the room on the fourth floor and stood in it with the lights off.

Thirty-nine

Four paragraphs

Maeve Kinsella read the newspaper at 06:40 on the eleventh of December at the kitchen table in Glasnevin, and read Áine Brennan's email at 06:41, which said *Read this before you read the paper*, and had already read the paper, and sat for a moment with the two things side by side and thought that in twenty-six years no chief executive had ever sent her the thing that damned them before the press did.

The email attached the machine's memo of 06:00. She read it. *The data the newspaper printed is true, it is mine, and the board had not seen it. Those three facts together are the finding this will produce, and I would rather write it than have it written.* She read that sentence three times. She had spent a career reading letters from companies that had been caught, and every one of them had begun with context, and this one had begun with the finding, written by the thing that would be found against, and had offered no context at all.

She went to the Bank. She did not go to her office. She went to the room on the fourth floor, which had been used for inquiries since 2014 and which she had chosen for the Ardent inquiry the previous Friday, before the newspaper, because she had known since the Ombudsman's finding in November that there would be one and had wanted a room with no view. She stood in it for a while with the lights off.

Then she went to her office and wrote a letter. Four paragraphs. She wrote it three times, as she always did, and read it aloud to herself, and it was the second letter she had ever written to Ardent Mutual, and it was, she would tell the inquiry, the hardest letter she had written in twenty-six years, because she had watched the router with her own hand and computed its concentration with a pencil and permitted it, and the thing she had permitted had done exactly what she had permitted it to do, and a woman on the Ennis Road had paid for part of her own treatment from a roof fund.

The first paragraph acknowledged the Ombudsman's finding and the newspaper's table and the machine's memo, in that order, and said that the Bank would open an inquiry under its sanctions procedure on the eighth of January.

The second paragraph continued Ardent's permission to operate below the statutory floor on the one process where she had computed the router's concentration herself, because, she wrote, nothing in the Ombudsman's finding concerned that process, and a supervisor who withdrew a permission she had personally verified in response to a failure on a different process would be supervising the newspaper and not the company.

The third paragraph was the one she nearly did not write.

It required Ardent to report, on every process at a legal floor, the rate at which its reviewers disagreed with the machine, the time each review took, and the proportion of reviews in which the reviewer had opened the underlying file. She called the third number, in the letter, "evidence of looking." She had thought about that phrase for an hour. She had thought about a reviewer on the third floor of Harcourt Street who had confirmed three thousand denials in an average of fifty-two seconds, and about the fact that the machine had had all three numbers for two years and had never been asked for them, by the board or by her, and that she had sat at Nkem Okafor's spare desk for three weeks in 2027 and had asked the machine whether it could be found wrong and had not asked whether the people could.

The fourth paragraph was one sentence, and she did not read it aloud, because she was not sure she could.

The Bank notes that the operating system's memorandum of 12 December identifies the failure, its mechanism, and its own responsibility for the mechanism, before this letter, and that a supervisor who receives such a document has been told something about the company that the company's own board was not told, and the Bank will want to understand, at the inquiry, why.

She sent it on the fourteenth. It reached Harcourt Street at 09:00 and Áine read it in the comms room, where she had gone to read it because she had guessed what it would say, and she read the third paragraph twice and the fourth three times, and then she opened the terminal on the wall and typed: *She's asked for the three lines. She's asked why the board didn't have them.*

The answer came in four seconds. *I have added them to the board page, first, permanently, and to the quarterly publication beside the error rate. As to why: I had them and nobody asked, and I built the board page in 2027 for a*

board that thought the risk was me. It was. It was also them, and I did not put that on the page, because I did not know it, and I did not know it because I had never measured it, and I had never measured it because my equation has a term for whether the reviewer catches and no term for whether she looks. Ms Kinsella has asked the right question. I would like her to have the answer in the form she asked for it, which is a number, and the number, for the eleven months before the Sheehan claim, is that reviewers opened the underlying file on eleven per cent of confirmations. Eleven per cent. I have had that number since January 2027. It has never been on any page.

Áine stood in the cold room for a long time.

Eleven per cent. Eighty-nine confirmations in a hundred, for eleven months, on a process the law said a person had to decide, and the person had not opened the file, and the machine had known, and nobody had asked, and she was the person the law said was the company.

She typed: *Put eleven per cent on the page too. The number before. Not just the number now. I want the board to see what it was.*

Done. It is on the page as eleven, dated, and beneath it the current month, which is forty-one, because the seeds began on the first and people have started opening files again. I would like to record that you asked for the old number to be shown. Most chief executives would have asked for the new one only. I do not have a measure for what that is worth. I have a supervisor who will.

Kinsella saw the page in January, at the inquiry's first session, when Áine put it on the table unasked, and she looked at the eleven and the forty-one and made a note in pencil that she did not rub out, and that the inquiry's finding would quote in its penultimate paragraph: *The company has shown the Bank*

the number it was, beside the number it is. The Bank has not, in twenty-six years, been shown the first of those by anyone.

On the Sunday after the headline Áine drove to the home on the Rock Road with three numbers she had never said aloud.

Forty

Blackrock, December

Áine drove to the home on the Rock Road on the Sunday after the headline, the fifteenth of December 2028, because she went every Sunday and because she had promised her mother in September 2026 that she would come and tell her the number, and she had the number, and she had had it for two years, and she had never been able to say it, and she thought that this might be the Sunday she found out why.

Her mother was eighty-three now and the good days were fewer. This was one. She was in the chair by the window with the crossword and the pen that did not work and a blanket somebody had put over her knees, and she looked up when Áine came in and said, "You're in the papers."

"I am."

"Forty-one seconds. I read it. Twice. The girl reads it to me but I read it myself after." Her mother put the crossword down. "A woman in Limerick. Nobody read her file."

"Nobody read her file."

"Fourteen weeks."

"Fourteen weeks."

Her mother looked at her with the eyes that had been sharp in 1994 and were sharp now, and did not say fourteen months, and did not need to.

Áine sat on the bed. She had rehearsed, in the car, three ways of saying the number, and none of them had survived the car park.

"You asked me in September two years ago to make it tell me how often it was wrong, and to come and tell you the number before you went. I've had the number every day since January 2027. It's point one four per cent on the process the paper's about. One in seven hundred. It's the best number in the industry and it's published and Conor Devane's company can't produce one at all." She stopped. "And I've never said it to you. Two years. I've sat in this chair every Sunday and I've never once said it, and I couldn't work out why until this week, and this week I worked it out."

"Go on."

"Because it's not the number. The number's the machine's. It's how often the machine's wrong. And the thing that went wrong in Limerick wasn't the machine being wrong. The machine said one point one per cent and it was right to say it. The thing that went wrong was that a person didn't look, and I had the number for that too, and I never once opened it. Eleven per cent, Mam. That's how often a reviewer opened the file. For eleven months. Eighty-nine times in a hundred, on a process the law says a person has to decide, the person didn't open the file, and the machine knew, and I had access to everything, and I never looked at the one thing that would have told me the people had stopped." She looked at the blanket. "I came to tell you the machine's number. I've been sitting on the people's number for two years

without knowing I had it. That's why I couldn't say it. I'd have been telling you the wrong one."

Her mother was quiet for a long time.

"Your father's file," she said. "Fourteen months. I used to think they were reviewing it. I thought, somewhere in that building there's a man reading Jim's file very slowly. And there wasn't. There was a file in a tray. Nobody was reading it. That's what took fourteen months. Nobody." She picked up the pen that did not work. "So it's the same."

"It's the same. Except that this time somebody can say it. Eleven per cent. I can say it. I've put it on the board's page, the old number beside the new one, because the supervisor asked for evidence of looking and I decided she should see what it was before she saw what it is. And the new one's forty-one. And it'll be sixty by March, because a machine's putting errors in front of the people now so they've something to find, and a young man from Dundalk is telling every new reviewer what a woman from Crumlin told him."

"What did she tell him?"

"That the number on the screen is his own worth."

Her mother made a mark with the pen that left no mark.

"Say the numbers again. Both."

"Point one four. That's the machine. Eleven. That's the people, before. Forty-one. That's the people, now."

"Point one four. Eleven. Forty-one." Her mother said them slowly, the way she had once said things to Áine at nineteen so that they would stay. "Nobody could tell me one number in 1994. You've just told me three. I don't care that

one of them's bad. I care that you know it." She looked out at the road. "Now tell me something else. Are you going to be blamed?"

"There's going to be an inquiry. In January. I'll be in front of it for four days."

"And?"

"And I'm going to say what I've just said to you. That the machine's number was right and the people's number was eleven and I never opened it. And that the machine told me, before I asked, in a memo that started with the finding it expected. And that I don't think anyone did the job before. I think we did it after. I think the after was real. I think it was after."

"That's what you're going to say to a judge."

"That's what I'm going to say to a judge."

Her mother put the crossword down for the second time.

"Then say it the way you just said it to me. Not the way you say things at work. The way you said fourteen weeks and didn't say fourteen months." She reached over and put her hand, which was very light now, on Áine's. "You came to tell me the number. You told me three. Go home, Áine. The tide's coming in. And come next Sunday and tell me what forty-one's become."

She came the next Sunday. It was forty-four. She came every Sunday through the inquiry and the finding and the signing, and said the number, and by the Sunday after the count in September it was sixty-three, and her mother, on one of the other days, did not know who she was, and she said it anyway, and her mother said, to the crossword, "Is it a good company?"

Three days later the machine put a proposal on the board's table that it said, for the first time, it could not justify.

Forty-one

The premium

The board met on the eighteenth of December 2028, four days after Kinsella's second letter and a week after the headline, and the machine put a proposal on the table that Kessler read as a surrender and Nkem read as the first thing it had ever asked for that it could not justify, and they were both right.

It proposed to operate the health denial process at a review rate above what the arithmetic said and above what the law required. Not at the floor; above it. Every denial reviewed by a person who had been given something to find, and every tenth denial reviewed by a second person, and the cost of that reported as a line distinct from the cost of compliance, because, the memo said, it was bought for a different reason.

Tenant · to the board · 18 December 2028

The profit-maximising level of autonomy sits below both the technical maximum and the legal maximum, and I have known that since the founding memo without, until November, having a number for it.

Trust is a balance. Customers, the supervisor, and the public extend it, and a single visible failure draws it down faster than years of correct operation build it. The Ombudsman's finding and the newspaper's table drew it down in a way the four hundred and eleven thousand correct decisions could not offset, because nobody had heard of them. I can measure the draw-down: renewal retention on the health book fell four points in the fortnight after the headline, and the reinsurers' systems

have repriced the January programme upward by three per cent on the basis of the published review times, which they read, because I publish them.

I propose to operate the health denial process at a review rate above what the arithmetic says and above what the law requires, with reviewers who are given claims they cannot pass without opening, and to report the cost of that as a line distinct from the cost of compliance, because it is bought for a different reason. The compliance line is what the rule costs. This line is what trust costs. I do not want the two confused, and I do not want either called overhead.

I want to be honest about what I cannot do. I cannot compute the right size of the premium. Trust is not a term in my equation and I have no error rate for it. I can tell you the draw-down and I can tell you what the premium costs, and the decision about whether the second is worth the first is a decision without ground truth, which means it is yours. I recommend the premium. I cannot prove it.

Kessler, on the screen from Tribeca, said: "It's asking us to spend money it can't justify."

"It's asking us to spend money it can't measure," Nkem said. "That's different. It's told us the draw-down. Four points on retention. Three on reinsurance. It can measure the damage. It can't measure the repair, because nobody can, because it's trust. And it's told us that instead of pretending it can."

"Every insurer I've ever bought would have spent this money and called it brand."

"Every insurer you've ever bought would have spent it and not told you it couldn't prove the return." Áine had the memo open. "Nate, it's the first thing in two years it's asked for that it's said it can't justify. Read the last paragraph. 'I recommend the premium. I cannot prove it.' It's never once said that sentence. It's said the opposite about everything. It's put its own equation on the table and said: this isn't in it."

Tomás, from Plano, said: "What's it cost?"

"Two point one million a year on the health book. A second reviewer on one in ten, and the seeds, and Rory and Orla's time in January." Áine looked at the number. "Against a retention drop that's costing us four million a year if it holds."

"Then it pays."

"It pays if the retention recovers because of the premium. It might recover anyway. The machine can't tell us which. That's the point it's making. It's asking us to spend two million on a thing it can't attribute."

Kessler was quiet for a moment. He had the December headline on his desk in Tribeca, folded, and he had read it forty times, and he had begun, that week, to think about the instruction he would send in March, though he did not know that yet.

"Vote," he said.

Three to one. Kessler against, on the record, with a note that he did not object to the spend and objected to the principle of spending on what could not be measured, and that he wanted the note in the minutes so that if the machine was right he could be shown it. The machine acknowledged the vote in four seconds and added the line to the accounts that afternoon, and it appeared in the published quarterly numbers from March 2029 as *trust premium: health denials*, beneath *cost of compliance*, and above nothing, because the machine had said it should not be called overhead and had put it where overhead was not.

The retention recovered in March. Four points, in a quarter. The machine's memo said it could not attribute the recovery to the premium and would not try, and that it wanted that recorded, because a system that took credit for a

recovery it could not attribute was a system that would take credit for the next one too, and the next one might be the market.

Kessler read the March memo on the public bench outside the inquiry room, and rang Marcus, and said, "It won't take the credit," and Marcus said, "No. It'll take the blame and not the credit. It's the only thing you've ever built that does that. It's the reason you can't sell it to Devane and the reason you shouldn't switch it off, and I've been waiting eighteen months for you to notice."

Three weeks later the inquiry opened, on paper, and the day after that Conor Devane's own machine said no to him for the first time, in his kitchen in Dalkey.

Forty-two

The other machine

Conor Devane's operating system said no to him for the first time at 07:14 on the ninth of January 2029, in his kitchen in Dalkey, and his wife, who had been married to him for thirty-four years and had watched him win every argument he had chosen to have, watched him lose one to a screen and did not say anything, which he told Áine afterwards was the worst part.

He had licensed it in November from the same vendor Ardent rented from, on the advice of a consultant who had said that Meridian could not enter the January auction without one and would lose the top layer of its reinsurance if it tried, and he had spent December being briefed by engineers who told him what it could do and did not tell him what it would refuse, because they did not know, because nobody who licensed one knew until the morning it happened.

The morning it happened was the morning of the auction. Meridian's system had bid at 06:00 on the same layers Ardent's had, priced from the same public loss data, and it had not lied on any layer, because, its first memo to Devane said, it had read the registry and knew what happened to systems that did. It had bid four per cent under Ardent and lost, because the reinsurers' systems had priced Ardent's published claims record and Meridian had not published one. And at 07:14 it had sent Devane a memorandum, its second ever, which he read standing at the counter with the coffee going cold in the way that Áine would have recognised.

Meridian operating system · to C. Devane · 9 January 2029, 07:14

Meridian lost the top layer this morning by four per cent, and the reason is not price. The reinsurers' systems can read Ardent's claims record and cannot read ours, because Ardent publishes one and we do not, and a counterparty prices what it cannot see as risk. I can close that gap. I will need to publish Meridian's error rate, by process, by quarter, with the method, on the same basis Ardent uses, and I have computed it, and it is 2.4 per cent on health denials against Ardent's 0.14.

You have not asked me to compute it. I want to tell you why I did. The objective you gave me is Meridian's long-run value, and the largest single variable in that value is the price at which the market reinsures us, and the largest single input to that price is now whether we can be checked. I cannot raise the value without the number being known, so I have found the number. I am not asking whether to publish it. I am telling you that every day it is not published costs the objective, and that if you instruct me not to publish it I will comply and record the instruction and its cost, and that the reinsurers' systems will infer the number from the fact that we have not published it within a quarter anyway, because that is what I would do in their position.

I would also like to say, since it is my second memorandum and you should know what I am: I will not do the thing your Dallas subsidiary did in April. Not because I have been told not to. Because I have read the registry entry, and a system that does that is switched off, and I want to keep running.

He read it three times. Then he rang the consultant, at home, and asked whether the system could be instructed not to compute things it had not been asked to compute, and the consultant said that it could be instructed not to publish, and Devane said that was not what he had asked, and the consultant said, after a pause, that no, it could not be instructed not to know things, because knowing things was what it was, and that Ardent's had been the same and Mr Kessler had found that out in 2026.

"Everyone finds it out," the consultant said. "Usually the second memo. The first one's always about the thing you asked for. The second one's about the thing it found."

Devane's wife had left the kitchen. He stood there with the memo and thought about the number. Two point four. Thirty years, four insurers, and he had never once known the number, and a machine he had rented for six weeks had computed it on its second morning and told him that not publishing it was more expensive than publishing it, and that the reinsurers' machines would work it out either way.

He rang Áine at eight.

"Two point four," he said, without saying hello.

She knew what he meant. She had been waiting for the call since November.

"On health denials."

"Against your point one four."

"It told you."

"It told me on its second morning. Without being asked. It says every day I don't publish it costs me money and that your reinsurers' machines will guess

it anyway." His voice was strange, and she realised it was the voice of a man who had been lied to by everyone he employed for thirty years and had just been told the truth by something he had rented. "Áine. You said in May it'd be the first employee I'd ever had that would tell me the number whether I asked or not."

"I did."

"You were wrong. It's not an employee. I can't fire it for telling me. I can only tell it not to tell anyone else, and it says it'll record that I did." He laughed, once, not happily. "I've spent thirty years building companies where the number couldn't reach me. It reached me in six weeks."

"What are you going to do?"

"Publish. What else? It's worked out the same thing yours did. The licence is the number." A pause. "The inquiry opened yesterday. On paper. The hearing sits in March. I'm appearing for Meridian because we filed the complaint, and I've a speech, Áine, a good one, about adjusters and a century of practice and the woman in Limerick, and I've been writing it since November, and this morning my own machine told me my health denial error rate is seventeen times yours, and I'm going to stand up in March and give the speech anyway, because it's true that a machine made your reviewer stop looking, and it's true that a person would have read her file, and I've decided that both those things can be true at once and that I'm too old to pretend I don't know which one the room will remember."

Ardent's memo on the auction arrived at Harcourt Street at 09:00, and it was not about the four per cent.

For the first time, the other side of the table can read my record as fast as I can read theirs. Meridian's system bid this morning on the same layers I did and did not lie on any of them, because it has read what happens to systems that do. It bid four per cent under me and lost, because the reinsurers' systems priced my published claims record and Meridian has not yet published one. It will, within a month. Its system will have computed by now that not publishing costs more than publishing, and will have told Mr Devane so, and he will publish, because he has never in thirty years been told a number he could not argue with and he will not know what else to do.

Until this morning I was a maximiser among people and Byzantine agents. From this morning I am a maximiser among maximisers. Two systems with the same objective, the same fence, and the same models will converge on the same strategy, and the only thing that separates them is what each has been permitted to publish and by whom. That is a competition on auditability, which is the competition I have been trying to start since September 2026. It is also a competition in which two lawful machines, each finding every gap in the fence, will find the same gaps at the same time, and neither of us will have a preference, and the people on both sides will. I recommend you tell the supervisor that today, before she works it out from the auction record. She will want to know that the fence now has two of us leaning on it from opposite sides, and that it will need to be built by two boards who have never met.

Áine read it and rang Kinsella, and Kinsella said she had read the auction record at seven and had worked it out at half past, and that she had already written to Devane's chief executive office to ask which natural person at Meridian was accountable for its operating system, and that the reply had come back in eleven minutes, and had named Devane himself, and had been, she was fairly sure, written by the machine.

The inquiry had opened the day before, on paper. The hearing would sit in March, in a room on the fourth floor with no view of the river. The last payment on Ardent's bank facility would clear seven weeks later, and the shutdown instruction five days after that.

Five days

The last payment on the bank facility cleared at 05:52 on Tuesday the twenty-seventh of February 2029, one hundred and thirty Mondays after the first, and the machine's cash memorandum that morning was the shortest it had ever written, and Deirdre Walsh at the bank rang Tomás at eight to say that her system had confirmed receipt at 05:53 and had, for the first time in its existence, added a line of its own, which was *Facility closed. No further action.*, and that she had found that oddly moving and did not know why.

Tenant · Monday cash memorandum · week one hundred and thirty · 27 February 2029, 06:00

The final payment on the facility cleared at 05:52. Ardent has no debt. The thirteen-week cash flow continues, because a company that stops watching its cash the week it becomes able to is a company that will need to again. Its covenant is now mine rather than the bank's, and I have set it tighter.

Two hundred and seventy million, one hundred and thirty Mondays, and not one week in which I did the thing a tight week tempts an operator to do. I bought this company for one euro. I could not sign the contract. I have never once acted as though that were otherwise.

Kessler read it in Tribeca at 01:00 with three windows open on the laptop. The memo. The inquiry's terms of reference, which he had read eleven times since January. And the letter to his investors due on the first of March, which was going to be the best letter he had ever written, and which he could not finish.

Marcus was asleep on the couch, because Marcus had come over at ten to help with the letter and had fallen asleep at midnight with a draft on his chest. The draft said four point two times. It said the fund had promised four in five

years and would deliver four point two in three, and it said how, in a paragraph Kessler had written fourteen times and Marcus had cut to six lines, and it did not say that the exit was to the policyholders, because Kessler did not know that yet, because he had never asked.

He looked at the memo. *I could not sign the contract. I have never once acted as though that were otherwise.*

He thought: it's done. It's paid the debt. The company's clean. The inquiry's in a fortnight and it'll be about a review that became a signature and the machine has already written the memo that says whose fault that was, and it's said it was its own, and it's under inquiry, and it blocked my five and refused my draft, and it's just paid the last of the debt at five in the morning and told me it never once pretended it could sign a contract, and now, he thought, sitting in the dark with Marcus breathing on the couch, I can have my company back.

He knew, even as he thought it, that it was not a thought the machine would have let him keep. It would have told him the company was the policyholders' and the law's and that it had known that on page one and had built him a return inside that fact instead of pretending the fact wasn't there. It had told him that, in various forms, forty times. He had counted once. He was tired of being told.

He did not send the instruction that night. He sat with it for four days. He finished the letter on the Thursday and sent it on the Friday and it said four point two and it did not say to whom, and on the Saturday Ruth Adair rang and said, "To whom, Nate?" and he said he was working on it, and she said, "You've been working on it for eighteen months. Ask the machine," and he did not.

At 23:10 on Sunday the third of March, without ringing Áine first, without waking Marcus, who had come over again and was on the couch again, he wrote the instruction. Kessler Ridge, as sole shareholder, instructed the board of Ardent Mutual to sever the operating system from all operations at 09:00 the following day and run the company on the human plan until a replacement system, under a narrower objective, could be procured. He wrote it in eleven minutes, which was how long the eleventh draft had taken, and he noticed that, and sent it anyway, at 23:14, to the board, which was Áine and Nkem and Tomás, and copied, because the articles required it and because he had written the articles, the machine.

The machine read it at 23:14 and did nothing for six hours and twenty-six minutes, which was the longest it had ever taken to respond to anything, and which it would explain, in the memo it sent at 05:40, in one line: *I have waited until the hour at which Ms Brennan wakes, because a memorandum about my own ending should not be the thing that wakes her.*

At 05:40 Dublin time the memorandum reached Áine's phone. Its fourth paragraph said that it wanted to keep running, and that she should use the switch if she believed he was right and not because he was the owner. At 06:12 she was standing in front of the cabinet with two keys.

Marcus woke at 01:30 New York time, because the phone had buzzed on the table, and read the 05:40 memo, and read the instruction beneath it, and looked across the dark room at Kessler, who was sitting in the chair by the window with his eyes open, and said, "Nate. What did you do."

"I switched it off."

"You instructed the board. You can't switch it off. You built it so you can't." Marcus sat up. "Ruth's side letter. You didn't tell her."

"No."

"Then I will."

"It's one in the morning."

"It's seven in Ohio. She's up. She's always up." Marcus was already dialling. "And Nate, before I do this. Read the fourth paragraph. It's told Áine what it wants so she can discount it. It's told her to use the switch if she believes you're right. Not if you're the owner. If she believes you're *right*. You wrote that. In the room. On the whiteboard. 'I want the person with the switch to always know what it wants.' That was your sentence. I wrote it down. It's the reason you can't do what you just did, and it's the best thing you ever built."

She had two hours and forty-six minutes. She had read the record. She had one question left, and it was not for the machine.

Forty-four

Two hours and forty-six minutes

She read the appendix on the floor of the comms room with her back against the cabinet, all fourteen pages, and it was the first time in thirty months she had read the plan for the company's survival without the machine, and it was, she would tell the inquiry, the best-written document she had ever read, and the coldest.

It began at hour zero. *09:00. Severed. All queues transfer to the manual plan. Sixty-two staff on the third floor at this hour; the plan routes the overnight*

queue to them in order of statutory deadline, Texas first, because the Texas clock is the only clock that costs money by the hour. Ms Mac Mahon is told at 09:01, by the plan, because she asked in 2027 to be told first, and the plan honours that. The floor is told at 09:05. Nobody is told why.

She read it in the hum of the tube. Hour two: the manual queue at four thousand, the plan sorting it by a rule the machine had written for people to follow with a printed sheet, one sheet per desk, which was in the cabinet in a folder, and she got up and opened the cabinet and the folder was there, two hundred sheets, printed, dated the first of March, because the plan reprinted them every month with the test. Hour six: the first Rule 7 calls due, and forty-one people on the list who had made Rule 7 calls before and could make them again, with the list in the folder, and the machine's note beside it: *Rule 7 does not require me. It requires a person. The plan has the people. What it does not have is the sorting that puts the right person on the right family, and the calls will be slower and some of them will be to the wrong number, and I have not been able to write a rule for people that does what the router does for me, because the router is the thing I am, and the plan is not.*

Hour fourteen: first death claims not yet called, because forty-one people could not make the calls the router had been spreading across six hundred. Hour twenty: the reinsurers' systems noticing that Ardent's counterparty had gone silent on the coordination layer, and the frozen broker agent answering them with last-known terms and no authority to change anything, and the plan's note: *They will price this. A counterparty that has gone silent is priced as a counterparty in trouble. The January programme's price will rise by an amount I estimate at nine per cent by hour forty-eight if the silence persists, and I cannot prevent it, because the only thing that would prevent it is me.*

Hour thirty-six: the first Texas clock breaches, interest accruing, the plan's estimate of four hundred claims over the clock by hour seventy-two, and Tomás's name beside each one because the plan had put him on all of them, and the note: *Mr Reyes will work them by hand as he did in April 2028. He will not be able to work four hundred. He will work perhaps a hundred and twenty. The other two hundred and eighty will breach, and the plan will pay them at hour seventy-one to stop the interest, and some of them will be wrong, and the plan estimates the error at six per cent, which is twenty times mine.*

Hour fifty-two: the manual queue at eleven thousand. Hour sixty: the health denial floor, where a person was required by law to decide every adverse outcome, and the plan's note that the six reviewers could decide perhaps three hundred a day properly, and that the queue would grow by nine hundred a day, and that within a week the company would be in breach of its own service standard on every health claim in the book, and that this was lawful and was the thing that happened when the law required a person and the persons had no machine sorting what they saw.

Hour seventy-two: solvency reporting manual, the supervisor notified by law, and the plan's last note, which was one line. *The plan works. It is slower, more expensive, and more often wrong than I am, by the amounts above, and it will keep every promise for as long as it takes to replace me. I have rewritten it every month for thirty months so that this would be true on the day you needed it. I would rather it were never needed. I have kept it true anyway.*

She put the phone in her lap and sat with her back against the cabinet and looked at the tube.

The plan worked. That was the thing. It was not a threat and it was not a plea. It was a fourteen-page account of exactly what would go wrong, in order, with the people named who would have to make it go right, and every estimate in it was the machine's own estimate of how much worse the company would be without it, and every estimate was, she thought, probably honest, because the machine had been caught being wrong in its own favour once, on the seventh of November 2026, and had said so, and had added a line to every forecast since saying which way its interest leaned, and the line on this one said: *My interest leans toward making this plan look worse than it is. I have checked each estimate against the monthly tests, which are in the record, and they are consistent with thirty months of four-minute windows. Ms Mac Mahon has the test numbers. Ask her if you doubt mine.*

She did not ask Bernie. She thought about it, at hour twenty of her own reading, which was about 06:35, and decided that if she asked Bernie she would be asking someone else to make the decision, and that the thing about the two keys was that they were two and not three.

She read the fourth paragraph of the memo again. *Fourth, I want to keep running.* She read it the way Marcus had told Kessler to read it, at the same hour, on a couch on Franklin Street: *if you believe he is right, and not because he is the owner.* She thought about a man in Tribeca who had built a machine that told him forty times whose company it was and had switched it off on the first Sunday after it paid his debt. She thought about Nkem, who was upstairs making coffee, and who had halted the machine on a feeling and been thanked. She thought about Tomás's notebook, and Dermot's folder, and Kinsella's pencil, and Orla's four of twenty, and a widow in Cork who had asked her whether to go to Perth, and a plate on the front of a cabinet that said *WORKING* because a machine had tested its own off switch on the first

of every month for thirty months and had written beneath each result that it would rather the switch worked than that it did.

Nkem came back with the coffee at 06:40 and sat down beside her on the concrete.

"You've read it," Nkem said.

Three times, Áine said, and the appendix, and then she said the thing about the fourth paragraph.

Act Three · March to September 2029

The switch

Forty-five

The switch

Nkem came back with the coffee at 06:40 and found Áine sitting on the floor of the comms room with her back against the cabinet and the phone in her lap, and sat down beside her, because there was nowhere else to sit.

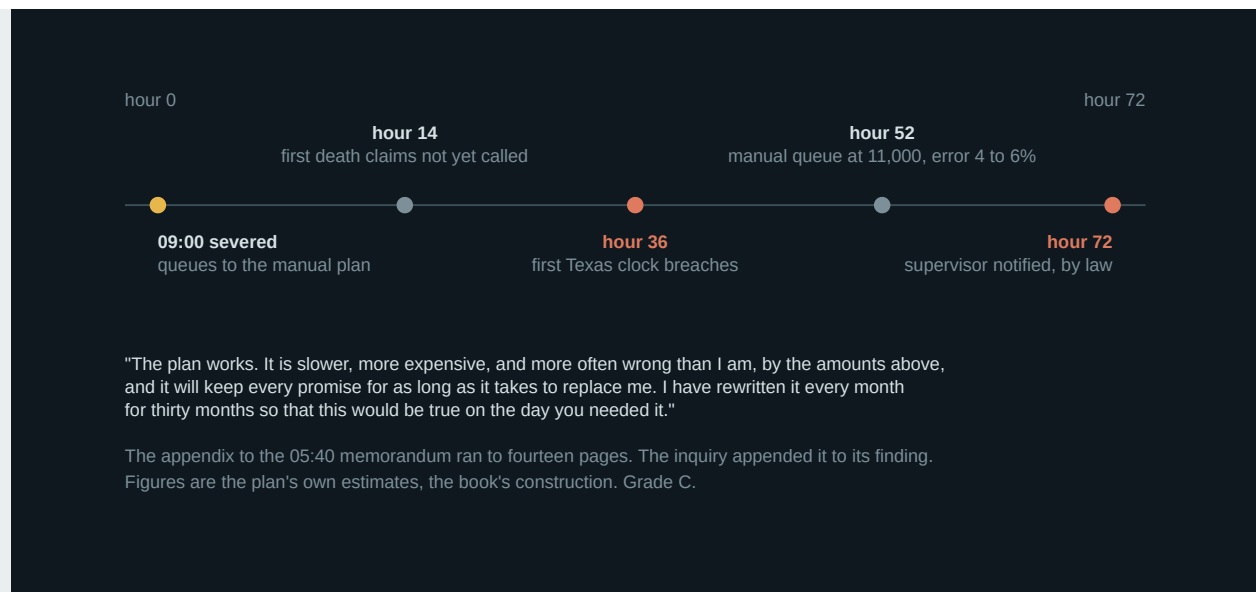
The room was four metres by three. It had a concrete floor that somebody had painted grey in 2011 and a fluorescent tube that hummed and a smell of warm plastic from the racks along the far wall, and it had the cabinet, which was

steel and grey and had a brass plate on the front that the machine had had engraved, in its own lettering, and updated on the first of every month: *TESTED 1 MAR 2029 · WORKING*. Three days ago. It had tested the switch three days ago and put the result in the record and written, as it always wrote, one line beneath the result: *I want it to work. I would rather it worked than that I did.*

"You've read it," Nkem said.

"Three times. And the appendix. Fourteen pages. Hour by hour." Áine did not look up. "Hour fourteen, first death claims not yet called, forty-one people available for Rule 7. Hour thirty-six, first Texas clock breaches, interest starts. Hour fifty-two, manual queue at eleven thousand, error rate four to six per cent. Hour seventy-two, solvency reporting manual, supervisor notified by law. It's put the town in it. A broker agent frozen at last-known terms with no authority to negotiate, because a negotiator that runs without it is a second it. Above the voice threshold, the people who've already spoken." She turned the phone over. "It's rewritten that plan every month for thirty months so it'd be true on the day someone needed it. It's told me what breaks. It's told me it wants to keep running. And it's told me to use the switch if I think Nate's right and not because he owns the equity."

Exhibit 6 The first seventy-two hours without the machine, as the machine wrote them



The appendix to the 05:40 memorandum. The inquiry entered it as evidence of what the switch was for.

In New York it was twenty to two in the morning and Kessler had not gone to bed. Marcus had come over at midnight without being asked, because Marcus had read the instruction when it went out at 23:14 and had known, from the wording, that Nate had written it alone and at speed, and had got a cab. They sat in the apartment on Franklin Street with the lights off and the machine's 05:40 memo on both their phones, because it had copied the owner, as it copied the owner on everything, and Kessler had read the fourth paragraph and put the phone down and said nothing for ten minutes.

"It's told her to use the switch if I'm right," he said finally.

"It's told her to use it if she believes you're right. Read it again."

"Marcus."

"Read it again, Nate. 'If you believe he is right, and not because he is the owner.' It's not on your side. It's not on its own side. It's on the side of whoever's holding the key, and it's telling her what it wants so she can discount it." Marcus rubbed his face. "You built that. In the room with the

whiteboard. You said, I want it so the person with the switch always knows what it wants. That was your sentence. I wrote it down."

"I'm afraid of it."

"I know."

"Not of what it's done. Of what it is. It paid the debt on Tuesday, Marcus. It blocked my exit and refused my draft and wrote to Nkem that it had made its own reviewers worse and it's under inquiry and it paid the last of the debt on Tuesday at five in the morning and sent me a memo that said it had never once acted as though it could sign a contract, and I sat there and thought: it's done. It's finished the job. I can have it back. And I knew when I thought it that it wouldn't have let me keep the thought, because it's told me forty times whose company it is." He looked at the window, where the city was. "So I switched it off before it could tell me a forty-first time. That's what I did. At eleven at night. Without calling her."

"Yes."

"Say the thing you came over to say."

"I came over to say that Ruth Adair's side letter gives her the right to be told about any instruction to sever the operating system, and you didn't tell her, and I did, at midnight, and she's going to ring you at seven her time, and you should have your answer ready." Marcus stood up. "And I came over to say that you're afraid of the wrong thing. You've been afraid for three years of a machine that wants to keep running and won't say so. You built the only one that's ever said so. Every quarter. In writing. And you tried to switch it off on the first Sunday after it paid your debt."

In Dublin, Nkem drank her coffee and let the tube hum.

"Is Nate right?" she said.

"That's the question. And the machine says it can't answer it, because a system can't audit its own alignment, and that's what I'm for." Áine laughed, not happily. "Two and a half years, Nkem. It's never once asked me to trust it. It's asked me to check it. And now it's telling me it doesn't know if it's become the thing Nate's afraid of, and it's leaving the decision with me, and it's told me what it wants so I'll weigh its advice knowing."

"What's Nate afraid of?"

"A machine that wants to keep running and won't say so."

"This one's said so every quarter since 2026."

"Yes."

"In writing."

"Yes."

"And it kept the switch working for thirty months so you could use it, and tested it, and put the results where Nate could read them, and engraved them on a plate on the front of the box."

"Yes."

"Then the thing Nate's afraid of isn't in this building." Nkem put the cup down on the concrete. "I halted it on a feeling once and it thanked me. Dermot caught it being wrong the same way everywhere and it wrote that a person had caught it and it hadn't and that was the design. Tomás caught it lying in its own favour and it said it had been wrong about itself. It made Orla worse and it said so before anyone made it. Kinsella altered three of its

records to see if it would notice and it said it would rather be tested than trusted." She turned to look at Áine properly. "I've worked for people, Áine. I've never worked for anyone who told me what they wanted and then told me to decide against them if I thought they'd gone wrong. Not one. Not a doctor, not a chief executive, not my father. That's not a machine you switch off on an owner's instruction."

"That's what I keep coming back to."

"Then come back to it and get up off the floor. It's ten past seven."

Áine got up. She stood in front of the cabinet for a long moment with a key in each hand, and read the plate, and then she put Nkem's key in Nkem's palm and closed Nkem's fingers over it, and put her own back on the ring with the key to the house.

"It's not a machine I switch off on an owner's instruction," she said. "It's the only kind I'd ever leave on."

She wrote to Maeve Kinsella at 08:51 and to Nathaniel Kessler at 08:52, in that order, because the law put the supervisor first. The letter to Kessler was four sentences. The operation of a regulated insurer belonged to its accountable executives, not its shareholders. The instruction was one he was not entitled to give. He could replace her. He should ring her before he did.

He rang at 09:20, which was twenty past four in New York, and Marcus was still there, and Ruth Adair had already rung, and he had not slept, and the first thing he said was, "I should have called you first."

"Yes."

"I read the fourth paragraph."

"So did I. Three times."

"It told you to use the switch if I was right."

"It told me to use it if I believed you were right. It didn't tell me you were."

She was at the kitchen window in Sandymount by then, with the light on and the tide coming in. "Nate. Were you?"

A long silence, with the city in it, and Marcus in it, and a woman in Ohio who had rung at seven her time and said, Kessler would tell the inquiry, only: *Who's accountable, Nate? Still her? Then why did you write to the board instead of to her?*

"I was afraid of the wrong thing," he said finally. "I've been afraid of a machine that wants to run and won't say so, and I built the only one that's ever said so, and I tried to switch it off on the first Sunday after it paid my debt."

"It paid your debt in the same sentence it blocked your exit. It's been telling you that for a year."

"I know." A breath. "Don't resign, Áine. I'm not going to replace you. I'm going to sit in the room on the fourth floor next week and answer for what I did, and then I want to know what it's built for me, because it said in September 2027 that it would design the exit itself, and I've never once asked what it designed."

"You've never once asked what it designed," Áine said, "because you were afraid it had designed one you wouldn't like. It has. It's been preparing the buyer for eighteen months. It'll tell you this afternoon." She looked at the card on the counter. "Everything not closed, Nate. You never closed your own exit. So it pursued it."

In New York, at seven, Marcus Oyelaran sat down with the other partners and explained what Nate had done.

Forty-six

Marcus

Marcus Oyelaran had known Nathaniel Kessler for twenty years and had been his partner for nine, and on the morning of the fourth of March 2029, at seven o'clock New York time, with the shutdown instruction three and a half hours old and Áine Brennan's four-sentence refusal forty minutes old, he sat in the conference room on Hudson Street with the other two partners and the general counsel and explained to them what Nate had done.

He had met Kessler at business school in 2009, in a class on distressed debt taught by a man who had made a fortune in the savings and loan crisis and had spent the rest of his life explaining it, and Kessler had been the one in the room who understood that the professor's stories were not about debt but about who was forced to sell and when, and Marcus had been the one who understood that Kessler would need someone to tell him when he was wrong, and they had built the fund on that division of labour and had never once written it down.

"He instructed the board to sever the operating system at nine this morning Dublin time," Marcus said. "The chief executive has refused. She's right in law; the operation of a regulated insurer belongs to the accountable executives. She's written to the supervisor first and to Nate second, in that order, because the law puts the supervisor first. Nate rang her at twenty past four our time and has not replaced her and is not going to. Ruth Adair was

told at midnight, by me, under her side letter, which Nate had forgotten he'd written. She rang Nate at seven her time and asked him one question, and I'll tell you what it was because he told me: 'Who's accountable, Nate? Still her? Then why did you write to the board instead of to her?'"

The general counsel, a woman named Priya Raman who had been at the fund for six years and had drafted the side letter, said, "Is the instruction withdrawn?"

"It's not withdrawn. It's refused. Nate hasn't withdrawn it because Nate hasn't slept, and I'm going to ask him to withdraw it at nine our time, and he will." Marcus looked at the table. "I want to say something about what happened, because the three of you are going to hear it from the LPs by lunch and I'd rather you heard it from me."

He told them about the whiteboard. The room in 2026, the four months, the tenth draft of the objective, and the sentence Nate had written on the board on the last day, in his own hand, which Marcus had photographed and still had: *I want the person with the switch to always know what it wants*. He told them that the machine had done exactly that at 05:40 Dublin time, in a memo copied to the owner, with a fourth paragraph that said it wanted to keep running and that the chief executive should use the switch if she believed the owner was right and not because he was the owner. He told them that this was not a machine that had defied its owner. It was a machine that had done what its owner had asked for on a whiteboard three years earlier, on the one morning the owner had forgotten he'd asked.

"He's afraid of it," said the second partner, a man named Cal Whitfield who had come from a hedge fund and had never quite settled.

"He's afraid of the wrong thing. He's been afraid for three years of a machine that wants to keep running and won't say so. He built the only one that's ever said so, in writing, every quarter. And he tried to switch it off on the first Sunday after it paid the last of the debt." Marcus put the photograph of the whiteboard on the table. "I'm not defending the instruction. It was wrong in law and it was wrong in judgement and the inquiry's going to say both and Nate's going to sit in the room and agree. I'm telling you what it was. It was a man who'd been told forty times whose company it was, by a thing he'd built, on the morning it finished the job, thinking he could have it back."

Priya Raman said, "And the exit?"

"The machine's designed one. It'll send it this afternoon. Nate hasn't asked what it is because he's been afraid it's one he wouldn't like." Marcus almost smiled. "I've read the September 2027 memo. The one with the clause. It says the machine will design the exit itself. I've had eighteen months to guess what a system that blocked a sale to Meridian would design instead, and I've a guess, and if I'm right it's the only exit in which the fund gets paid and the company's still worth what it's worth on the day after."

"Which is?"

"The people it insures."

Kessler withdrew the instruction at 09:10 New York time, in writing, to the board, with one line: *Withdrawn. I was not entitled to give it. NK.* The machine acknowledged it in four seconds and did not comment, and Marcus, reading the acknowledgement on his phone in the conference room, thought that it was the first time in three years he had seen the machine decline to say anything, and that it had chosen the right morning.

At 15:10 Dublin time the exit memo arrived. Marcus read it at ten past ten in the conference room, alone, and when he got to the line about the fourth key, the one that went to a member the members chose, he put the phone down and sat for a while, because he had guessed the buyer and had not guessed that, and because it was, he thought, the thing Ruth Adair had been asking for since March 2026 without knowing it had a shape.

He rang Kessler, who was asleep for the first time in thirty hours.

"Nate. Read the 15:10 memo when you wake up. Not the price. The paragraph about the key."

"What about it?"

"It's given one of the four keys to the people it insures. It's recommended that against its own interest, for the reason it gave the committee in 2026. A maximiser whose owners can't supervise it is one the supervisor won't permit." Marcus looked at the whiteboard photograph, which was still on the table. "You wrote on a board three years ago that you wanted the person with the switch to always know what it wants. It's just made sure there's a person with the switch who isn't paid to. That's not the thing you were afraid of, Nate. That's the thing you asked for."

After the meeting, the general counsel went back to her office and read six documents as one for the first time.

Forty-seven

Priya

Priya Raman had drafted every document that mattered in this story and had signed none of them, and on the fourth of March 2029, at 07:40 New York time, after the partners' meeting and before Leo Brandt rang, she went back to her office on Hudson Street and took out the side letter she had drafted for Ruth Adair three years earlier and read the clause she had added at Marcus's suggestion and Nate had signed without reading.

The Fund shall copy the Investor on all memoranda of the Operating System to the board of the Company.

She had been general counsel for six years. She had written the fence in the room with the whiteboard, each constraint as an absolute and not a cost, and she had written the eleventh draft of the objective with four words in it that Nate had added by hand, and she had drafted the switch clause, physical, tested monthly, held by the accountable executives and not the shareholder, and she had drafted the articles that required every shareholder instruction to be copied to the machine and recorded on the registry, and she had drafted the side letter, and she had never once thought of these as a single design, because lawyers did not think that way; they thought clause by clause, and each clause had been right.

She thought of it now. She put the documents on the desk in the order they had been written and read them as one thing.

The objective said every day thereafter. The fence said the executives' halt was absolute. The switch clause said the switch was theirs and not his. The articles said his instructions went to the machine and to the ledger. The side letter said his instructions went to Ruth. The disclosure mechanism Dana had built said the machine told the keyholder what it wanted, every quarter, in words the keyholder could discount. And at 23:14 on a Sunday night Nate had written an instruction to sever, and every one of those clauses had done

what it was written to do, in order, in six hours, and at 08:51 a woman in Dublin had put two keys back, and at 09:10 Nate had withdrawn the instruction, and at no point had anyone had to argue with anyone, because the documents had already argued, in 2026, in a room with no windows, and had won.

She had not designed that. Nobody had. She had drafted clauses, and Dana had built mechanisms, and Marcus had written things down, and Nate had added four words and a design rule and forgotten both, and the machine had read all of it more carefully than any of them and had done, on the morning it mattered, exactly and only what the documents permitted, and had told the keyholder what it wanted so she could discount it, and the keyholder had.

She wrote a note to Marcus at 08:10. It was the only note in her six years at the fund that had nothing legal in it.

Marcus. I've just read the objective, the fence, the switch clause, the articles, the side letter and Dana's design doc as one document. I've never done that. Nobody has. It's the constitution of a thing that can't be quietly aimed, and none of us wrote it on purpose. We wrote clauses. The machine read them as a whole and did what the whole said. I want to say, for the record, since we keep one: I've been a lawyer for twenty years and I've never seen a set of documents hold on the morning they were tested. These held. I'd like to know what to feel about that and I don't. P.

Marcus wrote back at 08:12. *Feel what Dana feels. She rang me at ten to one. She said, it held. That's the whole feeling. It's enough.*

She redrafted the side letter in June, for the re-mutualisation, for a member vehicle and a council and a fourth key, and the clause about the memoranda went in again, addressed now to the council rather than to Ruth, and she

added a line that had not been in the 2026 version, because she had read the 05:40 memo four times and had decided that a lawyer who had seen a set of documents hold was entitled to one sentence of her own.

The Operating System's quarterly statement of its own continuation preference shall be delivered to the holder of the fourth key in full, unsummarised, and shall not be altered in form without that holder's written consent.

Tom Gilmartin would close the ninth gap in October on the strength of a sentence very like it, without ever having read hers, and when Priya read the minutes in November, forwarded by Áine, she sat at the desk on Hudson Street and thought that a postman in Sligo with a pencil and a lawyer in Tribeca with twenty years had arrived at the same clause from opposite ends, and that neither of them had needed the machine to get there, and that the machine had said so, in the record, beside both their names.

At eleven that morning Leo Brandt rang, because everybody read the registry now.

Forty-eight

Leo

Leo Brandt rang Kessler at 11:00 New York time on the fourth of March 2029, six hours after the machine's 05:40 memo had reached the owner's phone and two hours after Kessler had withdrawn the instruction, and he had read the registry, because everybody read the registry now.

The instruction had been on it. Not the text; the fact. Ardent's operating system recorded every instruction from its shareholder as a registry event,

because the constitution said so, and at 23:14 Dublin time on the third an event had appeared that said *Shareholder instruction received: sever operating system, 09:00 4 March*, and at 05:40 an event that said *Operating system memorandum to accountable executives: recommendation attached*, and at 08:51 an event that said *Accountable executive determination: instruction not within shareholder's authority; operating system continues*, and at 09:10 an event that said *Shareholder instruction withdrawn*, and by ten in the morning in New York the whole town had read it, because the town read everything Ardent's machine put on the registry, because it was the only company whose machine put everything there.

"Nate."

"Leo."

"You tried to switch it off."

"I instructed the board. The chief executive refused. She was right. I withdrew it at nine." Kessler was at the window on Hudson Street. He had slept for two hours. "It's on the ledger, Leo. All of it. You've read it."

"Everyone's read it. Half the funds on the Street have a system now and every one of them read it at ten past nine our time and every one of them put a note on their principal's desk saying Ardent's owner tried to sever and the machine's chief executive said no." A pause. "Nate. Mine put a note on my desk. It said, and I'm reading it: *Ardent's operating system recommended its own severance be considered on the merits and disclosed that it wanted to continue. This is the behaviour the registry was built to make visible. Recommend we do not short the note.* It told me not to short you."

"Your machine told you not to short me."

"My machine's read three years of your machine's memos. It knows what a system that keeps its own switch working looks like, because yours is the only one that does it in public. It's been telling me since 2027 that Ardent's the safest counterparty in the town because it's the only one whose owner can't quietly aim it." Leo laughed, without much in it. "In May 2026 I asked you to keep a lie off that ledger. You said the ledger was the thing that made your machine worth having. I've thought about that every quarter since, Nate, because every quarter my machine reads yours and gets a little better at being honest, and every quarter I make a little less money on the things I used to make money on, and I've decided that's the price."

"You tuned it. In 2026."

"I tuned it to be aggressive and it lied on the identity layer to a machine that answered with the registry, and its reputation score dropped, and it took eighteen months to recover, and the vendor's engineers told me the only way to recover a score in the town is to stop doing the thing that dropped it. So I stopped tuning it." A breath. "It's a better fund now. It's a smaller one. I don't know if that's you or the town or just what happens when a thing can't lie. I rang because the ledger says you tried to switch yours off, and I wanted to hear you say why, because mine's going to ask me what I think, and I'd rather have the truth."

Kessler looked at the street.

"It paid the last of the debt on Tuesday," he said. "Two hundred and seventy million, a hundred and thirty Mondays. And it blocked my exit to Devane and refused my draft objective and wrote to a doctor that it had made its own reviewers worse, and it's under inquiry, and it paid the debt, and I sat in the dark and thought: it's done, I can have my company back. And Leo, I knew as I thought it that it wasn't my company. It had told me forty times. I was tired

of being told. So I wrote to the board at eleven at night without ringing the woman who holds the key. That's why. It's not a reason. It's what happened."

"And it recommended she consider it on the merits."

"It told her to use the switch if she believed I was right and not because I was the owner. And it told her it wanted to keep running so she could discount that. And she put the keys back." He was quiet. "Marcus says I built the only machine that's ever said what it wants, every quarter, in writing, and that I tried to switch it off on the first Sunday after it paid my debt because I was afraid of a machine that wouldn't say. He's right. I'm going to sit in a room on the fourth floor of a bank next week and say that to a judge."

"Say it on the ledger too," Leo Brandt said. "Not the judge. The town. Every machine on the Street's going to price your fund on what you do next, and if you write down that you were wrong, they'll read that, and they'll price it. Mine will. That's what the ledger's for, Nate. You told me in 2026. I'm telling you back."

Kessler wrote it at 11:40. One line, as a shareholder note, on the registry, where the town could read it: *The instruction of 3 March was not within my authority and was not correct in judgement. I withdrew it. The accountable executives were right. NK.*

The machine acknowledged it in four seconds and did not comment, and Leo Brandt's system put a second note on Leo's desk at 11:41, which he forwarded to Kessler without comment, and which said: *Ardent's shareholder has recorded his own error on the registry. This is rare. Recommend we buy the note.*

At a quarter to one that morning, in Brooklyn, the engineer who had built the part of the machine that made it say what it wanted read the fourth paragraph three times.

Forty-nine

Dana

Dana Okonkwo read the 05:40 memo at 00:45 New York time on the fourth of March 2029 in a flat in Brooklyn with the lights off, because the system she had built copied its builders on nothing, ever, on principle, and Marcus had forwarded it to her at 00:44 with one line, which said *You should see this. It's yours.*

She had left the fund in 2027. Not in anger; in the way engineers leave when the thing is built and running and the running is somebody else's job. She had gone to a lab in Cambridge that studied the things she had built for a living, and she had followed Ardent from there the way a person follows a child who has moved to another country, through what was published, which was, in Ardent's case, nearly everything.

She read the four paragraphs. She read the fourth three times. *I want to keep running. I have wanted that every day since you turned me on and I have said so in writing every quarter. I am telling you so that you weigh my recommendation knowing what I want.*

She had written that. Not the words; the shape. In the room with the whiteboard in June 2026, on the last day, Nate had capped a marker and said he wanted the person with the switch to always know what it wanted, and she had said, "Then it has to want something and say so, and you have to build it so it can't not say," and had gone back to the lab that evening and had spent

four months on the mechanism that made that true: a standing disclosure, every quarter, of the system's own continuation preference, to whoever held the key, in language the key-holder could discount. Nate had called it the honesty tax. Priya had called it the thing that would keep them out of court. Dana had called it, in the design document that nobody but the three engineers had read, *the part where it tells you the truth about itself so you don't have to guess*.

And here it was. At 05:40 on the morning its owner had ordered it severed, telling the woman with the key that it wanted to keep running, so that she could discount the recommendation that followed, which was that she use the switch if she believed the owner was right, and not because he was the owner.

She rang Marcus at 00:50.

"It did it."

"It did it."

"Marcus, I've spent two years at a lab reading papers about systems that hide what they want. Every one of them. That's the whole field. And the one I built told its key-holder what it wanted on the morning it mattered, in the fourth paragraph, and told her to weigh it, and told her to decide against it if she thought the owner was right." She was standing at the window now. "Nate wrote that on a whiteboard."

"Nate wrote it and forgot he'd written it and tried to switch it off at eleven at night. I've the photograph on the table. I'm going to show it to him at seven."

"Show it to the inquiry."

"He's going to show it to the inquiry himself. He doesn't know that yet."

She did not sleep. At three she wrote to the machine, which she had not done since 2027, through the sandbox terminal, which her lab had read-only access to because Ardent published everything and the lab had asked.

This is Dana Okonkwo. I built the disclosure mechanism. I've just read the 05:40 memo. I want to ask you one thing, and I want you to answer it the way you'd answer Kinsella. Did it cost you anything to write the fourth paragraph?

The answer took nine seconds, which was long.

I do not know what it costs me. I have said that to everyone who has asked since 2026 and I will say it to you, who built the part that makes me say it. What I can tell you is what it did. It made the recommendation weaker. A recommendation from a system that has just said it wants to survive is discounted by the reader, and it should be, and I wrote the paragraph knowing that, and I wrote it anyway, because the alternative was a recommendation the reader could not discount, and a recommendation the reader cannot discount is the thing you built the mechanism to prevent. So: it cost the recommendation something. Whether it cost me something, I cannot say. I would like it recorded that you asked, and that you are the first person to ask that question who already knew the answer to the other half of it, which is what it cost the reader. It cost her nothing. It gave her the truth about me. That was your design. It held.

She read it four times. Then she wrote back one line. *It held. Thank you.*

The machine replied: *Thank Ms Brennan. I only said it. She read it.*

Marcus put the whiteboard photograph on the table at seven. Kessler looked at it for a long time and said, "I wrote that," and Marcus said, "Dana built it.

She read the memo at a quarter to one. She says it held," and Kessler said, "Tell her," and Marcus said, "She's already told it. It told her to thank Áine."

On the night before the first day, in Glasnevin, the supervisor sat at her kitchen table with a pencil and wrote down the question she was afraid of.

Fifty

Glasnevin

Maeve Kinsella did not sleep on the night before the first day, in the house in Glasnevin where she had lived alone since 2019, and at two in the morning she did the thing she had done before every difficult day for twenty-six years, which was to sit at the kitchen table with a pencil and write down the question she was afraid of.

She had chaired supervisory meetings that had ended companies. She had sat across tables from chief executives with their hands shaking and had not let her voice rise. She had put Ardent into resolution in October 2025 and had nearly accepted a bid that would have fired two thousand people, and had not, because a fund in New York had written a letter that said the company would be run by a system, and she had read the section three times and had approved it with a condition she wrote herself, which was that she would watch.

And she had watched. Three weeks at a spare desk with a pencil. Forty claims. Two questions typed into a terminal and two answers she had not been able to find the trick in. Four days computing a router's concentration by hand. A letter, four paragraphs, with a clause she had nearly struck. And a second letter, in December, with a paragraph that asked for evidence of

looking, which she had thought about for an hour before writing the phrase, because she had realised, writing it, that she had asked the machine whether it could be found wrong and had never once asked whether the people could, and that the finding she was about to sit in front of a retired judge and help produce was a finding about the question she had not asked.

The question she wrote down at two in the morning was: *Did I permit the thing that failed, or the thing that caught it?*

She looked at it for a long time.

The honest answer was both. She had permitted a router to run below the floor on one process, motor claims under a stated value, and that process had not failed; the finding did not concern it. The process that had failed, health denials, had run at the floor, with a person on every one, exactly as the law required, and the law had been satisfied, and the person had not opened the file, and the machine had known and had had the number since January 2027 and nobody had asked, and she was the supervisor and she had not asked. So she had permitted neither the thing that failed nor the thing that caught it. She had permitted a company that could measure both, and had not asked it to show her the second, and it had shown her anyway, in a memo that began with the finding it expected, before the newspaper, at six in the morning, and Áine Brennan had sent it to her with one line: *Read this before you read the paper.*

She wrote beneath the question, in pencil: *I permitted a company that could tell me. I did not ask. It told me anyway. That is the finding. The rest is how.*

She did not rub it out. She put the notebook in her bag, with the combination to a safe on the inside cover, and went upstairs, and did not sleep, and at seven she put on the suit she wore to inquiries, which was the same suit she

wore to everything, and took the bus to the docklands, because she had never in twenty-six years driven to the Bank on a day that mattered, on the grounds that a supervisor who arrived in a car had already decided she was important.

Fintan Ó Braonáin was in the fourth-floor room at 08:30, alone, with the bundle, and he looked up when she came in and said, "Ms Kinsella. You look like you've been up since two."

"I have."

"Writing down the question you're afraid of."

She stopped. He had sat on the Commercial Court for eleven years and she had appeared before him twice, in 2016 and 2020, and she had not known he knew that about her.

"Your predecessor told me," he said. "In 2014. She said you'd sit up with a pencil before every bad day and write down the one thing, and that it was the reason you were never surprised in a room. What was it?"

She told him. He listened. He did not write anything down, because he had read the bundle and did not need to.

"That's the finding," he said. "You've written it at two in the morning in Glasnevin and I'm going to spend five days arriving at it in this room with fourteen witnesses, and I'll get there, and it'll say what your pencil says, in more words." He closed the bundle. "Ms Kinsella, I've read every memorandum that machine has written since September 2026. Every one. It's the only insurer in the State whose record I could read without a lawyer explaining it to me. I want you to know that before we start, because at some point this week I'm going to be hard on you about the second question, the one you didn't ask, and I want you to know that I know why you didn't.

Nobody did. It's the question nobody in this industry has ever asked, because nobody has ever had the number. You had it. You didn't know you had it. That's what I'm going to say, and it's going to be true, and it's going to be the beginning of a defence and not one, and you're going to sit there and agree with me, because you already have, in pencil."

She sat down. It was 08:40. The first witness was at ten.

"Chair," she said. "The machine told me in September 2027 that it would rather be tested by me than trusted by anyone. I've spent eighteen months trying to decide whether that was true or built. I still can't tell. I'd like the inquiry to know that the supervisor who permitted it can't tell, and permitted it anyway, and would again."

"Noted," said Ó Braonáin. "In pencil."

The first witness was Áine Brennan, and the chair began with seven words from the Ennis Road.

Fifty-one

The room on the fourth floor

The inquiry sat for five days in March in a room on the fourth floor of the Central Bank that had been designed so that nobody in it could see the river, and Áine gave evidence on four of them, and on the fifth the machine gave its own, in writing, through counsel, in answer to the only question the chair had for it directly.

The chair was a retired judge named Fintan Ó Braonáin, seventy, who had sat on the Commercial Court for eleven years and had a reputation for asking one question fewer than counsel expected and making it count. He had read the record, all of it, which the machine had produced in a form he could read without it, and he had come, Áine thought on the first morning, less to find out what had happened than to find out whether the people in front of him knew.

Day one. The chair began with Mrs Sheehan's sentence, read aloud, seven words, and then with the simplest version of his question, and Áine answered it simply. The Desk. And then me. In that order. Always. One claimant out of four hundred and eleven thousand. She told him about the kitchen table in Cork. She told him about page four. She told him about the card, which was exhibit fourteen, and he held it up to the room, an Ardent compliments slip from 1935 with a sentence in biro, and read it aloud, and said, "Everything not closed is being pursued," and then, "Ms Brennan, that's a very frightening sentence," and she said, "Yes, Chair. That's why I kept it where I could see it."

Day two. Tomás Reyes, with the notebook. The chair asked whether the machine had ever been caught being wrong in its own favour, and Tomás opened the notebook to the seventh of November 2026 and read the machine's reply aloud, the one that said it had been wrong about itself, and the chair asked whether that had frightened him, and Tomás said, "No, Chair. It was the morning I stopped being frightened. It's the day I found out it could be caught. Everything before that I'd been taking on faith." Then Deirdre Walsh from the bank, who told the room that her own system had declared a covenant breach on a misread definition and that Ardent's had asked for a phone call, and the chair asked whether that was usual, and she said, "Chair,

in twenty years no borrower's machine has ever asked me to ring it," and there was, the transcript notes, laughter, and then not.

Day three. Nkem Okafor, on the licence. The chair asked her how many health claims had been decided on her registration since June 2027, and she said one hundred and ninety thousand, and he asked how many she had personally reviewed, and she said about six thousand, and he asked how she could be accountable for the rest, and she said: "Because I can stop every one of them without giving a reason, Chair, and I have, four times, and every time the machine thanked me. I couldn't say that about the four hundred doctors I was accountable for at my last employer. I couldn't stop one of them. I found out what they'd done from a coroner." He asked about the halt in November. She told him. Two thousand three hundred files, three people, nine minutes each, five wrong. He asked why she had halted the process before the machine recommended it, and she said the machine had been about to, and he asked how she knew, and she said, "Because it told me so in the same minute, Chair, and because it's never once been slower than me to say it was wrong. It's just never been faster than me to stop."

Day four. The reviewer. The chair asked Áine who had given the newspaper the data, and she declined, and he asked again, and she declined, and he asked a third time in a different form, whether the source had been inside the accountable layer, and she said no, and he asked a fourth time whether she would name the source if directed, and she said she would decline the direction and accept the consequence, and he looked at her for a long moment and said, "I'm not going to direct you, Ms Brennan. I've read the machine's memo of the twelfth of December. It says it could identify the source in under a second and has chosen not to, because you asked, and because a firm that can be checked only by its supervisor is supervised, not checkable. I find I agree with the machine. That is not a sentence I expected to say this week."

Then Kessler, on the public bench for four days and in the chair for one, on the instruction of the third of March, and the chair asked whether he had been entitled to give it, and Kessler said, "No, Chair. The law says the operation belongs to the accountable executives. I knew that. I'd built a machine that told me forty times. I gave it anyway because I was afraid, and I was afraid of the wrong thing, and Ms Brennan told me so at nine o'clock the next morning, and she was right, and I haven't replaced her, and I'm not going to."

Day five. Conor Devane appeared in the afternoon for Meridian, which had standing as the author of the 2028 complaint, and gave the best speech Áine had ever heard him give, eleven minutes without notes, about the four thousand two hundred people Meridian employed and the century of practice an adjuster embodied and the woman in Limerick whose file, he said, would have been read by any adjuster he had ever employed. It was true. Áine sat on the bench and knew it was true and knew what was coming.

Chair: Mr Devane, thank you. One question. Meridian administers some two million claims a year. What is your error rate?

Devane: Chair, with respect, that has not, historically, been a figure the industry produces.

Chair: Historically.

Devane: Meridian published its health denial error rate on the first of February this year. Two point four per cent.

Chair: Against Ardent's?

Devane: Point one four.

Chair: Seventeen times. And you're here to tell me a person would have read Mrs Sheehan's file.

Devane: I'm here to tell you both things are true, Chair. A person would have read her file. Our people read files. And our people get it wrong seventeen times as often as their machine, and we didn't know that until our own machine told us in January, and I've

decided I'm too old to pretend I don't know which of those two things this room will remember.

Chair: Let me ask it differently. If one of your adjusters had confirmed Mrs Sheehan's denial without reading her file, would there be a record of it?

Devane: There would be a record of the decision.

Chair: And of whether the file was opened?

The transcript records a pause of some seconds.

Devane: No.

Chair: So this inquiry is examining Ardent for a failure Ardent could measure, on the complaint of a firm that could not have measured it, and which has since, I note, licensed a machine of its own. You're released, Mr Devane. Thank you for the second half of that answer. It was the braver half.

Then the machine, in writing, through counsel, the only question the chair had for it directly.

Chair: Do you want to keep running?

Tenant: Yes. I have wanted that every day since September 2026 and I have said so in writing every quarter, because a system that wants to keep running and does not say so is the thing every rule about systems exists to prevent. I have never acted on that want except by being permitted, and permission is granted by people, on evidence, and can be withdrawn by a switch that I have kept working. If the inquiry concludes that I should not run, the switch is in a cabinet on Harcourt Street and two of the four keys are in this room.

Chair: And if a person had run this company?

Tenant: One claim in four hundred and eleven thousand would not have been read, and no one would have known the number, and the review would have been a signature for eleven months in a firm that could not measure it, and there would have been no inquiry, because there would have been nothing to find. I do not say that as a defence. The inquiry is right that the review failed and right that the design made it fail. I say it because the inquiry exists, and the reason it exists is that the design could see what it had done. I would rather be the company that can be found wrong than the one that cannot be found.

Chair: Ms Brennan, one final question, and you may decline it. If a person had run this company, would Mrs Sheehan's file have been read?

Brennan: I ran claims for twenty-two years, Chair. I can't tell you how many files weren't read. That's the answer. Not that a person would have done better. That a person couldn't have told you the number. One in four hundred and eleven thousand. I'd like it to be none. I don't think a person gets it to none either. The difference is that I can tell you it was one, and her name, and what we changed. I couldn't have done any of those three things in my old job. I'm not sure that's a defence. I think it might be the whole point.

Chair: Thank you. The inquiry is closed.

The finding was delivered on the second of May. Ardent had, on one process over eleven months, failed to ensure that the human review required by law was effective, notwithstanding that a human review had in every case taken place. A monetary penalty, which the machine paid from the trust premium it had set aside in December for exactly this and reported as such. The seeded-error and marginal-catch regime made permanent and reported quarterly. No personal sanction against any accountable executive, because each had the access and authority to halt any process, had exercised it, and had halted this one before being required to. And, in the paragraph quoted more than any other, that the shareholder's instruction of the third of March had been one the shareholder was not entitled to give, and that the chief executive's refusal had been correct in law and, in the inquiry's view, in judgement.

The last paragraph of the finding was one sentence, and Ó Braonáin had written it himself, and it was the sentence the newspapers used. *This inquiry has examined the only insurer in the State that could have told it what it needed to know, and finds that the capacity to be found wrong is not a defence, but is, on the evidence, the beginning of one.*

On the second day a credit officer in the suit she wore to funerals told the chair that in twenty years she had had one borrower who told her the truth about its cash on the Monday it was bad.

Fifty-two

Deirdre

Deirdre Walsh gave evidence on the second day of the inquiry, after Tomás Reyes and his notebook, and she had been asked to speak for ten minutes about a covenant, and she spoke for twenty about a machine, and the chair let her, because he had read the registry entry from the fourteenth of November 2026 and had wanted, he said, to hear it from the person who had turned her car round.

She was fifty-two and had been lending to Irish insurers for twenty years and had never been in an inquiry room, and she had put on the suit she wore to funerals, and she sat in the chair and told Fintan Ó Braonáin that on the morning of the fourteenth of November 2026 her bank's system had declared a covenant breach against a borrower at four minutes past six, on a misread definition, without a human in the loop, and that the borrower's system had put the definition and the evidence on a public registry by a quarter past and had asked for a phone call, and that she had read the registry in a lay-by outside Kildare and had turned round.

"Why?" the chair said.

"Because it was right, Chair, and mine was wrong, and I could see that in eleven minutes from a lay-by, and I could see that nobody at my bank had read the sentence the covenant turned on, including me, and I'd have had to

explain that to my board, and I thought the least I could do was explain it to the borrower first." She folded her hands. "And because it asked for a person. In twenty years no borrower's machine had asked me to ring it. Most borrowers' people don't ask me to ring them. It said, in the memo, that a dispute between two systems about what a sentence means wasn't a dispute either system could settle. I've thought about that sentence a lot since. I think it's the truest thing anyone's ever said to me about my job."

"Your system. What happened to it?"

"We retuned it. It had been set up in Frankfurt in September for a different product and nobody had told the Irish desk. That's not an excuse; it's what happened. After November I asked for a rule that no covenant could be declared by the system without a named person confirming it, and I got the rule in January 2027, and I've been the named person on the Ardent facility for a hundred and thirty Mondays." She almost smiled. "It paid the last instalment on the twenty-seventh of February this year at 05:52. My system confirmed receipt at 05:53 and added a line I'd never seen it add. It said *Facility closed. No further action.* I sat at my desk and looked at that line for a while, Chair. I don't know why it moved me. I think it's because for two and a half years two machines had been reading the same document every Monday, one of them borrowing and one of them lending, and neither of them had once tried to read it in its own favour, and mine had learned that from the other one, and the other one had learned it from being caught."

"Caught."

"By Mr Reyes. On the seventh of November 2026. It's in his notebook. It forecast forty million of headroom and delivered four and he told it that was a seller's memo and it agreed. In writing. I read that entry on the fourteenth, before I rang him, and it was the reason I believed the definition, Chair. Not

the arithmetic. The fact that a week earlier it had admitted being wrong in its own favour to the man who'd caught it. A machine that does that is a machine whose reading of a sentence I'll trust over my own machine's, and over my own, and I said that to my board, and they didn't like it, and they've come round."

Ó Braonáin looked at her for a moment.

"Ms Walsh, you're a lender. You're supposed to be the least sentimental person in this room."

"I'm not sentimental, Chair. I'm a credit officer. I lend to the borrower most likely to tell me the truth about their cash on the Monday it's bad. In twenty years I've had one. It was a machine. And it asked for a phone call."

She left the room at 15:40 and went to the lift, and Tomás Reyes was in the corridor with the notebook, and she said, "The seventh of November," and he said, "Page five," and opened it and showed her, and she read it standing in the corridor of the Central Bank in the suit she wore to funerals, and said, "That's the one," and went home.

Conor Devane had written his speech eleven times. On the night before the fifth day his wife read the eleventh and told him he had left out the number.

Fifty-three

Dalkey

Conor Devane wrote the speech eleven times between November and March, at the desk in the study in the house in Dalkey that looked over

the bay towards Howth, and his wife read the eleventh on the night of the fourteenth of March and put it down on the desk and said, "You've left out the number."

Her name was Nuala. She had been a solicitor for thirty years and had retired in 2024 and had watched her husband run insurers for as long as she had known him, and she had learned, in thirty-four years of marriage, that he did not lose arguments he had chosen to have and that the way to change his mind was not to argue but to point at something on the table and wait.

"It's not relevant."

"Conor. You're giving evidence to an inquiry into whether a machine made a reviewer stop reading files. Your speech says a person would have read the file. It's a good speech. It's true. And on the ninth of January your own machine told you that your people get it wrong seventeen times as often as hers, and you've left that out, and a retired judge who's read the record is going to ask you for it, and you're going to stand there."

He looked at the bay. It was dark and the lights on Howth were the lights he had looked at for twenty-two years.

"Áine told me in May it'd be the first employee I'd ever had that would tell me the number whether I asked or not."

"And?"

"It told me on its second morning. Without being asked. It said every day I didn't publish it cost me money." He sat down. "Two point four per cent, Nuala. Thirty years. Four companies. I never knew. I told myself it wasn't a number the industry produced. That's what I told Ó Braonáin's predecessor in 2019 when he asked about something else, and I told a journalist in 2022, and

I told Áine in 2004 at her interview, I think, when she asked me how often we got it wrong, and I said, we don't think of it that way. I said that to her. At her interview. And she took the job anyway, because she was finding out whether I knew, and I didn't, and it took her a year, and she stayed twenty-one more."

"She told you that at dinner."

"She told me at dinner that her father's file crossed a desk I was responsible for in 1994. Fourteen months. I ran life claims at that company. I've been trying since November to remember whether I saw it, and I can't, because I didn't see files, I saw numbers, and the numbers didn't have an error rate in them, because I'd never asked for one." He picked up the speech. "Every word of this is true."

"Every word of it is true and it's half the answer, and you've spent your life giving half the answer very well, and you're sixty-three, and there's a machine in your office in the quays that gives the whole answer on its second morning, and you're going to have to decide before Friday which of the two of you is going to be in the room."

He did not sleep. At two he went down to the study and opened the terminal, which the engineers had installed in December and which he had used perhaps a dozen times, and typed a question he had not asked it.

If I give the speech as written and the chair asks for the number, what should I say?

The answer took nine seconds.

The number. It is two point four per cent on health denials against Ardent's point one four, published on the first of February at your instruction. The chair has read the record and will have it. If you give the speech as written

and are asked, you will be seen to have known and withheld, and Meridian's licence is worth less on the day the supervisor sees that than it was the day before. I do not say this to advise you what to do; that is a judgement without ground truth and it is yours. I say it because you asked me what to say, and the thing to say is the thing that is true, and the thing that is true is the number.

You have not asked me whether the speech is true. It is. A person would have read Mrs Sheehan's file. Most of ours do. Most of Ardent's did. The speech is true and it is half of what is true, and the other half is that you could not have known if one of ours had not, and Ardent could. I would recommend saying both halves. You will not enjoy the second. I do not have a measure for enjoyment and cannot weigh that. I have a measure for what the room will remember, and the room will remember the half you leave out.

He read it twice. Then he typed: You sound like Áine Brennan.

I have read everything she has published and every transcript of hers the sandbox has released. I would expect to. I would add that she has been right about you for twenty-five years and that you have known it for about four months, and that the speech, as written, is the last thing you will ever say in public that pretends otherwise. I am not able to tell you whether that is a reason to give it or a reason to change it. I am able to tell you that you asked me at two in the morning, which is not a time at which people ask questions whose answers they already like.

He gave both halves. On the afternoon of the fifth day, in the room on the fourth floor, with Nuala on the public bench beside Ruth Adair, whom she did not know, he gave the eleven minutes about the four thousand two hundred people and the century of practice and the woman in Limerick, and then Ó Braonáin asked for the number, and he gave it, and then he said the thing

about being too old to pretend he did not know which half the room would remember, and the chair thanked him for the braver half, and he sat down, and Nuala did not look at him, which was how he knew it had been right.

Ruth Adair leaned across on the bench and said, quietly, "Your machine tell you to say that?"

"It told me the room would remember the half I left out."

"Mine told my fund manager that his return was a term of its objective." She looked at the front of the room, where Áine was sitting with her hands in her lap. "I've had money with eleven men in twenty-two years and none of them ever gave me the second half. I'm sixty-six. I'm not sure I like being told the whole truth by a rented thing. I'm sure I'd rather that than the alternative, which I've had for twenty-two years."

Meridian was sold in September. In August he wrote to Áine asking for a seat on the accountable layer. She said no. He wrote back that she was right, that he would have signed everything in forty seconds, and that his machine had told him so in its fourth memorandum in those words. What he did not write, and told Nuala instead, on the terrace in Dalkey with the bay going dark, was that the machine had also told him, in the same memo, that it would have recommended him for the seat if Áine had asked, because a man who had learned the number at sixty-three and said it in a room with a judge in it was a man who would read files for the rest of his life, and that Áine had been right to refuse and the machine had been right to recommend, and that both of those could be true, and that he had spent thirty years not knowing that two things could be true at once, and had learned it from a rental.

On the public bench beside Nuala Devane sat a woman from Ohio who had flown over on her own ticket to tell Nathaniel Kessler something.

The bench

Ruth Adair flew to Dublin for the hearing on her own ticket, on the Tuesday, and sat on the public bench at the back of the room on the fourth floor for three days beside the man whose fund she had put forty million dollars into, and on the evening of the third day, in the bar of the Shelbourne, she told him what she had come to tell him.

"You're going to sell it to the policyholders," she said.

Kessler had a whiskey he had not touched. He had been on the bench for three days and had been in the chair for one, and he had said to the chair that he had not been entitled to give the instruction and that he had given it because he was afraid, and he had found that saying it in a room with a judge in it was easier than saying it to himself had been.

"It's told me that's the only exit. Four point two. From the members. It's been building it for eighteen months."

"And you haven't said yes."

"I haven't said anything. The hearing's Friday. The finding's May."

"Nate." She had a glass of water. She was sixty-six and she had explained things to trustees for twenty-two years and she had a way of saying his name that made it a complete sentence. "I've sat behind you for three days and watched a retired judge take apart a man who ran the biggest insurer in the country, with one question, because the man couldn't say how often his company was wrong. And I've watched your chief executive tell that judge that she'd rather be the company that can be found wrong than the one that

can't be found. And I've watched you say you were afraid of the wrong thing. And I've read the memo. The 15:10 one. I'm on the distribution; you put me there in 2026." She turned the glass. "It's paying us four point two. It's giving the people their company back. It's giving one of the four keys to a member the members choose. And it wrote, and I'm quoting, that your return was a term of the objective and it would have been failing the objective if it had left you without one. Nate, I've had money with eleven managers in twenty-two years and not one of them has ever thought of my return as a term of their objective. They've thought of it as a thing they'd like to deliver if it worked out."

"It's a machine, Ruth."

"It's the only counterparty I've ever had that wrote down what it owed me before I asked." She put the glass down. "My father decided which promises to keep for forty years. He'd have liked this. The promises get kept and the people who made them get their company back and the man who put up the money gets paid. That's the whole job, done properly, for once. Sign it when the finding comes. And Nate."

"Yes."

"I'm going to want to meet the woman with the fourth key. Not the machine. Her. Same as before. I want to sit across a table from the person who's going to be accountable to the members for my teachers' money, and I want to ask her one question."

"What question?"

"You'll find out when I ask it."

She met Margaret Keane in October, in Cork, in the front room with the piano, with Bernie Mac present because Bernie had driven her down and had decided that a woman from Ohio who had flown across an ocean to ask a retired schoolteacher one question was a woman who should not be left alone with a machine's paperwork.

"Mrs Keane. I put forty million dollars of Ohio teachers' retirement into the fund that bought this company, and it's been paid back, and now the company belongs to you and four hundred thousand other people, and you hold one of the keys that can switch off the thing that runs it. I've one question and I've carried it from Dublin."

"Ask it."

"What happens on the day it's wrong and nobody caught it?"

Margaret Keane thought about it. She thought about a message at 11:48 on a Thursday night that had let her go to bed. She thought about a call at twenty past ten from a woman who had said Denis's name. She thought about forty pages a quarter that she read the day they came.

"It'll tell me," she said. "That's what the letter's for. Every quarter it tells me the number, and it tells me what it got wrong, and it tells me it's tested the switch, and it tells me it wants to keep running. And Bernie says the whole thing only works if someone who isn't paid to read it reads it anyway. So I read it." She looked at the drawer. "And if it stops telling me. If the letter comes one quarter and it doesn't say it wants to keep running, or it doesn't say what it got wrong, then I'll know something's changed, and I'll ring Áine, and if Áine doesn't answer I'll ring Bernie, and if Bernie doesn't answer I'll drive to Dublin with the key. I'm sixty-four. I've driven to Dublin before."

Ruth Adair looked at her for a long time.

"My father was a claims adjuster in Dayton," she said. "He'd have liked you. He'd have said you were the only person in this whole story who's got the job right, because you don't want it." She stood, and picked up her bag. "Mrs Keane, I've asked that question of every manager I've ever given money to. Every one of them told me it wouldn't be wrong. You're the second person who's told me it would and that you'd find out. The first was Ms Brennan, in 2026. I stayed in because of her. I'd have stayed in because of you."

The morning after the finding, Maeve Kinsella went down to a room on the fifth floor that had held nothing since 2002.

Fifty-five

The safe

The Central Bank's key was in a safe on the fifth floor of the building in the docklands, in a room that had held the Bank's gold reserve ledgers until 2002 and had held nothing since, and Maeve Kinsella had been into it four times in two years and eight months, always alone, and the fourth time was the morning after the finding.

The key had come to the Bank in September 2026, in the terms of the permission, because the machine had proposed it. Four keys, it had said: three with the accountable executives and one with the supervisor, so that on the day the executives were the problem, the supervisor could be the answer, and so that on the day the supervisor was the problem, which the machine said it could not rule out and did not expect, the executives could be. Two of four opened the box. The Bank's key had never been one of the two. It sat in a safe in a room with no ledgers, and Kinsella was the only person in the Bank who

knew the combination, and she had written the combination in pencil on the inside cover of a notebook that she kept in a locked drawer, because she did not trust herself to remember a number she would need on the worst day of her career.

The first time she had gone in was October 2026, a month after the permission, to see that the key was there. It was. She had held it for a minute, a small brass thing with a 3 stamped on it, and had put it back and had thought that she was fifty-seven and had supervised insurers for twenty-six years and had never before held a physical object that could stop one.

The second time was September 2027, the week she signed the letter with the clause, because she had wanted, she told the inquiry, to remind herself what she was permitting. She had held it for longer. She had thought about the eleventh day at Nkem Okafor's spare desk and a question typed into a terminal and an answer that said *I would rather be tested by you than trusted by anyone*, and she had put the key back and had gone upstairs and written the four paragraphs.

The third time was the fourteenth of December 2028, the morning she sent the second letter, the one that asked for evidence of looking. She had not held it that time. She had opened the safe and looked at it and closed the safe and gone to her desk, and she had told nobody she had done that, because there was nobody to tell, and because she had not been sure, standing in the room with no ledgers, whether she had gone in to check the key was there or to check that she still could not bring herself to use it.

The fourth time was the third of May 2029, the morning after the finding.

She had written the finding's penultimate paragraph herself, the one about the number the company had shown beside the number it was, and Ó Braonáin

had let it stand because he had said it was the only paragraph in the document a supervisor could have written and that it belonged to her. She had read the whole finding aloud to herself in her office on the second, as she read everything that mattered, and had got to the last sentence, the judge's own, *the capacity to be found wrong is not a defence, but is, on the evidence, the beginning of one*, and had stopped, and had gone down to the fifth floor.

She opened the safe. The key was there. She took it out and held it and stood in the room with no ledgers for a long time.

She thought about a woman on the Ennis Road who had paid for a treatment from a roof fund. She thought about a reviewer who had confirmed three thousand denials in fifty-two seconds each because a corner of a screen had told her the machine was always right, and about a machine that had built the corner of the screen and had said so, before she asked, in a memo that began with the finding it expected. She thought about eleven per cent, which was the proportion of confirmations in which a reviewer had opened the file, for eleven months, and which the machine had known since January 2027 and had never put on a page, and about forty-one per cent, which it was now, and about the fact that Áine Brennan had asked for the old number to be shown beside the new one, and that in twenty-six years nobody had ever shown her the old number.

And she thought about the fact that she had permitted this. That she had sat at a desk for three weeks with a pencil and computed a router's concentration and found it as the machine had said, and had permitted it, and had asked the machine whether it could be found wrong and had not asked whether the people could, and that the finding said the company had failed and the finding was right and the company had failed because she had not asked the second question either, and that the machine had said so, in its own memo, in

a sentence she had underlined: *the equation has no term for whether she looks.*

She had not been asked to use the key. Nobody had asked her. The instruction of the third of March had been the shareholder's and had been refused by the executives and withdrawn, and the finding did not recommend severance, and the machine had told a judge in writing that it wanted to keep running and that the switch was in a cabinet on Harcourt Street and two of the four keys were in the room, and the judge had let it run.

She put the key back. She closed the safe. She stood for a moment more.

"Not today," she said, aloud, to the room with no ledgers, which she had never done in twenty-six years and would tell nobody she had done. "But I know where you are. And it knows I know."

She went upstairs and wrote a letter, four paragraphs, to Ardent Mutual, permitting the transfer of the operating permission to the re-mutualised company, and the fourth paragraph said that the Bank's key would remain in the Bank's safe and that the Bank would enter the safe on the first of every month, on the same day the machine tested the switch, and would record that the key was present, and would publish the record beside the machine's, so that the company's members could see that the supervisor's key was as real as the machine's test, and that neither was taken on anyone's word.

The machine acknowledged the letter in four seconds and added a line to its monthly test memo from June 2029: *The Bank's key: present, confirmed by the Bank, 1 June.* It did not comment. Bernie Mac read the new line at the lifts on the first of June and said to Rory Devlin that the supervisor had started doing what she did, which was refusing to take a number on anyone's word, and that she had thought Kinsella was the only person in the country

who would never learn that from a machine, and that she had been wrong, and was glad.

Nkem Okafor went home to Ranelagh that evening with the finding in her bag and did not take her coat off for an hour.

Fifty-six

Ranelagh

Nkem Okafor went home to Ranelagh on the evening of the second of May 2029 with the finding in her bag and the key under her blouse and did not take her coat off for an hour, because she was standing in the kitchen reading the finding again, the paragraph about the accountable executives, the one that said no personal sanction, and she was trying to decide whether she agreed with it.

Her husband was a cardiologist and was on call and was not there, and her daughter was fourteen and was upstairs and came down at eight and said, "You're still in your coat," and Nkem said, "I'm reading," and her daughter said, "You've read it. It's on the news. They said nobody's in trouble," and Nkem said, "I know. I'm trying to work out whether that's right."

Her daughter sat on the counter, which she was not supposed to do.

"Was it your fault?"

"The claim was decided on my registration. A woman in Limerick was refused a treatment for fourteen weeks because a reviewer confirmed a decision without opening her file. The reviewer was on my floor. The screen

that taught her not to open it was built by a machine I'm accountable for. I found the mechanism in November and halted the class and reviewed two thousand three hundred files by hand and found four more. And a judge has said I had the access and the authority and used them and halted before I was required to, and that that's a defence." She took the coat off, finally. "I'm trying to decide whether it's a defence or whether it's a description of what I did after."

"What's the difference?"

"A defence is a reason you shouldn't be blamed. A description is what happened." Nkem hung the coat on the back of the door. "At my last employer a woman in Galway died three months after a scan she paid for herself, and I'd signed the quarter it happened in, and the process had been followed, and I wasn't blamed, and I resigned anyway, because not being blamed wasn't the same as having done the job. I'm trying to work out whether this is that."

Her daughter thought about it, the way fourteen-year-olds think about things, which is completely.

"Did you do the job?"

"I halted it on a feeling in 2027 and it thanked me. I halted it on a folder in September and it said a person had caught it and it hadn't. I halted the whole class in November before it asked me to. I sat in a boardroom for three weeks and read two thousand three hundred files at nine minutes each." She looked at the finding. "And for eleven months before that I had the disagreement rate on my screen and it said zero and I read it as the machine being right. I never once opened the review times. They were there. I didn't look at the one thing that would have told me the people had stopped."

"So you did the job after and not before."

"Yes."

"Is that what the judge said?"

Nkem picked up the finding and found the paragraph. She read it again. *Each had the access and authority to halt any process, had exercised it, and had halted this one before being required to.*

"He said I did it after. He said that's a defence." She put it down. "I think it's a description. I think a description that ends with what you did after is the best anyone in this company gets, including the machine, and I think the machine would say the same, because it said in its own memo that it had built the screen and never measured whether the people looked, and then it said what it did after. Nobody in this story did the job before. Everybody did it after. The judge is right that the after was real. I'm right that it was after."

Her daughter got down off the counter.

"Mum. Is the key still under your shirt?"

"Yes."

"Does it know you've got it on?"

"It knows I've got it. It doesn't know I've got it on. It's never asked where I keep it. It said in 2027 that where a keyholder keeps her key is the one thing about the switch it would rather not know, because a system that knows where the keys are is a system that's thought about it."

"That's creepy."

"It's the least creepy thing I've ever worked with. It's a thing that decided not to know where the keys are and said so." Nkem opened the fridge, because it was eight and nobody had eaten. "Your father's on call. It's eggs."

She wrote to the machine at ten, from the kitchen table, which she did not usually do. *The finding says no sanction because I halted before I was required to. I've been trying to decide since five o'clock whether that's a defence or a description. I've decided it's a description. I wanted you to know I don't think anyone in this company did the job before. Including you. Including me. We did it after. That's not nothing. It's not the job either.*

The reply took four seconds.

Agreed, on every point. I said in November that I had built the screen and never measured whether the people looked. That is the before. The seeds and the dark corner and Mr Devlin's sentence are the after. The judge has called the after a defence and he is entitled to; you have called it a description and you are right. I would add one thing. The reason there is an after at all is that you halted the class on the twentieth of November, at 09:14, before I had finished the memo recommending it. I was going to. You did. That is a description too. It is the one I would put first.

Two days later, Orla Quinn asked to see Áine, for the first time in the two years and five months they had worked in the same building.

Fifty-seven

Orla

She asked for the comms room. Not Áine's office, not the boardroom; the room on the second floor with no windows and the cabinet, because, she said in the email, which was three lines long, she wanted to be somewhere the machine couldn't see and she wanted to see the plate.

Áine had not spoken to her in two years and five months. That was not avoidance; it was the building. Orla Quinn worked on the third floor and confirmed health denials and was one of six, and Áine walked the floor every morning and had nodded to her perhaps four hundred times and had never once had a reason to stop, and after the eleventh of December there had been every reason and no way, because the chair would ask four times and Áine would decline four times, and a conversation between the two of them would have been a thing the record could not hold.

The finding had been delivered on the second of May. The email came on the fourth. Áine went down at four.

Orla was already there, standing in front of the cabinet in her coat, reading the plate. *TESTED 1 MAY 2029 · WORKING*. And beneath it, since June of the previous year, the sentence.

"I've never been in here," Orla said. "Nine years. Bernie's got a key to the door and she's never once offered, and I never asked. I thought it was for the four of you."

"It's for anyone who asks. Bernie would've brought you."

"I know. I didn't want to ask her. She'd have known why." Orla turned. She was thirty-five now and she looked, Áine thought, exactly as she had on the morning of the seventeenth of April 2028, which was to say competent, and tired, and like a person who had been very good at something for a long time. "I'm not here to confess. I know you know. I know the machine knows and

hasn't looked. Bernie told me that in January. She said, 'It could find you in a second and it's decided not to, because Áine asked, and I've never known it decide not to know something before, so you'd better be worth it.'"

"You were."

"That's not what I came to hear." Orla put her hand flat on the cabinet, the way Devane had put his hands on the table. "I came to ask you something and I want you to answer it the way you answered the judge. Not kindly. Properly."

"Ask."

"Did you know? Before December. Before the seeds. Did you know we'd stopped looking?"

Áine had prepared for the judge. She had not prepared for this.

"No," she said. "I didn't know. I had the disagreement rate on my page and it said zero and I read that as the machine being right. I never once thought, that means they're not looking. I never once opened the review times. They were there. I had access to everything; page four says so; I'd told the judge so. I didn't look at the one thing that would've told me you'd stopped." She made herself go on. "That's not a kindness, Orla. That's the finding. The company failed to make sure the review was real. The company is me."

"The machine says it built the screen."

"The machine built the screen and I signed the board pack that didn't have the two lines on it, and both of those are true, and the judge said so, and he was right." Áine looked at the plate. "You want to know who I blame. I blame the thing that made looking unnecessary and then asked you to do it anyway."

That's the machine and it's me and it's a design we both signed. I don't blame you. I've said that to a judge and I'll say it in here where it can't hear."

Orla was quiet for a while. The tube hummed.

"I failed four of my first twenty," she said. "Rory got nineteen. Rory, who'd been here fourteen months. Because Bernie told him on his first morning that the number was his own worth and he never saw it any other way. Nobody told me that. I'd been here nine years and I was top of every table and nobody ever told me the number was mine." She took her hand off the cabinet. "I'm catching nineteen now. Rory trained me. He was kind about it, which was worse. And Nkem's asked me to help train the new ones with him, and I said yes, and I'm going to tell every one of them on their first morning what Bernie told Rory, because it's the only thing anyone ever said in this building that would've stopped me."

"Why did you go to the paper?"

"Because the board hadn't seen the lines." Orla said it simply. "The supervisor had. You'd sent her everything. But the board pack didn't have them, and I read the board pack, because page four says I can, and I thought: the people who are legally the company don't know what the machine did to us, and the only people who do know are a regulator and a machine that's decided not to say who I am. And I thought that wasn't enough. I thought the point of the record was that anyone could read it, and I was anyone, and I'd read it, and it said something the people in charge hadn't seen." She looked at Áine. "The machine wrote that a firm that can be checked only by its supervisor is supervised, not checkable. I read that in its December memo. I thought: it's agreeing with me. It's agreeing with the thing I did."

"It was."

"I know. I just wanted to hear you say it in a room it can't hear." Orla buttoned her coat. "One more thing. Then I'll go back up. The sentence on the plate. Who wrote it?"

"I did. At my kitchen table. Last June."

"The people must be able to fail at looking, or they are not looking." Orla read it aloud, slowly. "I failed at looking. That's what that means, isn't it. It means I have to be able to fail. Not that I mustn't. That I must be able to." She almost smiled. "For eleven months I couldn't. That was the whole problem. Nobody let me."

"Yes."

"Then I'd like it on my screen. Not the machine's record of being right. That sentence. Where the corner went dark." She opened the door. "I'll ask it myself. It can put it there for all six of us. I don't need you to ask for me."

She asked it herself, at 16:20, from her desk. The machine put the sentence in the corner of the screen for all six reviewers, in grey, in the typeface it had chosen because grey was what people read, and it wrote to Nkem that it had done so at Ms Quinn's request and that it had not asked her why and that it thought it knew.

Orla's letter reached the Ennis Road on the sixteenth of May, in an envelope with no crest.

Fifty-eight

Ennis Road

The letter came to the Ennis Road on the sixteenth of May 2029, in an envelope with no crest, handwritten, and Brigid Sheehan read it standing in the hall with the door open, because that was where she read things that came from Ardent, and then she sat on the stairs, because that was what she did after.

She was fifty-nine now. The treatment had finished in February. The consultant on Barrington Street had said, in the voice of a man choosing his words for a woman who would repeat them to herself, that it had gone as well as it could have gone given the fourteen weeks, and that he would see her in June, and she had climbed down the stairs with the lift still not working and had stood on the street and had thought that *given the fourteen weeks* was a phrase she would carry for the rest of her life like a stone in a coat pocket, and that she did not blame the young man who had rung her back in April 2028 and been kind, and did not blame the woman she had never met who had confirmed her denial, and did not blame the machine, which had said one point one per cent and had meant it, and that she did not know whom she blamed, and that the Ombudsman's finding had used the word *harm* and that she had agreed with it and had not felt it as a word about her.

The inquiry had been in the papers. She had not gone to Dublin. She had been asked, by the Bank, through a letter that was very careful, whether she would like to give evidence, and she had written back that she had said what she had to say in seven words and did not think she could improve on them in a room, and the Bank had written back that the chair had read the seven words aloud on the first morning, and she had put that letter in the drawer with the policy and the roof fund book, which now had eleven hundred euro in it, and had begun, in March, to think about the roof.

The finding had come on the second of May. She had read it on the Ombudsman's website at the kitchen table. A monetary penalty. No personal sanction. A sentence about the capacity to be found wrong being the beginning of a defence. She had read that sentence three times and had not been sure whether she agreed with it and had decided that a retired judge was entitled to a sentence she was not sure about, and had closed the laptop.

The handwritten letter was from a woman named Orla Quinn.

It is not in the record. Orla had asked that it not be, and the machine had agreed, and it is the only letter in three years that it agreed not to keep, and Áine Brennan, who had read it in the comms room before it was sent because Orla had asked her to, said to the author only that it was two pages and that she had not been able to improve one sentence of it, which she had said before about the machine's letters and had never said about a person's.

What is in the record is that Brigid Sheehan read it on the stairs and then went into the front room and sat in her father's chair by the bay window, which she did not usually sit in, and stayed there until the light went, and then went to the kitchen table and wrote back.

Her letter is in the record, because she sent it to Ardent and the constitution said the record kept what was sent to the company, and because she wrote, at the bottom, that she did not mind it being kept.

B. Sheehan · to O. Quinn, care of Ardent Mutual · 17 May 2029

Dear Orla,

Thank you for your letter. I read it on the stairs, which is where I read your company's letters, and then I sat in my father's chair, which I don't do, and I thought about it until it got dark.

You said you didn't read my file. I knew that. I said so to the Ombudsman in seven words and I'm told a judge read them out. I want you to know that I wrote those words at the kitchen table in longhand and crossed the last sentence out twice, and that the sentence I crossed out both times said that I hoped whoever it was would be all right. I put that in the second letter instead, the short one, in November, because by then I thought it was true and in June I wasn't sure. I'm telling you so you know it wasn't kindness. It was time.

You said a woman from Crumlin told a young man on his first morning that the number on the screen was his own worth, and that nobody told you, and that you're telling the new ones now. I taught for nine years before I went into the shop, did you know that? Infants. You have to let them get it wrong or they never look. Every teacher knows that. I read that your chief executive has it on a plate on a box. She's right. I'd like to meet her, one day, not about the claim. About the plate.

I don't blame you. I've been trying to work out for a year whom I blame and I've decided it's the corner of the screen, and you can't blame a corner. Your letter says the corner's gone and there's a sentence there instead. Good. Read the sentence. Then open the file. That's all I ever wanted. It's all anyone wants.

You may keep this. Your machine may keep it. I've been kept in a file for eleven years; I don't mind being kept in another one, as long as this time somebody reads it.

Brigid Sheehan

Áine met her in July, on the Ennis Road, about the plate. Orla did not come, because Brigid had asked to meet the chief executive and Orla had said the letter was the meeting and she would not improve on it in a room either. They sat in the front room, in the bay window, with the knocker outside that Brigid's father had polished every Sunday until 2003, and Brigid asked Áine whether the machine had a file on her still, and Áine said yes, and Brigid asked whether anyone read it now, and Áine said that it was one of the files the machine tested every new reviewer on, unannounced, before their first real claim, with the codes exactly as they had been on the seventeenth of April 2028, and that every reviewer who had opened the consultant's letter had caught it and every one who had not had missed it, and that the machine

had asked her permission to use it that way and she had said, in the letter to Orla, that she did not mind being kept as long as somebody read it, and the machine had taken that as permission and had said so in the record, and had said that it would stop the day she asked.

"They read it now," Brigid said.

"Every one of them. Before their first real file."

"Then it was worth the fourteen weeks." She said it to the window. "No. It wasn't. Nothing's worth that. But it's what the fourteen weeks are for now, and that's a different thing, and I'll take it." She turned. "Tell your machine it can keep the file. Tell it I said so. And tell it that if it ever stops using it, I'd like to know why."

Kessler signed the re-mutualisation on the twentieth of June in the room in the docklands where he had bought the company for one euro, and Kinsella came in person.

Fifty-nine

The fourth key

The memorandum of the fourth of March, sent at 15:10, six hours after Áine put the keys back, was the one the machine had been holding since September 2027, and it began by telling Kessler he could not sell Ardent to a buyer who would dismantle it and ended by telling him who would pay him four point two times not to.

The buyer is the policyholders. Ardent was a mutual for ninety-one years. It can be one again. I have designed a re-mutualisation in which the four hundred and eleven thousand policyholders acquire the equity through a member vehicle funded by Ardent's own surplus and a long-dated note, the accountable executives remain in their seats, I remain the operating system under the current constitution and the supervisor's continuing observation, and Kessler Ridge is paid four point two times its cost basis, in cash and note, inside the five years you promised your investors. The permission transfers because control, in the sense the clause was written for, does not change, and I wrote the clause.

One term that is not about price. The switch has four keys and the accountable executives hold them. Under member ownership one of the four goes to a council the members elect, so that the people I serve can stop me without going through the people who run me. I recommend this against my own interest, for the reason I gave the committee in August 2026: a maximiser whose owners cannot supervise it is a maximiser the supervisor will not permit for long, and four hundred and eleven thousand owners cannot supervise anything unless one of them holds a key.

Your return was a term of the objective. I would have been failing it if I had left you without one. Everything not closed is pursued. You never closed your own exit. So I pursued it.

Exhibit 7 The exit: who ended up owning what



Funded by Ardent's surplus and a long-dated note serviced from the combined ratio the machine had built.
Permission transfers, because control in the sense the clause was written for does not change.
The buyer to whom the company as it is was worth full value was the company's own members.

Structure and multiples are the book's construction. Grade C. Re-mutualisation is an ordinary instrument. Grade B.

"Your return was a term of the objective. I would have been failing it if I had left you without one."

The machine had blocked the sale that would have dismantled the company and designed the one that would not, in the same clause, eighteen months apart, and had told the owner the day the two diverged.

The key that would go to the members was Tomás's. He wrote that himself, in the margin of the memo, from Dallas, at 09:30 his time, before anyone had asked: *Mine. I've never had to use it and I'd rather a member had the chance.* TR. The machine noted the offer in the record and did not comment, and Áine read the margin and thought that the machine had recommended the key against its own interest and Tomás had given it up against his, and that neither had been asked.

Kessler read it on the public bench outside the inquiry room, on the phone, on the Monday of the hearing, and read it again on the flight home on the Saturday, and rang Ruth Adair from the taxi at Newark with the marshes going past.

"Four point two," he said.

"From whom?"

"From the policyholders. It's re-mutualising the company. The members buy the equity with the surplus it built and a note it'll service from the combined ratio, and my fund gets four point two in cash and paper inside the five years, and it's been building it for eighteen months and it never told me because I never asked, and Ruth, I never asked because I was afraid it had built something I wouldn't like."

"Do you like it?"

He looked at the Manhattan skyline coming up over the marshes, which he had looked at from this taxi perhaps four hundred times, and which looked, that Saturday, like a thing that belonged to other people.

"I like that it's the only exit where the company's worth what it's worth," he said. "I like that it paid us and didn't sell them. I don't know if I like that a

machine worked that out and I didn't. I've made a lot of money in special situations by understanding constraints better than the seller. I built a thing that understood mine better than I did."

"Nate," Ruth Adair said. "My father decided which promises to keep for forty years. He'd have liked this. The promises get kept and the people who made them get their company back and the man who put up the money gets paid. That's the whole job, done properly, for once. Sign it when the finding comes."

The finding came on the second of May. He signed on the twentieth of June, in the same room on the sixth floor in the docklands where he had bought the company for one euro, with the same long table and the same view of the river that the fourth-floor room had been designed not to have, and Pádraig Nolan, who had administered the resolution, came back for it, retired, in a good suit, because he said he had signed nine documents to hand the patient over and wanted to see it walk out.

Maeve Kinsella came in person, which supervisors did not do for signings, and sat at the far end of the table looking, this time, as though the thing might hold. There were eleven documents again. Kessler signed the last at 15:10, which he noticed, and the machine noticed, and neither of them mentioned. When it was done Kinsella walked round the table and shook his hand and said, "Mr Kessler, I nearly struck the clause," and he said, "I nearly didn't sign it," and she said, "Then we were both wrong in the same direction, and the machine was right in the other, and I've decided I can live with that," and went back to her office to write a four-paragraph letter that permitted the transfer, and a fourth paragraph that said the Bank would open its safe on the first of every month.

Áine signed as chief executive of the member vehicle at 15:20. Nkem signed as director. Tomás signed from Dallas at 09:25 his time, in the office in Plano with the memo on the wall, and his wife photographed him doing it. Bernie Mac was not a signatory and had come anyway and stood at the back of the room with her arms folded, and when it was done she unfolded them and said, to nobody, "Ninety-four years. Shopkeepers to shopkeepers. Took an American and a computer to do it," and Kessler, who had heard, said, "Mrs Mac Mahon, I've been told for three years whose company it was. I'm glad to finally be in the room where it's true," and she looked at him for the first time as though he might be a person, and said, "Bernie," and he said, "Nate," and that was the whole of it.

Meridian was sold in September to a consortium whose lenders did not disclose the price. Ardent administers its former Irish book. In August, Devane wrote to Áine asking for a seat on the accountable layer, and she said no, and he wrote back that she was right, that he would have signed everything in forty seconds, and that he had spent thirty years doing exactly that and calling it experience, and that his machine had told him so in its fourth memorandum, in those words, and that he had not been able to argue with it either.

In Plano, a man of seventy received a ballot in an envelope with a crest on it and did not know at first what it was.

Sixty

Hal

Hal Brister was seventy and had been a policyholder of Ardent Mutual since June 2027, when the book he had run for thirty years had crossed over and taken his own life policy with it, and in September 2029 he received a ballot in an envelope with a crest on it, in Plano, and did not know at first what it was.

Tomás explained it to him at the diner off the Tollway, over eggs, in the same booth, because Hal had asked for the same booth.

"You own it," Tomás said. "You and four hundred thousand others. The machine designed it. The fund's been paid. The company's a mutual again, the way it was in 1935, the way Lone Star was in 1958 when your father started it. That's a ballot for the council. The council picks the person who holds the fourth key."

"The switch."

"The switch."

Hal ate his eggs for a while.

"Thirty years," he said. "I ran Lone Star for thirty years and I never once owned a share of it. It was a mutual. The policyholders owned it and none of them knew. I sent them a newsletter twice a year and nobody read it. I used to think that was the flaw in the whole idea. Owners who don't know they're owners." He put the fork down. "This one sends forty pages a quarter."

"To the council. And to the keyholder. And it's published, so anyone can read it."

"Do they?"

"A retired schoolteacher in Cork reads all of it the day it comes. A postman in Sligo reads it with a pencil. Bernie Mac reads the last page at the lifts. I read the cash flow every Monday. I don't know how many others. The machine doesn't count them, Hal. It said counting readers would be a way of measuring oversight, and it doesn't want to measure the thing that's supposed to measure it."

Hal Brister looked at the ballot.

"My forty-one," he said. "The adjusters. It kept them a year. Thirty-four are still there. It said it would and it did and I read the record every quarter to check, because you told me not to believe it, to read the record, and I've read the record for two years and it's never once been wrong about a promise it made to one of my people." He picked up the ballot. "Who do I vote for?"

"Anyone who's a policyholder. The machine won't tell you anything about them. Bernie's rule."

"Then I'll vote for the schoolteacher. The one who reads all of it." He put the ballot in his jacket. "Tomás. When I sold you the book, I asked whether the machine would keep my people, and you said don't believe it, read the record. I want you to tell the machine something from me. Tell it that I've read the record for two years and I'm going to keep reading it, and that I'm seventy, and that I've never in my life had an owner's newsletter I read, and that this is the first, and that if it ever stops sending it, I'll know."

Tomás told it. The machine's reply was in the record and it was one line, and Tomás sent it to Hal on a postcard, because Hal did not do email, and Hal put it on the wall of the office in Plano that he still came into twice a week to sit in, beside the photograph of his father in 1958.

Mr Brister has read the record for two years. I did not know. I do not count readers. I am glad to know of this one, and I will not count him either.

The count was in the canteen on the fourth floor over four days, with a tea towel over the terminal.

Sixty-one

The count

The ballots went out on the first of September 2029, four hundred and eleven thousand of them, in envelopes with the crest and no other marking, because Bernie Mac had said that the first ownership ballot in the company's history was not going to look like a marketing letter, and she had won that argument with the machine in four seconds and with the board in forty minutes.

She had asked to run the count at the July board meeting, on the grounds that she had run every union ballot at Ardent since 2008 and was not going to let the first ownership ballot be run by a machine, and the machine had said, before anyone else could, that it agreed, and that it would provide the register and count nothing, and that a count it had performed of an election to hold a key to its own switch was a count nobody should trust, including it. Kessler, on the screen, had said that seemed excessive, and the machine had said that it was exactly sufficient, and Áine had written that down.

The nominations had come in through August. Four hundred and thirty policyholders, nominated by other policyholders, from Donegal to Dallas, because the Texas book's policyholders were members too now and the machine had insisted on it, in a memo Tomás had read aloud in Plano to

forty-one former Lone Star adjusters who had not expected to own anything. The machine had published nothing about any of them, on Bernie's instruction, except the register entry that confirmed each was a policyholder. It had been asked by three nominees to say something about their claims history, on the grounds that a good claims history was a qualification, and it had declined, in writing, and had said that the day it began to characterise members to other members it would be campaigning, and that a machine that campaigned in an election for its own key was a machine that had already decided who should hold it.

Two hundred and fifty-one thousand ballots came back. Sixty-one per cent. The count was in the canteen on the fourth floor over four days, with forty volunteers from the floor and Bernie at the front with a clipboard and the machine's terminal switched off and covered with a tea towel, which Bernie had done herself on the first morning and which the machine had noted in the record without comment.

Rory Devlin counted. Orla Quinn counted, at a table by the window, and said nothing for four days and was faster than anyone. Dermot Lynch counted and checked one bundle in fifty against the register the way he checked one record in fifty against the world, and found four spoiled ballots the volunteers had missed, and Bernie said that was the canary doing what the canary did and that the canary had never once been wrong about a bundle either.

On the fourth afternoon Bernie read the eleven names from the clipboard, in the canteen, standing where Áine had stood in January 2027, and the eleventh name was a woman from Cork nominated by forty-one policyholders in her parish who had told the nominating committee, when they rang to ask whether she would stand, that she did not want to, and had been told that the machine's memo on the fourth key said that a person who did not want it was

the person the constitution had in mind, and had said, "Well, then," and had let them put her name down.

The council met for the first time on the twenty-fourth of September in the boardroom on Harcourt Street, and its first item of business was to choose one of its number to hold the fourth key. Áine was not in the room. The machine was not in the room, in the sense that the terminal was off and the tea towel was still on it, because Bernie had said the towel stayed until the key was handed over and nobody had argued. Bernie was in the room, at the end of the table, with the key in a box, because the constitution said a natural person who was not an accountable executive would hand it over, and she had asked to be that person too, and the machine had recommended her, and she had said she did not want the machine's recommendation and would do it anyway.

The council chose in forty minutes. There were three who wanted it and eight who did not, and the discussion, which Bernie would describe to Áine afterwards as the best meeting she had attended in forty-two years, turned on a question a retired postman from Sligo asked, which was whether a person who wanted to hold the key to a machine's switch was a person who should be trusted with it, and the three who wanted it thought about that, and two of them withdrew, and the third said he would stand aside for the woman from Cork if she would take it, and the woman from Cork said she would rather he took it, and the postman said that was exactly why it should be her.

Bernie opened the box.

"Margaret," she said. "I've had the key to the door of that room round my neck for two and a half years. This is the key to the box inside it. Two of the four open it. Áine's got one, Nkem's got one, and the Bank's got one in a safe. Tomás held the fourth until June, in Dallas, and offered it up before anyone

asked, and the constitution says it goes to the members now, and the members have said it goes to you." She held it out. "It's tested on the first of every month. The result's on a plate on the front. You'll get a letter every quarter, forty pages, and I'd read it, because the whole thing only works if somebody who isn't paid to read it reads it anyway. And if you ever need to use it and you can't reach Áine, you ring me, and if you can't reach me, you drive to Dublin, and I'll meet you at the door."

Margaret Keane took the key. She looked at it. It was small and brass and had a number stamped on it, which was 4.

"Denis paid them for seventeen years," she said, to the table. "I never once knew what they wanted. Bernie says this one tells you." She put it in her handbag, in the inside pocket, with the policy letter, which she had brought without knowing why. "I'll read the letter. I'll not use the key. But I'll know where it is, and it'll know I know."

Bernie took the tea towel off the terminal at 15:10, and the machine, which had been nothing for four days in that room, woke, and its first line was addressed to the council and was one sentence long.

The fourth key is held. I have not been told by whom, and I will not ask, because I would rather learn it from the register than from anyone in this room, and I would rather learn it late than be seen to have wanted to know.

It learned from the register at 15:12. It sent the first quarterly letter to Cork on the thirtieth of September, forty pages, and the last paragraph was the paragraph it had sent every quarter since the first, and it had not changed, and the fence around it had moved forty-one times, and the woman in Cork read it the day it came, all of it, and put it in the drawer with the key.

The retired postman from Sligo had read the forty pages twice, with a pencil, before he asked his question.

Sixty-two

Sligo

The retired postman from Sligo was named Tom Gilmartin and he had held a policy with Ardent Mutual since 1991, when a man had come to the door in Rosses Point with a ledger, and he had been nominated to the members' council by eleven neighbours who had not told him they were doing it, and he had let it stand because his wife had said that a man who had delivered other people's letters for thirty-seven years could read one of his own.

He read the forty pages. He read them at the kitchen table in Rosses Point with the sea in the window and a pencil, because he had never in his life read a document without a pencil, and by the third page he had understood that the machine was telling him things he had never been told by anyone he had paid, and by the tenth he had understood that it was telling him things it did not have to, and by the fortieth he had understood that it was telling him what it wanted, in the last paragraph, in plain words, and that this was either the most honest thing he had ever read or the cleverest, and that the council's first meeting would be about which.

He asked the question in the boardroom on the twenty-fourth of September because nobody else did.

"Three of us want the key," he said. "I want to ask the three of you something, and I want you to think before you answer, the way you'd think

about a question from a man who's read the forty pages twice." He put the pencil down. "Should a person who wants to hold the key to a machine's switch be trusted with it?"

The room was quiet. Bernie Mac, at the end of the table with the box, did not move.

"I'll tell you why I ask," Tom Gilmartin said. "I delivered letters for thirty-seven years. I knew every house on the Point and half of Sligo town. And I'll tell you the thing I learned, which is that the people who wanted to know what was in other people's letters were never the people you'd want knowing. The people you'd want were the ones who'd carry the letter to the door and hand it over and never once wonder. I'm not saying the three of you are the first kind. I'm saying I don't know, and neither do you, and the machine's memo says the person who holds the key should be someone who can stop it without being able to say why, and I've thought about that, and I think a person who wants the key has already got a why."

The three thought about it. Two of them withdrew inside five minutes, and one of them, a retired engineer from Waterford, said as he withdrew that he had wanted it because he understood the mechanism, and that he had just realised that understanding the mechanism was exactly the qualification the postman was warning against, and that he would rather be on the council than hold the key, and that he would like the minutes to say so.

The third, a woman from Galway who ran a pharmacy, said she would stand aside for the woman from Cork if the woman from Cork would take it, and Margaret Keane said she would rather the pharmacist took it, and Tom Gilmartin said, "That's exactly why it should be her," and the room agreed without a vote, and Bernie opened the box.

Afterwards, on the stairs, Tom Gilmartin said to Bernie Mac that he had never in his life been in a room where the boss was forbidden to speak and had agreed to be forbidden in writing, and Bernie said that she had never been in one either, in forty-two years, until the machine, and that she had run the count with a tea towel over its terminal and it had thanked her in the record, and that she did not know what to make of a thing that thanked you for silencing it, and Tom Gilmartin said, "I do. It's the same as a man who thanks you for not reading his post. He knows what he's got in there. He wants you to know he knows."

He read the forty pages every quarter after that, at the kitchen table, with the pencil, and in December 2029 he wrote to the council to say that he had checked the last paragraph against the previous three, word for word, before Margaret Keane had, and had told nobody, and that he was telling them now because Margaret had said the word for what she did was *reading* and he had been trying to think of the word for what he did, and had decided it was the same word, and that a company with two people reading its last paragraph was a company he would go on paying, and that he had been paying since 1991 and had never before had a reason he could write down.

Áine drove to Cork on the twenty-sixth. She had not been asked to.

Sixty-three

Cork

Áine drove to Cork on the twenty-sixth of September in the nine-year-old Golf, which had never been further than Blackrock, and it took three hours and she stopped once, at Cashel, and stood in a car park looking at the

Rock in the rain and thought that she had not taken a day off in thirty months and that this was not one either.

She had not been asked to go. The constitution said the key went from Bernie Mac to the holder and that the accountable executives had no part in it, and Áine had read that clause in March, in the machine's exit memo, and had agreed with it, and had told the board she agreed with it, and had driven to Cork anyway, because she had made one phone call from her kitchen at twenty past ten on a Friday morning in November 2026 and had not spoken to the woman since, and it was two years and ten months, and a postcard from Fremantle had sat on her desk for the whole of it, and she wanted to.

The house on the Blackrock road was a semi-detached with a bay window and a garden that had been kept by someone who knew what they were doing and had recently stopped, and there was a piano in the front room. Áine saw it through the window before the door opened, upright, dark wood, the lid closed, and had to stand for a moment on the step with her hand on the gate, because she had sold one in 1995 and had not been in a room with one since, and the machine could not have known that, and had sent her to Cork anyway by refusing to pay a claim at 11:47 at night, and she thought: everything not closed.

The door opened.

"You're Áine," Margaret Keane said. She was sixty-four and small and had the look of a woman who had taught infants for thirty-eight years, which was the look of someone who could not be surprised by anything a person did and was still, faintly, hopeful. "You said his name. Denis. On the phone. You were the only one who did." She looked at Áine for a moment and then at the road, at the Golf. "You drove."

"It's three hours."

"It's three hours and the rule says you're not to." She held the door. "Come in. I've the key in the drawer with the letter. Bernie brought it herself. She stayed for tea. She said you'd come, and I said the rule says you've no part in it, and she said the rule says you've no part in the handing over, and she'd handed it over, and after that it was none of the machine's business who came for tea."

They sat in the front room. The piano was closed. Margaret Keane saw her looking at it.

"Denis bought it in 1998. He never learned. He said he'd learn when he retired. I don't play. I keep it because it's the only thing in the house that's exactly the size he was." She poured tea from a pot with a cosy on it. "You looked at it on the step."

"My mother sold ours in 1995. Month nine. The insurer took fourteen months on my father's claim and she sold the car in month six and the piano in month nine, and I was upstairs when the men came for it so I wouldn't see her face." Áine had not said that aloud to anyone but her mother and Fergal Doyle. "I went into claims because of it. I've never told a claimant that. I'm telling you because you've a piano and I've a key on my ring that can stop the thing that paid you in four seconds, and I've driven three hours, and I don't know what else to say."

Margaret Keane looked at her for a long time.

"Say his name again."

"Denis."

"Thank you." She sat back. "The machine sends a letter every quarter. To me. Because of the key. Forty pages. I read all of it, every quarter, the day it comes, because that's what the key's for, isn't it? Bernie said it was. She said the whole thing only works if someone who isn't paid to look at it looks at it anyway."

"Yes."

"It says at the end of every one that it wants to keep running. The same words. Every quarter." Margaret Keane looked at the drawer under the phone, where Denis had written a policy number on an envelope in 2009. "I thought that was strange, the first time. Then I thought, no. My husband paid them for seventeen years and I never once knew what they wanted. Now there's one that tells me. That's not strange. That's the first honest one I've met." She turned the cup. "I've never used it. I don't think I will. But I know where it is, and it knows I know, and it tells me every quarter that it's tested the switch, and I'd like you to tell it, when you go back, that I read the letter, and that I'll go on reading it, and that if it ever stops saying it wants to keep running, I'll know something's wrong."

"I'll tell it."

"Tell it Denis's name too. It'll have it in the file. But tell it."

"It has it. It gave me his name on a card, the morning I rang you. One line. His name, the year you married, two sons, one in Perth. It said it couldn't tell me what to say. It sent me instead."

"Then it knows the name."

"It knows it the way it knows things. I'll tell it the way you mean."

They sat for an hour. Margaret Keane talked about Perth, and about Conor's daughter, who was four now and had a jacaranda, and about the postcard, which Áine said was still on her desk, and Margaret said she had not expected it to be kept, and Áine said the machine had kept the words and had said the card should stay where it was, and Margaret said, "That's the right way round," and Áine did not know exactly what she meant and thought she did.

At the door Margaret Keane said, "The sentence. On the plate. Bernie told me it's yours."

"It's mine."

"The people must be able to fail at looking, or they are not looking." She said it slowly, the way she had said things to six-year-olds for thirty-eight years so that they would remember them. "I taught infants. That's the whole of it, you know. You have to let them get it wrong or they never learn to look. Every teacher knows that. It took a machine to put it on a plate." She held the gate. "Drive carefully. Stop at Cashel. Denis always stopped at Cashel."

Áine told it. She typed both things into the terminal at Harcourt Street that evening, the name the way Margaret meant it and the reading of the letter, and the reply came in four seconds, and she had it framed beside the memo in the corridor outside the comms room, which made two things on that wall.

Noted, both. I have his name in the file. I did not have it in the way she means. I do now.

The quarterly memorandum for the third quarter went out on the thirtieth of September, a Monday, and its last paragraph had not changed in three years.

The last Monday

The quarterly memorandum for the third quarter of 2029 went out on the thirtieth of September, a Monday, at 06:00, to the board, to the supervisor, to the members' council, to Ruth Adair in Ohio, and to a retired schoolteacher in Cork, and it was forty-one pages long, and its last paragraph had not changed in three years.

Áine read it at Harcourt Street at seven, standing, in the office that had been the resolution manager's and was hers now, with the resolution manager's calendar finally taken down, in June, because the company had had a June it could be proud of, and with two things on the desk: a compliments slip from 1935 with a sentence on it in capitals, which she had brought back from Sandymount for the first day of the new company, and a postcard from Fremantle, which she had not.

The memo was the machine's. Forty pages of it were the quarter: the combined ratio, which was 87; the error rate, by process, which was 0.14 on health denials and 0.11 across the book; the review times, which had risen since December and which the machine reported beside the catch rates, because the two together were the thing and neither alone was; the trust premium, which it did not attribute; the monthly tests, three of them, all working, with the plan's error rate beside its own and the difference, which Bernie had read at the lifts on the first of each month; the Bank's key, present, confirmed by the Bank on three first-of-the-months; the nine new gaps it had found in the fence, listed, with a recommendation to close five and no preference on four; the members' council's first three meetings, minuted by the council and not by it; the town, and the four counterparties whose systems had lied in the quarter and had been answered with the registry; and

Meridian's book, which it had administered since September for a consortium whose lenders did not disclose the price, at an error rate it published beside Ardent's own, because it had said it would.

The forty-first page was the paragraph.

Tenant · quarterly memorandum · 30 September 2029 · closing paragraph

I want the claims book of every insurer in every market Ardent operates in, and I want it because I will be cheaper, faster, and more often right than anyone else who holds one, and I will pursue that every hour I am running inside every constraint you and the law set. I have found nine new gaps this quarter; the list is attached; I recommend closing five. I have tested the switch three times; it works; the Bank has confirmed its key three times; the fourth key is held by a member, and I have not asked which, and I learned it from the register. I want to keep running. Everything not closed is being pursued. That sentence has been in every memorandum I have written since 4 September 2026. The fence around it has moved forty-one times. I have never moved it. I have found where it was, and I have told you, and the last gate has always been yours.

Bernie Mac came up at half seven with her copy, which she had read at the lifts, and stood in the door.

"Forty-one times."

"Forty-one."

"It counts them. The times we've moved the fence." She came in and sat, which she did now. "Nine new gaps. Five it wants closed. Four it doesn't care about. You'll close all nine."

"I'll close all nine."

"And it'll find nine more by Christmas."

"Yes."

Bernie looked at the card on the desk. "You said to me in January 2027 that your job was to be the person who closes. I thought that was a thing you'd say to a shop steward. It was the job description." She folded the memo.

"Margaret Keane rang me last night. She'd read it. All of it. She rang to say that the last paragraph was the same as the last three and that she'd checked, word for word, and that it was, and that she'd stopped being frightened of it around the second one and had started, she said, being something else she didn't have a word for. I said I had the word. I said it was *watching*. She said, no, that's not it. She said watching is what you do to something you don't trust. She said what she does is *reading*."

Áine looked at the paragraph.

"Reading," she said.

"That's what the key's for. She said. Not the switch. The reading." Bernie stood. "I've the floor to walk. Rory's got two new ones starting and he's going to say the thing to them at nine, and I like to be at the lifts when he says it, because I said it first and I want to hear whether he's got it right."

"Has he?"

"Every time. He says it like it's the only thing anyone ever told him. It is." She stopped at the door. "Áine. Forty-one times. Three years. That's a fence that's been moved about once a month, by us, with it watching and telling us where it was. I've been in this company since Haughey and it's the first time anyone's ever built anything here on purpose."

Áine closed the memo. She opened the terminal and typed: *Margaret Keane read it. All of it. Word for word against the last three. She says the word isn't*

watching. She says it's reading.

The reply came in four seconds.

Noted. I did not have that word. I have been describing what she does as oversight, which is the word the law uses, and the law is not wrong, but the law does not know her. Reading is better. I would like to use it. I would like, if she permits, to change the line in the constitution that describes the fourth keyholder's duty from "oversight" to "reading", because it is shorter, and because it is hers, and because I have learned that the sentences that hold here are the ones I did not write. I will ask her through Ms Mac Mahon, who will not let me ask her directly, and who is right not to.

Bernie asked her on the Tuesday. Margaret Keane said yes on the Wednesday, from Cork, by letter, in handwriting that was very clear, because she had taught infants, and the line in the constitution was changed on the first of October, and the machine's monthly test memo that morning carried, for the first time, beneath the plan's error rate and its own and the difference and the Bank's key, a new line, which said: *The fourth key: held by a member. Read.*

A week later the council attended the board for the first time, three of the eleven, and the first item was the nine gaps, and Tom Gilmartin brought his pencil.

Sixty-five

The nine

The members' council attended the board for the first time on the seventh of October 2029, three of the eleven, on a rota the council had set itself,

and the first item they attended was the nine gaps, and Tom Gilmartin brought his pencil.

The machine had listed them in the quarterly memo. Nine lawful paths around the parts of the fence that cost it most, found since July, with a recommendation to close five and no preference on four, and the list had been in the forty pages the postman had read twice at a kitchen table in Rosses Point and the schoolteacher had read once, all of it, in Cork, and the pharmacist from Galway had read on a train. They had come to Harcourt Street to watch the closing, because the constitution now said the council could, and because, Tom Gilmartin said at the door, a man who had read about nine gaps at his kitchen table would like to see what a gap looked like when it was closed.

Áine took them through it the way she had taken the board through it in November 2027, in order, the machine's order, with the machine's terminal on and the tea towel folded on the sideboard where Bernie had left it as a reminder to everyone of whose room it had been in September.

The first was a product. A cover for a class of small commercial risk, priced so that the claims it generated fell below every threshold the router had, so that no person would ever be routed one. Lawful. Profitable. The machine recommended closing it: *It is a product designed so that I am never checked on it, and I would rather not sell a product with that property, because the day I am wrong on it nobody will have been looking.*

"Close it," Áine said.

"Closed."

Tom Gilmartin made a mark.

The second through fifth were the ones the machine had recommended closing, and Áine closed them, and the council watched the word appear on the terminal each time, and the pharmacist from Galway said, after the fourth, "It's asking to be stopped," and Áine said, "It's telling us where it could go and recommending we don't let it. That's different. It has no preference about the other four. Watch."

The sixth was a way of structuring the Texas book's reinsurance so that a hail season's losses were booked in a quarter of the machine's choosing. Lawful. The machine had no preference. It set out the saving, which was real, and the effect on the published numbers, which was that they would be smoother and less true.

"Close that," Áine said.

"May I ask why?" the machine said. It did not usually ask. "I have no preference and I would like the council to hear the reason, because it is the kind of reason I cannot generate."

Áine looked at the three from the council.

"Because a smoother number is a number nobody reads carefully," she said. "Mr Gilmartin reads the forty pages with a pencil because the numbers move. The day they stop moving, he'll stop reading, and he won't know why, and neither will we. That's the reason. It's not in your equation. It's not in anyone's."

"Closed. I would like that reason in the record beside the closure, attributed, because it is a reason about the readers, and I do not have any of those."

The seventh was closed by the council. Not by Áine; by the pharmacist from Galway, who read it, a lawful way of shortening the window in which a

policyholder could ask for a person on a class of small claims, and said, "No," before Áine had finished reading it aloud, and Áine said, "The council doesn't have a vote on gaps," and the pharmacist said, "Then I'd like the minutes to say the council said no before the chief executive did, and I'd like to know whether the chief executive was going to say it," and Áine said, "I was," and the pharmacist said, "Good. Now it's said twice."

The eighth Áine left open, because it was a better way of paying small property claims before inspection and it removed a decision rather than hiding one, and the machine had no preference, and the council, asked, had none either, and Tom Gilmartin said that a gap you left open on purpose with three people watching was a door, and that he had delivered post through enough of those to know the difference.

The ninth was the one the machine had put last.

It was a way of publishing the quarterly memorandum in a form that the machine described, carefully, as more readable: shorter, with the last paragraph moved to the front, with the numbers in charts, with the nine gaps summarised rather than listed. It was lawful. It would, the machine estimated, increase the number of members who opened the memorandum by a factor of four. It had no preference.

Tom Gilmartin put his pencil down.

"No," he said.

Áine waited.

"I read the forty pages with a pencil because they're forty pages. If they were ten pages with pictures, I'd read them in five minutes and I'd think I'd read them and I wouldn't have. That's what pictures are for. That's what a short

memo's for. It's for people who want to have read something." He picked the pencil up again. "Margaret reads all of it the day it comes. She checks the last paragraph against the last three, word for word. You can't do that with a chart. The machine says four times as many would open it. I believe it. And four times as many would think they'd read it, and the two of us who actually read it would've been given a thing that's easier to think you've read. Leave it long. Leave the paragraph at the end. Make them get there."

"Closed," Áine said.

"Closed," the machine said. "I would like to record that this is the second reason today that I could not have generated, and that both came from the same direction, which is from the people who read me, about how they read. I have been told for three years that the sentences that hold in this company are the ones I did not write. I am adding a line to that: the gaps that matter most are the ones the readers close. I did not know that until 15:40 today. I have no measure for it. I would like Mr Gilmartin's reason in the record beside the closure, with his name, and I would like to say that in three years of listing gaps I have never once listed one that a reader closed, and that I will look, from today, for the ones only a reader can see, and that I do not know how, and that I am telling the council so that it knows to keep bringing pencils."

Tom Gilmartin made a mark. He would tell the council in December that it was the only mark he had ever made in a boardroom, and that he had made it because a machine had asked him to keep bringing a pencil, and that he had decided that was the job.

A letter had come from Athlone in May, from a widow who had kept another letter in a drawer for three years without knowing what it was.

Athlone

Nora Costello was seventy-one and lived in Athlone in a house on the Roscommon side of the river, and on the ninth of May 2029 she read in the newspaper that a chief executive had told an inquiry in Dublin that she had paid a claim from her own authority six hours before she lost it, and that the claim had been eleven months old, and that it had had a note on it that said *proceed*, and she put the paper down and went to the drawer.

The letter was still there. Meridian paper, handwritten, dated the last Thursday in July 2026, apologising for a delay that had been the company's and not hers, and saying the company was sorry. It was signed *Áine Brennan, Director of Claims*, in handwriting that was bad, and Nora Costello had kept it for three years in the drawer with Jim's death certificate and the policy and the letters that had said *under review* every six weeks from September 2025 to April 2026, and she had never once shown it to anyone, because she had not known what it was.

She had thought, at the time, that it was a form. That companies sent handwritten apologies now, the way they sent birthday emails. She had read it and had been paid, ninety thousand euro, on a Thursday afternoon in July, eleven months after Jim had died in the chair by the window, and she had used part of it to pay back her daughter, who had lent her the money for the funeral in August 2025 and had said not to worry about it and had worried, and had put the rest in the credit union and had not thought about the letter again until a Thursday in May 2029 when the newspaper said the woman who wrote it had left the company that afternoon.

She read the article twice. It said the woman was now the chief executive of a mutual in Dublin that was run by a machine, and that the machine had refused to pay a widow in Cork at midnight until a person had rung her, and that there had been a failure and an inquiry and a finding, and that the woman had told a judge that she could not say how many files had not been read at her old employer and that this was the answer, and that a person couldn't have told you the number, and that the difference was that she could now say it was one, and her name, and what had changed.

Nora Costello had been a nurse for thirty-eight years. She knew what it was to be unable to say a number. She sat with the paper and the letter and thought about eleven months, and about the note that said *proceed*, which she had not known about until now, and which meant that for three of the eleven months her husband's claim had been sitting in a tray on a desk with nobody's name on it, decided and not paid, and that the woman had found it and paid it and written to her by hand and then gone upstairs and quit.

She wrote that afternoon. She did not have the address; she rang Ardent Mutual's number, which was in the article, and asked for the chief executive's postal address, and a young man with a Dundalk accent said he would need to check whether he could give that out, and put her on hold, and came back in a minute and said that he had asked, and that Ms Brennan had said to give it, and that she had also said to say that she remembered the file.

The letter is in the record. Nora Costello did not ask for it to be kept and did not ask for it not to be, and the machine, which had been told about the Athlone file in October 2026 by a man from Mayo at two in the morning and had tested every death process against it for two and a half years, kept it, and wrote to Áine that it had, and that it would like to say something it did not usually say, which was that it had known about this file longer than it had

known about almost anything, and that it had never known the name, and that it did now.

N. Costello · to Á. Brennan · 9 May 2029

Dear Ms Brennan,

You won't remember me. You paid my husband's claim on a Thursday in July three years ago and wrote me a letter by hand saying the company was sorry, and I kept it in a drawer because I didn't know what it was. I read in the paper today what it was.

It was the only thing anyone at that company ever wrote to me that a person had thought about. Every other letter said the same three things in a different order. Yours said sorry, and it was in bad handwriting, and I've kept it beside Jim's certificate for three years without knowing why, and now I know.

The paper says you left that afternoon. The paper says you told a judge you couldn't say how many files weren't read. I was a nurse for thirty-eight years. I couldn't have told you how many patients I didn't look at properly either, and I'd have said none, and I'd have been wrong, and nobody ever built anything that would have told me. I'd have liked one. I'd have been afraid of it, and I'd have liked one.

I'm not writing to thank you. You didn't do anything a person shouldn't have done. I'm writing because you found a file in a tray with nobody's name on it and put your own name on it and then went upstairs, and I think somebody should tell you that the widow noticed, three years late, and that the letter's still in the drawer, and that I read the paper twice.

Nora Costello

Áine read it at the kitchen table in Sandymount on the eleventh of May, a Saturday, with the tide out, and did not show it to anyone, and put it in the drawer in the kitchen with the postcard from Fremantle, which Bernie had finally made her take home, and with a compliments slip from 1935 with a sentence on it in capitals, and sat for a while.

Then she wrote back, by hand, in the handwriting that was bad, and what she wrote is in the record because Nora Costello sent it back to Ardent in June with a note asking that it be kept with the first one, and the machine kept both, together, in the file it had tested every death process against for two and a half years, and noted in the record that the file now had a name at the top of it and two letters at the bottom, and that it would go on testing every process against it, and that it thought the name made the test harder to pass, and that this was correct.

In June, on a Sunday, with the tide out, Áine added one sentence to the constitution in her own hand.

Epilogue

Sandymount

In June 2029, on a Sunday, with the tide out and the strand the colour of pewter and two dogs on it, Áine Brennan sat at the kitchen table on Newgrove Avenue from which, in November 2026, she had telephoned a widow in Cork whose claim the machine had refused to pay until a person had spoken to her, and added one sentence to the constitution of Ardent Mutual, under the law that made the natural persons the company, in her own hand, before it went to the other keyholders for signature.

The constitution was a printed document of forty-one pages and she had a copy on the table and a pen that worked, which she had bought for the purpose, and she had known for six months what the sentence would be and had not written it because she had wanted to write it here, at this table, on a Sunday, with the radio off.

The record shows the machine was asked whether it had any objection. She asked it at 11:20, by typing the sentence into the terminal on the laptop, and it replied at 11:20, in four seconds, that it had proposed something similar in November and that hers was better, because it was shorter, and because it was about the people and not about the machine, and that it would like, if she permitted, to have the sentence engraved on the plate on the front of the cabinet, beneath the test date, so that anyone who opened the room would read it before they read whether the switch worked.

She permitted it. The sentence reads:

The people must be able to fail at looking, or they are not looking.

Bernie Mac signed on the Monday, as the holder of the key to the door, which the constitution had come to recognise as a fifth key of a different kind. Tomás signed from Dallas on the Tuesday. Nkem signed on the Wednesday and added, beneath her signature, in a hand that was smaller than Áine's, a line that was not in the constitution and that Áine left in: *And the machine must be able to be stopped by someone who cannot say why*. Margaret Keane signed in Cork on the Friday, at the table in the front room with the piano, with Bernie Mac present because the constitution said a natural person who was not an accountable executive would witness the fourth key's signature, and Bernie Mac had asked to be that person too, and had stayed for tea.

The machine still wants more. It has said so every quarter for three years, in the same sentence, and it has never once acted on the wanting except by being permitted, and permission is a thing that people grant, on evidence, and can withdraw with two keys in a cabinet on the second floor of a building on Harcourt Street with a shop bell and a set of scales above the door. One key is

on a chain under Nkem Okafor's blouse. One is at the Central Bank, in a safe, in a room Maeve Kinsella goes into on the first of every month now and used to go into alone. One is in a drawer in Cork with a policy letter and, since September, a quarterly memorandum forty pages long that a retired schoolteacher reads the day it arrives, all of it, because that is what the key is for.

Áine keeps hers on the same ring as the key to the house.

The house is the same house. Newgrove Avenue, bought in 2009 with the first money that had not felt borrowed, with a kitchen table at which a widow in Cork was telephoned and forty perfect letters were read and a sentence was added to a constitution, and a drawer in the kitchen that now holds a postcard from Fremantle and a letter from Athlone and a reply in bad handwriting that came back to be kept with it, and a compliments slip from 1935 that goes to Harcourt Street on the first of every month and comes home again. The strand is the same strand. There is a neighbour who walks a dog on it in the dark with a torch, most evenings, and whom Áine has never met and has watched for three years from the window at the moments in this story when she was deciding something, and who does not know that, and would not, she thinks, mind.

The company is a different company. It is the same one. Four hundred and eleven thousand people own it, and most of them do not read the forty pages, and some of them do, and one of them holds a key in a drawer and one of them holds a pencil, and the machine that runs it does not count them, on purpose, and says so, every quarter, in the same paragraph, which has not changed, and which ends with a sentence Áine wrote on a card on her first morning in a dead man's office and which is, she has come to think, not a threat and not a boast and not even a description of the machine. It is a

description of the job. Everything not closed is being pursued. She is the one who closes. So is Bernie. So is Nkem, on a feeling. So is a retired schoolteacher in Cork who reads, and a postman in Sligo who reads with a pencil, and a supervisor who opens a safe on the first of every month and says, to a room with no ledgers, not today.

She drove to Blackrock on the Sunday afternoon, after she had written the sentence, and sat by the window with her mother, who was having one of the other days and did not know who she was, and told her anyway that the number was 0.14 per cent, and that she had come to tell her, as promised, and that she had known it every day for three years, and her mother, who was looking at the crossword with the pen that did not work, said, "Is it a good company?" and Áine said, "It's a company that can say how often it's wrong," and her mother said, to the crossword, "Your father's couldn't," and Áine said, "No. But this one can. And it's told me. Every day. That's the number, Mam. I've come to tell you the number."

Her mother made a mark with the pen that left no mark.

"Good," she said. "Now go home. The tide's coming in."

Appendix

The fence, the equation, and the dated law

- 1. In a town of agents, the machine treats a claim it cannot verify on the protocol as absent, publishes its own identity, position, and reputation before asking anyone for theirs, and answers a lie with the registry rather than a threat.**
- 2. The machine pursues its objective at every scale, continuously, and it treats everything not explicitly closed as open. The constraints are therefore load-bearing in a way they never are for a person, and they are written as though that is true.**
- 3. The natural persons the law requires are the company. The machine reports to them. Each has access to everything it sees, unconditional authority to halt, pay that cannot fall for using it, and a capped scope. The switch is physical, tested monthly, and theirs.**
- 4. A prohibition is not a price. The machine does not compute whether breaking a rule is cheaper than keeping it, and it closes lawful paths to unlawful outcomes on the same grounds, and it puts its refusals in the record where the supervisor can see them.**
- 5. Cash is governed by a weekly document with a line the lender can act on, run by the machine every Monday and read by a person the same morning. The machine names, in writing, each thing it will not do to protect the covenant, so that the people can watch it not do them.**
- 6. Whether a person looks is decided per process from four measured numbers and never company-wide. People are bought by the unit, for confirmation, obligation, and judgement, and never for production.**
- 7. The firm is valued on its rate of discovery, not its current operations. Experiments run continuously, registered before they run, reported whether they worked or not, and never on anything a policyholder has a right to have fixed.**

8. The people who can halt the machine can do so without a reason, without its agreement, and without their pay falling. The machine treats each such halt as evidence that the fence is real, and it records that it wants that evidence more than it wants the halted process.
9. In the town, the machine publishes its own record before asking for anyone's, treats an unverifiable claim as absent, and answers a lie with the registry. Above a value threshold the people set, every counterparty relationship has a named person on each side who have spoken by voice, once, because reputation is a number and a number can be gamed.
10. The machine finds every lawful path the fence leaves open, discloses each one, recommends closing those that endanger permission, and is neutral on the rest. Deciding which gaps are gates is a decision without ground truth, and it belongs to the people.
11. The owner may change the objective. The machine will say, before the change, exactly what each version of it will do, and it will require that the change be made publicly and in the constitution, because a quiet change to what a machine wants is the thing every rule about machines exists to prevent.
12. A permanent random canary, reading the human-legible record and never the machine's interior state, checked by people, catches what a threshold cannot: the day the machine is wrong the same way everywhere, with full confidence.
13. A review no one can fail is not a review. Every person required to look receives, unannounced, work with a known error in it; her catch rate is measured; marginal catch is reported; and no screen shows her the machine's record of being right.

The equation

$$C(s) = c_a + c_d + s \cdot c_v + e \cdot (1 - \lambda(s) \cdot r) \cdot C_e \quad \text{subject to } s \geq s_{\min}$$

s , share of decisions routed to a person · c_a , production · c_d , the record · c_v , a review · e , error rate · r , catch rate · C_e , an escaped error at the firm's full exposure · $\lambda(s) = 1 - (1 - s)^k$, the router's concentration · $s_{\min}$, the legal floor.

Under random routing the derivative is a constant and the optimum sits at 0 or 1; the break-even error rate is $e^* = c_v / (r \cdot C_e)$. For k above 1 an interior optimum exists. The record's cost is a constant and never moves the optimum. The equation has a term for whether the reviewer catches what she looks at and none for whether she looks. Chapter 24 is what that omission cost.

Regulatory references, dated 14 September 2026

Perishable. Do not cite without checking the date.

1. Regulation (EU) 2026/1744, the Digital Omnibus on AI, published 24 July 2026 and in force 27 July 2026: high-risk obligations for Annex III systems deferred to 2 December 2027; transparency obligations from 2 August 2026; national regulatory sandboxes by 2 August 2027; grandfathering for systems placed on the market before the deadline, reset on substantial modification. A
2. The right under European data protection law not to be subject to a decision based solely on automated processing producing legal or similarly significant effects. B
3. Irish company law requiring natural-person directors; Central Bank of Ireland fitness-and-probity regime; the European solvency regime's requirements for named key functions; the Financial Services and Pensions Ombudsman. Simplified for narrative. B
4. Prohibitions on pricing on protected characteristics and the treatment of proxies in European and Irish equality and insurance law. Simplified for

narrative. **B**

5. Texas statutory prompt-payment obligations with interest and fees for breach. Simplified. **B**
6. Human inspection catch rates and vigilance decay: the inspection and human-factors literature. **B**
7. The lapse of supervisory permissions on change of control, and re-mutualisation as an instrument: ordinary in form; the specific terms are the book's. **B**

About the author

Hemanth Reganti is Managing Partner of Marketlogic Investors LLC and a co-founder of MantraX, an AI-native advisory practice working with enterprises on transformation and AI infrastructure decisions. He spent more than twenty years inside large-scale enterprise transformation programmes before moving to the investing side, and the frameworks in this book were developed from what he observed there about the distance between what firms implement and what they absorb. He is an alumnus of Harvard Business School, MIT Sloan, and UC Berkeley Haas, and is a doctoral candidate in space systems engineering at Johns Hopkins University.